

NEON RELIC

CORE OPERATIONS MANUAL

The Verdant Covenant - Field Agent Edition



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"What is found must be known. What is known must be contained. What is contained must be guarded."

— The Oath of the Verdant Covenant

Project Neon Relic
Core Rules — First Edition

Version 2.3.5

Written by Bruce Moser and Stu [Last Name TBD]

Playtesters: Chris [Last Name TBD], Eric [Last Name TBD], Paul [Last Name TBD]

Layout and Design: [TBD]

Cover Art: [TBD]

Interior Art: [TBD]

Editing: [TBD]

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PART I — INTRODUCTION

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CHAPTER 1. INTRODUCTION

Project Neon Relic is a tabletop roleplaying game of occult investigation, psychological horror, and artifact recovery set in an alternate 1980s. Players are agents of a secret society called The Verdant Covenant, tasked with discovering, retrieving, and containing supernatural artifacts before they destroy the world — or the people who find them. Along the way, agents may encounter supernatural entities — ghosts, animated objects, corrupted humans, and worse — spawned or sustained by these artifacts.

The game uses the Year Zero Engine (YZE) dice-pool variant — the same framework behind *Vaesen*, *Mutant: Year Zero*, *Forbidden Lands*, and the *Alien RPG*. If you have played any of those, the core dice mechanics will feel familiar. What makes Neon Relic different is its Corruption system: a steadily rising psychological damage track with no safe reset, turning every pushed roll and every artifact activation into a calculated gamble against your own sanity.

Neon Relic's default protagonists are competent but vulnerable containment specialists. They are trained, resourced, and trusted enough to enter dangerous situations on the Covenant's behalf, but they are never powerful enough to dominate those situations safely. The intended fantasy is solve and survive under pressure — not superheroic paranormal mastery.

1.1. What This Game Is

- **Episodic investigation.** Each session follows a structured Case File — a "artifact-of-the-week" mystery driven by artifact recovery, faction interference, and occult threats.
- **Base management between missions.** The team maintains a Headquarters — a Covenant facility they upgrade, staff, and defend over the course of a campaign.
- **Psychological attrition.** The real threat is not the monsters. It is the toll the work takes on the agents. Corruption accumulates from pushing rolls, using supernatural abilities, and confronting the unnatural. It does not go away easily. Characters who cross the threshold are permanently retired.
- **Analog procedural thriller.** No internet. No GPS. No cell phones. Investigations require physical legwork, face-to-face conversations, and fragile 1980s technology that degrades under use.
- **Professional tradecraft under cost.** Agents have real tools, protocols, and institutional support, but those tools create access, leverage, and temporary control — not effortless victories.

1.2. What This Game Is Not

- **Not a step-dice system.** Neon Relic uses d6 dice pools, not the step-dice variant from *Twilight: 2000* or *Blade Runner RPG*.
- **Not high fantasy or superhero action.** Powers are rare, dangerous, and always come at a cost.
- **Not a dungeon crawl.** There are no experience points for killing monsters. Advancement

comes from completing missions and surviving trauma.

- Not a game where Division gear or Talents replace investigation. The Covenant equips you to enter the problem, not to bypass it.

1.3. The 1980s Setting

The world of Project Neon Relic is an amalgamation of neon-noir aesthetics and deep historical conspiracies. It is an alternative reality where the geopolitical tension of the Cold War is not merely fought with the threat of nuclear deterrence, but through the covert weaponization of ancient, mythological artifacts.

The Analog Aesthetic

The technological environment is characterized by analog limitations, forcing a distinct style of investigative gameplay. The absence of smartphones, GPS, and ubiquitous high-speed internet forces players into physical legwork and face-to-face interactions:

- Communication relies on vulnerable payphones, easily intercepted HAM radios, and analog cassette answering machines.
- Information is not Googled; it is painstakingly recovered from microfiche spools, physical library archives, and fragile floppy disks.
- Surveillance uses bulky camcorders, grainy polaroid cameras, and temperamental infrared equipment.

The juxtaposition of high-tech, neon-lit urban sprawl against the ancient, rotting, cosmic horror of the artifacts creates a stark, atmospheric dichotomy. Audio aesthetics play a major role — underground clubs pulse with aggressive synthwave beats, while secretive government laboratories hum with the low, oppressive frequencies of massive server mainframes.

The tactile, error-prone nature of 1980s technology maps naturally to the engine's attrition mechanics. Batteries die at the worst moment. Magnetic tapes corrupt. CRT screens flicker and distort in the presence of the anomalous.

1.4. The Verdant Covenant

For as long as civilizations have risen and fallen, the world has produced objects of unusual power and importance — relics of faith, symbols of kingdoms, forbidden texts, cursed idols, lost maps, sacred bones, and artifacts whose origins are long forgotten. Some inspire devotion. Some bring prosperity. Some bring ruin. Throughout history, wars have been fought over such objects. Empires have risen seeking them, and entire cultures have been erased because of them. To prevent the past from destroying the present, a quiet order was formed centuries ago.

The Verdant Covenant.

The Verdant Covenant is a secret society devoted to the discovery, recovery, and protection of artifacts of magical, religious, occult, and cultural significance. Its members hold a singular, unwavering belief: that the greatest dangers in history have never been armies or kings, but the objects left behind in their wake — relics imbued with power beyond understanding.

The Covenant does not seek these artifacts for wealth, glory, or dominion. Its purpose is stewardship alone. To study them. To preserve them. And above all, to ensure they are never wielded by those who would bring ruin upon the world.

No single account agrees on the true origin of the Verdant Covenant, but most surviving records speak of a time when a catastrophe erased an entire civilization — its cities silenced and its history fractured. At the center of these accounts is reference to a great green dragon, said to have witnessed the destruction and come to a grim understanding: that certain relics were not treasures, but instruments of ruin. The dragon began gathering such objects, cataloging and hiding them away from those who would misuse them. To some, it was a tyrant hoarding power. To others, a silent guardian preserving what remained of the world.

What followed is told only in fragments. The dragon was slain — whether by fearful kings, desperate scholars, or its own design is unknown. From its remains came the first tools of the Covenant: codices, satchels, and bracers fashioned from its hide, said to carry a trace of its purpose. Those who inherited its hoard became the first members of the Verdant Covenant, continuing its work of discovery, containment, and protection. And though the truth has long since blurred into legend, some within the order quietly wonder whether the dragon's will was ever truly extinguished — or merely divided and carried forward in the hands of those who came after.

The Square of Harmony (The Rule of 441)

The organization strictly maintains exactly 441 active members worldwide at all times — not a single operative more or less. This figure is derived from the "Square of Harmony," a principle rooted in the sacred geometry of Reversible Multiplicative Symmetry. Covenant occultists recognize that $441 = 21^2$, symbolizing the gross material plane; while its exact numerical reversal, 144, represents the enlightened, inverse stewardship of the anomalous.

The Covenant believes this numerical balance acts as a metaphysical anchor, keeping the organization from becoming corrupted by the volatile artifacts it hoards. Because of this rigid cap, the initiation of a new member invariably means a previous member has died or fallen to permanent Catatonia — ensuring the cycle of stewardship continues unbroken.

Organizational Structure

Within the Covenant there are three Divisions, each responsible for a different stage of the artifact lifecycle:

Division	Motto Segment	Purpose
The Wayfinder Division	"What is found must be known."	Scholars and researchers who uncover the existence and locations of lost artifacts.
The Recovery Division	"What is known must be contained."	Field agents who retrieve relics from ruins, vaults, corporations, and those who would misuse them.
The Keep	"What is contained must be guarded."	Wardens and archivists who guard the Covenant's vaults and ensure dangerous artifacts remain contained.



Note on Stack: The Keep's Department of Logistics — informally known as "Stack" — has a strong field identity, but it is still part of The Keep, not a fourth playable Division. See [Stack \(Logistics\)](#) for details.

Quick Response Teams

Under standard operations, the Covenant's three Divisions work sequentially: Wayfinders locate, Recovery retrieves, the Keep contains. This process is methodical, documented, and safe — when time permits.

When an artifact surfaces under hostile conditions — rival factions converging, civilian exposure escalating, or containment failures cascading beyond a single Division's capability — the Covenant activates a Quick Response Team. QRTs are ad-hoc field units assembled from available agents across all three Divisions, deployed to handle situations that require the full locate-retrieve-contain cycle in compressed, dangerous timeframes.

Your agents are a QRT. You were not hand-picked for compatibility. You were available, qualified, and willing — or at least, you didn't refuse fast enough. The Wayfinder on your team knows how to find the artifact and what it does. The Recovery operative knows how to get it out. The Keep agent knows how to make sure it stays contained. None of you can do the others' jobs, and all of you are expendable enough to be sent together rather than in sequence.

QRT activation is uncommon. Most Covenant operations proceed through normal divisional channels. The cases your team receives are the ones that can't wait — situations too volatile for the standard process, too dangerous for a single Division, or too politically sensitive to risk sequential handoffs that might leak information. This is why the Operations Board counts down. This is why rival factions are already moving when you arrive. You were sent because the situation has already escalated beyond routine.

QRT members retain their Division authority, equipment, and clearance. There is no formal QRT command structure — teams establish their own field leadership, which may shift between members depending on the phase of the operation. A Wayfinder might lead during investigation, a Recovery agent during extraction, a Keep specialist during containment. Flexibility is the point.

QRT Deployment and Standing

The quality of QRT assignments reflects the team's Covenant Standing:

Standing	Assignment Quality
0-4	You receive cases other teams passed on — cold leads, hostile territories, inadequate intel. The Covenant is testing whether your team can function.
5-9	Standard QRT assignments with reasonable intelligence packages and logistics support.
10-14	Priority cases with advance Wayfinder research, pre-positioned equipment, and Keep consultation on containment profiles.
15+	The team may request specific assignments. The Covenant treats your team as a proven asset and provides accordingly.

1.5. How to Use This Book

This rulebook is organized into six parts:

- **Part I: Introduction** — You are here. The game's premise, setting, and the Verdant Covenant.
- **Part II: Character Creation** — Build your agent step by step.
- **Part III: Core Mechanics** — The dice, attributes, combat, social conflict, health, and the Corruption system.
- **Part IV: The World of Neon Relic** — Divisions, equipment, artifacts, headquarters, and advancement.
- **Part V: The Director** — DA-facing tools: Case Files, factions, bestiary, travel, and guidance.
- **Part VI: Glossary** — Quick reference for all game terms.

If you are a player, start with Character Creation and Core Mechanics. If you are the DA (the Director), read everything — but especially the Director section and the Corruption chapter.

1.6. How Play Works

A typical Neon Relic session follows a structured rhythm: the team spends shifts investigating locations, interviewing NPCs, and gathering information while external pressure mounts on the Operations Board. Understanding shifts, shift actions, and Covenant packets is essential for every player — not just the DA.

Shifts

Each in-game day is divided into four shifts:

Shift	Approximate Time
Morning	6:00 AM – 12:00 PM
Day	12:00 PM – 6:00 PM
Evening	6:00 PM – 12:00 AM
Night	12:00 AM – 6:00 AM

During each shift, the team undertakes one primary action as a group. The DA advances the Operations Board by one square after each shift, regardless of what the team does. Time is always running.

Shift Actions

The team chooses one action per shift:

Action	What It Does
Scene	Go to a Location, interact with NPCs, gather information, or attempt an objective. This is the core investigative action.
Travel	Move between cities or distant locations. Short urban travel is free; long-distance travel costs a full shift.
Surveillance	Stake out a Location or NPC. Requires a full shift; reveals activity patterns, arrivals, or organization movements.
Research	Spend time in archives, libraries, or the Covenant's records. May reveal historical context, artifact precedent, or NPC backgrounds.
Preparation	Plan an approach, acquire equipment, set up a safe house, or coordinate with Covenant contacts.
Recovery	Rest, heal, or decompress. Required for Anchor Scenes and Safe Scene recovery (see Corruption and Healing).

Covenant Packets

The team can send one packet to Covenant HQ per shift — a request for information, analysis, equipment, or authorization. Packets are not instant:

- **Minimum response time: 2 shifts.** The request goes out, HQ processes it, and the response arrives no sooner than two shifts later.

- Requests must be specific. "Tell us everything about the artifact" gets nothing. "Run the serial number on this pocket watch against Keep intake records from 1920-1930" gets results.
- HQ responses may be incomplete, delayed, or intercepted. The DA controls what comes back and when.

The packet system means the team cannot pause the investigation to wait for HQ to solve their problems. They have to keep moving with incomplete information — and when the packet arrives, it either confirms what they've already been acting on or redirects them at a cost of time already spent.

Time Pressure

A standard case runs up to fourteen days — 56 shifts total. The Operations Board tracks every shift spent. While the team investigates, rival factions advance on their own timelines. An organization that reaches its crisis milestone before containment means the case is lost on their terms.

The clock is the game's central tension. Every shift spent on recovery, travel, or a dead lead is a shift the artifact spends getting worse and rival factions spend getting closer.

For full DA-facing rules on the Operations Board, Locations, NPC Cards, Information Cards, and case construction, see [Ch 15 — The Case File](#).

CHAPTER 2. FIELD REPORT: THE HOLBROOK FREQUENCY

Covenant Case File #CF-1987-0419 — REDACTED EXTRACT

Classification: Restricted (Operational Personnel Only)

Filed by: Agent Elena Vasquez, Recovery Division

The payphone on Seventh smelled like rain and cigarettes. I fed it two quarters and dialed the dead drop number. Three rings. Click. The recording played — Covenant shorthand for "packet received, processing, minimum two shifts." Two shifts. We didn't have two shifts.

Behind me, Kowalski was sitting in the van with the engine running, pretending to read a newspaper he'd already memorized twice. The surveillance van across the street — the one with the fake plumber's logo — had been there since Tuesday. MJ-12, probably. They'd made the shop yesterday morning. Same time we did.

It was Thursday. Day 9.

The morning shift had started with Yusuf pulling the Operations Board out of his field case and laying it across the motel room's credenza. Fourteen columns, four rows each. Nine days of crossed-out squares stared back at us. The relic row was worse — the artifact had advanced twice since the church incident, and we still didn't have the third Containment Truth.

"The Compact moved overnight," Yusuf said, marking their organization row with a red pen. "O_M2. Their fixer met with the appraiser at the harbor. If they hit M3 before we contain, they'll have the watch on a boat by Sunday."

Chen was at the desk, cross-referencing the county records we'd pulled yesterday with Professor Harlan's research notes. Two Information Cards pinned to the wall: I3 — the 1923 estate sale connecting the watch to St. Anne's Parish — and I5 — Harlan's description of the activation trigger. Sustained skin contact. That explained the previous owner's death.

We needed I6. The quiescence condition. The parish priest at St. Anne's knew it — we were almost certain — but the church had been locked since the incident on Day 6, and the priest wasn't answering his phone.

"We have two options," Chen said, not looking up from the notes. "I go back to the university library and try the restricted collection. Or someone talks to the priest."

"The priest is spooked," Kowalski said from the doorway. "He saw what happened in the nave. He's not opening that door for a badge."

"He might open it for a confession."

Silence. Kowalski looked at me. I looked at the Board. Five days left. The Compact was three squares from crisis. And the relic was doing something to the neighborhood — the motel clerk had complained about the clocks running slow, and I'd noticed the light in the parking lot had a quality I didn't like. A thickness.

"I'll take the church," I said. "Chen, try the library — if Harlan left anything else in the restricted stacks, we need it. Kowalski, stay on the van. If the plumber's truck moves, I want to know."

Yusuf pulled three cards from his field case and sorted them on the table — the NPC cards for the parish priest, the appraiser, and the Compact fixer. Standard practice. Know who you're dealing with before you walk in.

I picked up my jacket. In the inside pocket, I felt the weight of the cassette tape — Los Lobos, *By the Light of the Moon*. Marco's handwriting on the label. I didn't take it out. Not yet. Not until the shift was over and we were somewhere safe and I could sit with it for five minutes without the world pressing in.

The morning shift had started. The clock was running.

I reached St. Anne's by 10:15. The church was dark, but the side door was unlocked — the priest hadn't sealed it properly after the incident. The nave smelled wrong. Cold stone and something else. Ozone, maybe, or the way the air tastes before a thunderstorm that never comes.

Father Malone was in the sacristy, sitting in the dark with his hands on the table. He didn't look surprised to see me. He looked like a man who had stopped being surprised by anything.

"You're with them," he said. Not a question.

"I'm with the people who can make it stop."

He told me what I needed. The original Latin invocation — the one the parish had used in 1923 to seal the watch after three parishioners died holding it. He recited it from memory, slowly, while I wrote it down on a Covenant field form. His hands didn't shake. His voice did.

I6. Containment Truth number three. The quiescence condition.

I was back at the motel by noon. Chen had struck out at the library — the restricted collection had been pulled by someone with federal credentials two days ago. MJ-12, again. But it didn't matter. We had what we needed.

Yusuf laid the three Containment Truth cards on the table:

- I3: Provenance — 1923 estate, St. Anne's Parish.
- I5: Trigger — sustained skin contact.
- I6: Quiescence — the Latin invocation.

"Full containment profile," he said. He was already reaching for the Warden's Bracer on his left forearm.

The evening shift would be the containment attempt. The watch was in evidence lockup at the county sheriff's office — which meant either a formal Covenant requisition through proper channels (two shifts we didn't have) or an unofficial extraction that would burn our cover with local law enforcement.

Kowalski cracked his knuckles. "I'll get the watch."

I didn't ask how. Recovery Division.

That night, in the motel parking lot, with Yusuf's Bracer dampening the emissions and Chen reading the invocation from my field notes, we sealed the watch in a lead-lined containment case. The containment held. The clocks in the motel started running at the right speed again. The thickness in the light went away.

Day 10. We'd beaten the Compact by four days. MJ-12 would find an empty evidence locker and a confused sheriff. The parish priest would sleep through the night for the first time in a week.

I sat on the motel room bed after the others had gone to their rooms. I took out the cassette tape. Marco's handwriting. I didn't play it — the Walkman's rewind button was still broken. I just held it. Five minutes of quiet. The memory of a birthday before any of this. Before the Covenant, before the artifacts, before the things I'd seen in the Tucson raid that I still can't describe without my hands shaking.

I felt it work. The tightness behind my eyes loosened. The cold static that had been building since the church receded. Not gone — never gone — but manageable. Enough to sleep. Enough to do it again tomorrow.

I put the tape back in my pocket and turned off the light.

End of extract. Full operational details available to CL 3+ personnel.

Case status: Contained. Artifact transferred to Keep Vault 7, Bay 14.



CLASSIFIED

PART II — CHARACTER CREATION

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)
Distribution: Incoming Agent Onboarding



IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

176 mm × 120 mm

CHAPTER 3. CREATING YOUR AGENT

Every player in Neon Relic portrays a sworn agent of The Verdant Covenant — a specialist with a particular expertise, a history that brought them to this work, and a threshold for the horrors they are about to witness. You are building a trained containment operative, not an occult superhero. Character creation follows these eleven steps in order.

3.1. Step 1: Choose Your Division

Your Division is your character class. It defines your role within the Covenant, your primary attribute, your starting skills, and your access to supernatural Division Talents. Your Division tells the group what kind of pressure you are trained to handle — not that you can solve scenes cleanly on your own. There are three Divisions:

Division	Role	CL	Primary Attribute
Wayfinder	Research and intelligence. You find what others don't know exists.	3	Wits
Recovery	Field retrieval. You go in and bring the artifact out.	2	Agility
The Keep	Vault security, custody, and logistics. You guard what has been won — and equip those who win it.	3	Empathy



Clearance Level (CL) vs. Covenant Standing

These two numbers measure different kinds of trust, and new agents often confuse them.

Clearance Level is an equipment authorization tier. It determines what gear your agent can requisition during the Equipping Phase — higher CL means access to more expensive or more dangerous hardware. Your starting CL is set by your Division base plus an Age Group modifier (minimum 1, maximum 5), and it is defined here in Step 3.

Covenant Standing is institutional reputation. It reflects how much the Covenant trusts your agent's judgment, and it gates information access, advanced HQ facilities, and some talent prerequisites. Standing is earned through mission success and lost through exposure or failure. It is defined in [Headquarters](#).

High CL means the Covenant will hand you a suppressed rifle. High Standing means the Covenant will tell you why you need one. Both matter, but they increase

through different actions and govern different systems.

Read the full Division descriptions in [Divisions](#) before making your choice.

3.2. Step 2: Choose Your Department or Background

Within your Division, you have a specific background:

- **Wayfinder:** Choose a Wing — Research or Counterintelligence. Within that, choose a specialty.
- **Recovery:** Choose an Operational Paradigm — Ex-Agency Operative, Heavy-Hitter, or Acquisition Specialist. Within that, choose a specialty.
- **The Keep:** Choose a Department — Catalogers, Wardens, Internal Counterintelligence, or Stack (Logistics). Within that, choose a specialty.

Your Wing, Paradigm, or Department determines which sub-unit Talent list you select from during Step 5.

3.3. Step 3: Choose Your Age Group and Distribute Attribute Points

Choose an Age Group that reflects your agent's seniority and experience. This determines your age range, attribute point pool, skill point pool (used in Step 4), and Clearance Level modifier — the longer you've served the Covenant, the higher your authorization.

Age Group	Age Range	Attribute Points	Skill Points	CL Modifier
Young	22-28	14	10	-1
Experienced	29-38	13	12	+0
Senior	39-52	12	14	+1

Younger characters are physically sharper (more attribute points); older characters are more skilled and better connected (more skill points and higher clearance). The trade-off is real and interesting — there is no "best" choice.

Distribute your Attribute Points across your four core attributes. Each attribute has a minimum score of 2 and a maximum score of 5.

Attribute	Range	Description
Strength	2-5	Physical power, endurance, and resistance to bodily harm.

Attribute	Range	Description
Agility	2-5	Reflexes, coordination, fine motor control, and speed.
Wits	2-5	Perception, memory, deductive reasoning, and technical aptitude.
Empathy	2-5	Charisma, social intuition, and resistance to psychological horror.

Division Favorite Attribute: Each Division has one Favorite Attribute — the stat at the core of your agent's identity. Plan to assign 4 or 5 points there. Wayfinder: Wits | Recovery: Agility | The Keep: Empathy. Investing there is strongly recommended but not mechanically enforced.

Attributes as Health Pools

Your four attributes serve a dual purpose: they define your dice pools and they are your health. When your agent takes damage, the relevant attribute is reduced:

- Physical damage (bullets, blunt trauma, falls) reduces Strength
- Hobbled damage (sprint, forced march, exertion) reduces Agility
- Mental horror (supernatural imagery, occult overload) reduces Wits
- Emotional trauma (witnessing atrocity, corruption of bonds) reduces Empathy

When any attribute reaches 0, your agent is Broken — incapacitated and unable to act independently. Broken does not mean dead. Full rules for damage, Broken state, and recovery in [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

3.4. Step 4: Distribute Skill Points

Distribute your Skill Points (determined by your Age Group in Step 3) across the thirteen core skills. No single skill may exceed 3 at character creation.

Skill	Attr	Starting Max	Recommended Division Priority
Force	STR	3	Recovery
Brawl	STR	3	Recovery
Endure	STR	3	Keep
Sneak	AGI	3	Recovery
Deft Hands	AGI	3	Keep (Stack)
Firearms	AGI	3	Recovery
Investigate	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Keep (Stack)

Skill	Attr	Starting Max	Recommended Division Priority
Tech	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Keep (Stack)
Lore	WIT	3	Wayfinder, Keep
Heal	WIT	3	Keep
Manipulate	EMP	3	Wayfinder
Command	EMP	3	Keep
Psychoanalyze	EMP	3	Wayfinder, Keep

Unranked skills: A skill at rating 0 means you have no formal training. You may still attempt rolls using only your Attribute Dice — there are no "untrained" restrictions.

Division Key Skill — Starting Cap Exception

Each Division has one designated Key Skill that may start at rating 4 instead of the normal cap of 3. This single exception represents professional mastery acquired before Covenant service:

- Wayfinder Key Skill: Lore
- Recovery Key Skill: Firearms
- The Keep Key Skill: Command

You may spend up to 4 of your starting skill points on your Division's Key Skill. No other skill may exceed 3 at character creation. During play, any skill may advance to a maximum of 5 via XP — the Key Skill restriction applies only at creation.

Division	Key Skill (Starting Cap: 4)
Wayfinder	Lore
Recovery	Firearms
The Keep	Command

3.5. Step 5: Choose Your Starting Talents

At creation, every agent selects three talents, one from each of the following categories:

Slot	What to Choose	Where to Find the List
Division or General Talent	One talent from your Division's talent list OR one General Talent (not both).	Division list: Divisions . General list: Advancement .
Wing / Paradigm / Department Talent	One talent from your specific sub-unit's list. Must match your Wing, Paradigm, or Department from Step 2.	Divisions — find your sub-unit section.
Background Talent	One talent from the Background Talents list. Available to every agent regardless of Division. Always passive — no activation cost.	Advancement .

Most Division Talents cost +1 Corruption to activate. One talent per list is a Healing talent, usable freely but once per session. General Talents are passive or per-session effects with no Corruption cost unless noted. Background Talents are always passive — no activation cost.

Talents and Division items are meant to create leverage: a clue path, a brief edge, a safer handling window, a cleaner extraction. They should not change the game's default expectation that agents must still investigate, improvise, and pay a price for certainty.

Talent Advancement: Additional General, Division, or Wing/Paradigm/Department talents can be purchased during play using XP. See [Advancement and Talents](#).

3.6. Step 6: Record Your Starting Statistics

Once attributes are set, note the following:

Statistic	Starting Value
Clearance Level (CL)	Division base CL + Age Group modifier (minimum 1)
Corruption	0 — you begin psychologically intact
Max Corruption Threshold	10 + Empathy score
Broken Thresholds	Any attribute reaching 0

The Corruption Threshold — and why Empathy matters

10 + **Empathy** is the absolute limit of what your agent's mind can endure. Exceeding it means permanent catatonia — the character is retired from play. It is not a target. It is a cliff edge.

A character with Empathy 2 has a threshold of 12. Empathy 4 gives a threshold of 14. That two-point difference represents entire sessions of additional safety margin in a game where Corruption accumulates through pushing rolls, talent activation, artifact handling, and surviving

supernatural encounters.

As threshold approaches, your options narrow: lower Empathy reduces social dice pools, reduces your passive resistance to emotional trauma, and leaves no buffer for emergencies. The game's Corruption economy is deliberately asymmetric — Corruption is easier to gain than to lose.

Manage your Empathy carefully at creation. See [Corruption and Healing](#) for the full economy.

Maximum Corruption Threshold is the number at which your character's mind permanently fractures, resulting in catatonia and character retirement. This is the most important number on your sheet — protect it.

3.7. Step 7: Claim Your Division Item

Every agent receives their Division's signature item at induction. This item requires no CL check and no requisition roll — record it automatically.

Division Item vs. Starting Kit: The Division Item (Step 7) is separate from and in addition to the Starting Kit (Step 8). You receive both. The Division Item is a piece of Covenant-issue hardware unique to your Division; the Starting Kit is the standard field loadout appropriate to your role. Stack agents also have a department-specific kit variant described in Step 8.

Division	Item	Granted Abilities
Wayfinder	Verdant Codex	Secures memory, assists with language and symbol work, highlights likely historical correlations, preserves documents.
Recovery	Verdant Satchel	Masks minor artifact signatures, stabilizes transport, warns of instability, keeps basic field tools ready.
Keep	Warden's Bracer	Dampens nearby emissions during handling, warns of containment failure, makes cursed objects safer to manage, absorbs 1 Corruption/session, +1 Armor Rating.

3.8. Step 8: Select Starting Gear

Each agent begins with a Division-appropriate kit. Gear beyond this standard kit requires a Clearance Level roll during the mission's Equipping Phase.

Wayfinder Starting Kit

- Verdant Codex (Division Item — automatic)
- Briefcase with research materials (notepad, pens, carbon paper)
- 35mm camera with two rolls of film
- Forged credentials (press pass, academic ID, or government contractor badge — player's choice)
- Civilian clothing (appropriate for the investigation environment)
- 1× small concealable weapon (pocket knife, derringer) (optional, CL 3 item — already authorized)

Recovery Starting Kit

- Verdant Satchel (Division Item — automatic)
- Sidearm (.38 Special revolver or 9mm semi-automatic, 12 rounds)
- Flashlight (D-cell)
- Basic field kit: 10m rope, zip ties × 6, chalk × 2, crowbar
- Field jacket with concealed holster
- One additional item from the Equipment tables (CL 2 or lower)

The Keep Starting Kit

- Warden's Bracer (Division Item — automatic)
- Containment kit: 1kg salt, copper wire (10m), chalk × 4, sealed glass canisters × 4
- Lore reference binder (photocopied Covenant texts on known artifact types)
- Formal attire or tactical jacket (player's choice based on role)
- 1× sidearm (optional — Wardens only. Wardens are pre-authorized for a CL 3 sidearm because they perform physical vault security and field escort operations. Catalogers, Internal CI, and Stack agents must requisition a sidearm normally against their standard CL.)

Stack Department Variant: Keep agents who choose the Stack department replace the Containment kit and Lore reference binder with the following:

- Personal toolkit: flathead and Phillips screwdrivers × 3, soldering iron, wire cutters, electrical tape, multimeter
- Signal jammer (prototype; 1 use before requiring repair; Gear Die d6)
- Walkie-talkies × 2 (range: ~2km, 9V battery)
- Duct tape (1 roll), WD-40
- Practical coveralls or utility vest

Stack Requisition Bonus: Stack agents gain +1 requisition die whenever acquiring crafting materials during the Equipping Phase.

3.9. Step 9: Choose Your Anchor

Every agent has an Anchor — a personal source of solace that grounds them against the psychological toll of Covenant work. An Anchor is not a physical object; it is the practice, habit, or connection where the character finds peace. It connects you to who you are outside the mission.

Choose one of the following options:

- Roll d66 on the Anchor Sources table in the Healing chapter and accept the result as written.
- Invent your own: name the source of solace and describe how the character engages with it. Run it by your DA.

Record your Anchor on your character sheet.

Mechanic: Once per session, dedicate a scene to your Anchor — a quiet moment where you actively engage with your source of solace. Heal 1d4 Corruption. Full rules in the Healing chapter.

3.10. Step 10: Name, Country of Origin, and Biography

Choose a name appropriate for your campaign's 1980s setting. Record your Country of Origin. Then write 2–3 sentences of biography: who were you before the Covenant? What incident drew their attention? What can you not bring yourself to talk about?

Country of Origin Guidance: This is primarily narrative. Use it to inform your accent, contacts, cultural references, and how local authorities read you in the field. Do not apply mandatory mechanical modifiers.

1980s Name Inspiration: Choose names authentic to your character's country of origin and cultural background. British Isles: Margaret, Colin, Siobhan, Alistair. France: Isabelle, François, Nathalie, Michel. Germany: Ursula, Dieter, Heike, Jürgen. Japan: Kenji, Noriko, Takeshi, Yuki. Use surnames that fit your cultural heritage and the era — the 1980s had specific naming fashions in every country.

3.11. Character Sheet Summary

After completing all steps, your sheet should record:

Field	Notes
Name / Country of Origin / Division / Department	Identity and role
Clearance Level	Division base CL + Age Group modifier (minimum 1)
Age Group / Age	Chosen in Step 3 (Young / Experienced / Senior)
Attributes (STR / AGI / WIT / EMP)	Attribute Points distributed per Age Group, 2–5 each
Skills (13)	Skill Points distributed per Age Group, 0–3 each
Division Talent or General Talent	One chosen from Divisions chapter or the General Talents list in Advancement
Wing, Paradigm, or Department Talent	One chosen from the sub-group talent list in Divisions
Background Talent	One chosen from the Background Talents list in Advancement
Division Item	Automatic per Division
Starting Gear	Division kit (department variant if applicable) ± optional items
Corruption	Starts at 0
Max Corruption Threshold	10 + Empathy
Anchor	Source of solace (see Healing chapter)

3.12. Worked Example: Creating Petra Vasquez

The following example demonstrates a complete character build for a Recovery agent.

Step 1–2: Division and Background

Petra Vasquez is a Recovery agent with the Ex-Agency Operative background. She is a former DEA field agent who recovered an artifact during what she thought was a routine drug raid — and has been in the Covenant’s employ ever since.

Step 3: Age Group and Attributes

Petra's six years in DEA field operations put her at age 34 — she selects Experienced (29–38), giving her 13 Attribute Points and 12 Skill Points.

Attribute	Score	Reasoning
Strength	4	Ex-agency physical conditioning
Agility	4	Trained for fast entries; Recovery Primary Attribute
Wits	3	Sharp but not an analyst
Empathy	2	Gets by on presence, not charm; lower threshold is a real risk

(13 points spent: $4 + 4 + 3 + 2 = 13$)

Max Corruption Threshold: $10 + 2 = 12$. Petra has a tighter margin than she'd like — but those attribute points went where they needed to go.

Step 4: Skills (12 points)

Skill	Rating	Reasoning
Sneak	3	Core recovery skill; DEA background
Firearms	3	Agency-trained; Recovery Key Skill
Force	2	Physical entries, breaking down doors
Brawl	2	Hand-to-hand when it comes to that
Investigate	1	Enough to read a crime scene
Endure	1	Agency conditioning

(12 points spent: $3 + 3 + 2 + 2 + 1 + 1 = 12$. Remaining 7 skills at 0.)

Step 5: Starting Talents

- **Division Talent:** Petra chooses Shadow Walker (+1 Corruption): Become entirely imperceptible to mundane guards or cameras for a scene, provided she does not attack. This

fits her infiltration background perfectly.

- **Paradigm Talent:** As an Ex-Agency Operative, Petra selects Spycraft Discipline (Healing) — once per session, after successfully completing a covert objective without being detected, heal 1 Corruption. Years of deep-cover fieldwork taught Petra that clean work is its own reward.
- **Background Talent:** Petra takes Police Officer (+1 Firearms). Her DEA field certification included extensive weapons qualifications, and that muscle memory doesn't go away.

Step 6: Starting Statistics

Statistic	Value
Clearance Level	2
Corruption	0
Max Corruption Threshold	12

Steps 7–8: Division Item and Gear

Petra records the Verdant Satchel automatically. From the Recovery Kit she takes: .38 Special revolver (12 rounds), D-cell flashlight, field kit (rope, zip ties, chalk, crowbar), and field jacket. For her additional CL 2 item she selects a police scanner.

Step 9: Anchor

Anchor: Memory / Nostalgia — a cassette tape her brother Marco made for her birthday. She keeps it in the inside pocket of her field jacket. She doesn't listen to it — the Walkman's rewind button is broken — but holding it and remembering that birthday is enough.

Step 10: Name, Country of Origin, and Biography

- **Name:** Petra Vasquez
- **Country of Origin:** United States (California)

"Former DEA Special Agent, six years in field operations before the Tucson Incident. The Covenant found her two days after the raid. She's never asked them how they knew."



CLASSIFIED

PART III — CORE MECHANICS

Classification: Unrestricted (Covenant Personnel Only)
Distribution: All Field Agents



IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

176 mm × 120 mm

CHAPTER 4. CORE RESOLUTION MECHANICS

The foundation of Project Neon Relic relies on the classic dice-pool variant of the Year Zero Engine, originally pioneered in *Mutant: Year Zero* and expanded in *Forbidden Lands* and *Alien*. While the step-dice variant utilized in *Blade Runner* and *Twilight: 2000* offers nuance, the dice-pool system is fundamentally better suited for visually representing escalating tension and resource attrition — key themes in analog horror.

4.1. Defining "Session"

Throughout this book, "once per session" means once per continuous play session at your table — typically 3 to 4 hours. If your group plays significantly shorter sessions (under 2 hours), the DA may consider once-per-session abilities to span across two or more sessions. If your group plays extended sessions (6+ hours), the DA may reset once-per-session abilities at a natural midpoint (a significant scene break, shift change, or return to HQ). The intent is that agents recover at a rate of roughly once per 3-4 hours of play, regardless of how your group structures its calendar.

4.2. The Anatomy of the Dice Pool

The core philosophy of the Year Zero Engine is that rolling dice should only occur when the narrative outcome is uncertain and the consequences of failure are dramatic.

When to roll — and when not to: Both conditions must be true simultaneously. If the outcome is not genuinely uncertain, narrate success. If failure would produce no meaningful consequence (trying again is trivially available, the stakes are negligible), skip the roll. Rolling dice when it is not necessary is the most common error new DAs make — unnecessary rolls slow the table, dilute tension, and make success feel arbitrary.

No roll needed: A trained medic (Heal 3) bandaging a minor cut in a safe room. An agent searching an already-unlocked filing cabinet at their own HQ. A character with Force 4 snapping a hollow interior door.

Roll required: A medic treating a wound during a firefight while someone is actively shooting. An agent searching a chaotic crime scene before police arrive. A character forcing a reinforced exterior door while a guard approaches. When a player character (PC) attempts a risky action, they construct a dice pool consisting of three distinct elements, which should be color-coded, or otherwise separated, for immediate visual clarity at the gaming table:

Dice Type	Color	Source	Typical Range
Attribute Dice	White	Character's innate biological capability	1-5
Skill Dice	Green	Character's trained proficiency	0-5
Gear Dice	Black	Mechanical bonus from tools/weapons	0-3

4.3. Success, Difficulty, and Extra Successes

Every standard skill roll has a Difficulty. If a rule does not list one, the default Difficulty is 1.

Each 6 rolled counts as one success.

- **Standard roll:** You succeed if your total successes meet or exceed the Difficulty.
- **Opposed roll:** Both sides roll, then compare total successes; the higher total wins. Ties are resolved in favor of the player character.
- **Special binary roll:** A few subsystems, especially Corruption Burst checks, define their own pass/fail rule instead of using Difficulty.

Successes beyond what was needed are extra successes. If the roll supports stunts, each extra success becomes 1 Stunt Point.

Stunt Points must be spent immediately. They are not saved between rolls or carried into subsequent actions. If you do not spend a Stunt Point at the moment it is generated, it is lost. Decide how to spend extra successes before the next roll at the table.

Difficulty	Use
1	Standard risky task. This is the default when no other Difficulty is listed.
2	Hard task, active resistance, or strong time pressure.
3	Severe pressure, expert resistance, or dangerous complexity.
4	Extreme task requiring unusual competence, leverage, or luck.
5+	Near-impossible task. Use only when failure pressure is central to the scene.

Total successes vs. extra successes: Unless a rule says otherwise, only successes beyond the required threshold become stunt points. If a subsystem explicitly says "each success" does something, count the total successes rolled after determining whether the roll passed.

Difficulty vs. modifiers — two different things: Difficulty (the number in the table above) is how many successes a roll requires. It does not change the size of the dice pool. When a rule says "Difficulty 2" the roller must score 2 sixes. A modifier (written as +X or -X) adds or removes dice from the pool before rolling. The two can stack: a roll may be both Difficulty 2 (needs 2 successes) and have a -1 modifier (one fewer die). Rules always specify which they mean; when in doubt, "Difficulty 2" is the shorthand for a hard but achievable task.

Extra successes can be spent on stunts — extra narrative or mechanical benefits such as:

- Completing an action significantly faster
- Uncovering secondary hidden clues during an investigation

- Assisting an ally with their next roll
- Inflicting critical, debilitating injuries during combat

The elegance of this system lies in its speed; it produces immediate, decisive results by entirely removing post-roll arithmetic or target-number calculations.

4.4. The Push Mechanic and Attrition

The primary driver of suspense and narrative tension is the Push mechanic. If an initial roll does not meet its Difficulty, or if the player desperately needs additional successes for stunts, they may choose to push the roll — picking up and re-rolling all dice that do not currently display a 6.

However, pushing represents the character exerting maximum physical, mental, or material effort, and it comes with severe risks:

- You immediately gain +1 Corruption.

Design note: Corruption is the only push cost. There is no separate "Stress" track, no optional complication table. The Corruption system handles all forms of mental and supernatural pressure through a single unified resource — see [Corruption and Healing](#) for the full rules.

What happens when you push?

When your agent pushes a roll, they aren't simply gritting their teeth and trying harder. Something deeper activates — an involuntary reflex born from proximity to the unnatural. Maybe a phrase from a containment ritual surfaces unbidden. Maybe your hands remember how an artifact felt, and that phantom sensation steadies your grip. Maybe the whispers you've been ignoring since your last case suddenly become useful, guiding your attention to exactly the right detail.

Whatever form it takes, pushing means your contaminated mind is offering you a shortcut. The help is real. The cost is real. Every push is a transaction with something you don't fully understand, and it always leaves a mark — +1 Corruption, regardless of the task. The library is not safer than the field. The thing inside you doesn't care where you are.

The analog nature of 1980s technology naturally complements this mechanical attrition. Pushing a gear-assisted roll might degrade the item — short-circuiting alkaline batteries or jamming mechanisms — effectively reducing its inherent bonus until it can be repaired during downtime.

Gear Degradation

When you roll a dice pool that includes Gear Dice, you risk damaging the item. If any Gear Die in the initial roll shows a 1, the item's Gear Bonus is permanently reduced by 1 (until repaired by Stack during downtime).

Gear Dice are never rerolled when pushing. When you push, you pick up only your Attribute and Skill Dice — Gear Dice keep their initial values. If a Gear Die already showed a 1 on the initial roll, that degradation has already occurred before the push.

An item whose Gear Bonus has been reduced to 0 is Broken — it provides no dice to rolls and cannot be used until repaired.

This rule applies identically to all gear: weapons (Gear Bonus reduced by 1), armor (Armor Rating reduced by 1), and tools. Improvised items break outright when their sole Gear Die shows a 1 — see [Improvised Item Failure](#).

Gear Degradation example: Kowalski uses his lockpick kit (+2 Gear Dice) to crack a lock. The first Gear Die shows a 1 — the kit is nicked. Gear Bonus reduced from +2 to +1. He still needs more successes, so he pushes. Gear Dice are locked at their initial values; he rerolls only his Attribute and Skill Dice. No further degradation can occur on this push — the kit already took its damage on the initial roll. If he had rolled no 1s on the Gear Dice initially, the kit would be undamaged regardless of what happens on the push.

For full repair rules, see [Crafting and Repair](#).

4.5. Opposed Rolls

When two characters are directly working against each other — a guard watching for intruders while an agent tries to slip past, a witness resisting an interrogation, two agents in a grapple — a standard roll is not sufficient. Both sides have active stakes in the outcome. Use an Opposed Roll.

Procedure

1. Both characters construct their dice pools normally (Attribute + Skill + Gear).
2. Both roll simultaneously.
3. Count the number of 6s each side rolled — these are their successes.
4. The side with more successes wins.

If the winning roll supports stunts, each success beyond the opposing total is an extra success. Opposed rolls normally do not use a listed Difficulty. If a rule combines both, the acting character must first meet the listed Difficulty and then beat the opposing total.

Tie-Breaking

Design Decision: In Neon Relic, ties are resolved in favor of the player character. If a PC is involved in an opposed roll, a tie is a player win — regardless of who initiated the action.

Rationale: The active-party rule punishes players whenever a hostile NPC takes the initiative. Corruption costs and the asymmetric difficulty of the Corruption track already provide consistent pressure. Giving NPCs tie wins would compound that pressure without interesting dramatic benefit. This aligns with Alien RPG and the general YZE design principle of player-favorable resolution.

Edge cases:

- PC vs. NPC: The PC wins, regardless of who initiated.
- NPC vs. NPC: Equal nonzero successes = no change; both zero = no change (see below).
- PC vs. PC: The DA rules in context; no mechanical default applies.

If both sides roll zero successes, the outcome is no change — the situation remains unresolved, and the DA should advance the fiction in a direction that applies pressure (the confrontation escalates, time runs out, a third party notices, etc.). The acting character does not gain Corruption from a zero-zero tie.

Common Opposed Pairings

The following pairings arise most frequently in play. Either side may push their roll as normal, gaining +1 Corruption.

Active Roll	Opposing Roll	Situation
Sneak (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Agent moves silently past a watchful guard or suspicious bystander
Manipulate (EMP)	Psychoanalyze (EMP)	Convincing a witness — the target is actively trying to spot the lie
Command (EMP)	Manipulate (EMP)	Asserting authority vs. someone talking their way out from under it
Force (STR)	Endure (STR)	Trying to physically overpower or restrain another character
Brawl (STR)	Brawl (STR)	Contested grapple, disarm, or shove
Deft Hands (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Planting or pocketing an item without being noticed
Sneak (AGI)	Investigate (WIT)	Tailing a target without being made
Tech (WIT)	Tech (WIT)	Counter-hacking: both parties on the same BBS or mainframe simultaneously

Mismatched skills are allowed. If a situation calls for it, the DA may permit any logical pairing. The table above is guidance, not a hard constraint.

4.6. Range Zones

Actions in Neon Relic use five range zones to describe spatial relationships between characters and threats. Range affects who can help, who can be targeted by attacks, and the Difficulty of many rolls.

Zone	Distance	Typical Context
Engaged	Arm's reach	Physical melee contact; grappling, close-quarters brawls
Close	Same room (~10 m)	Hallway conversations, helping a nearby ally, short-range gunfight
Near	Short dash away (~30 m)	Across a courtyard, adjacent rooms, parking-lot cover
Far	Line of sight (~100 m)	Street-level sniper positions, exterior building perimeters
Very Far	Edge of engagement (~300 m)	Long-range rifles only; most skills have no effect at this range

Helping requires Engaged or Close range. Most social rolls require at least Close. Full rules for zone-based movement, attack reach, and Difficulty modifiers are in [Combat](#).

Pushed Opposed Rolls

Either or both sides may push their roll (gaining +1 Corruption each). Pushes are declared after comparing results. The loser may push the roll and if this causes the loser to become the winner, then the new loser may push the roll. Each roll may be pushed only once. If both sides push and the result is still a tie, apply the standard tie-breaking rule outlined in Section 3.3.

4.7. Helping

Agents operating as a team can be more effective than any individual. When one agent attempts a roll and an ally is present and capable, that ally may help.

Who May Help

An ally may help if both of the following are true:

- They are present in the scene (Engaged or Close range — same room, same vehicle, actively coordinating).

- They have a rating of at least 1 in the relevant skill, or they can provide a plausible narrative justification for how their own skill set contributes (DA approval).

Helping with a non-matching skill: The DA determines whether a different skill plausibly contributes. * Lore aiding Investigate: An archivist explains a library's organizational system before the searcher begins — reducing cognitive load. DA allows Lore to help Investigate. * Tech aiding Manipulate: A hacker has pulled the target's financial records and whispers key facts to the negotiator. DA allows Tech to help Manipulate. * Force aiding Command: A soldier stands visibly armed at the negotiator's shoulder. Non-verbal intimidation. DA allows Force to help Command.

The test: does the narrative make sense? Could that skill plausibly improve the outcome? If yes, it helps. If it is a stretch, the DA declines.

The Helping Bonus

- Each helper adds +1 die to the active character's dice pool.
- A maximum of 2 helpers may assist on any single roll.
- The helping dice are Skill Dice (green) — they can produce successes but are not pushed separately.

Maximum pool size: With 2 helpers, a character's pool can be up to +2 dice above their normal maximum. This represents peak team coordination — beyond this, too many cooks.

Helping and Corruption

- If the active character pushes the roll, helpers are not penalized — they lent their dice to the initial roll, not the push.
- Helpers do not gain Corruption when the active character pushes.

Helping in Combat

Helping during combat requires a slow action from the helper. A helper who assists a slow action during a combat round cannot take any other slow action that round.

4.8. Group Rolls

Some situations call for the entire team to attempt the same action simultaneously — crossing a dark chasm, navigating a treacherous building undetected before the guards change, deciphering a large number of documents before the contact leaves.

Procedure

1. Each character rolls their individual dice pool for the relevant skill.
2. Count how many characters succeed (met the roll's Difficulty, usually 1).
3. Compare against the Group Success Threshold set by the DA:

Threshold	When to Use
All succeed	The action requires total team performance — a single failure has consequences (e.g., stealth approach; one noise ruins it for everyone)
Majority succeed	Most of the team needs to make it (e.g., climbing a fence before a gate locks)
At least one succeeds	The team needs one person to pull it off; others can assist if needed

Group Roll Failure

If the group fails to meet the threshold:

- The DA applies consequences to all who failed, not as individual failures but as a shared narrative setback.
- Individual characters who succeeded are not penalized — they did their part.
- Characters who failed may push as normal (gaining +1 Corruption each), independently.

Group rolls and pushing: Each character's push decision is independent. A character who already succeeded cannot push — there is nothing to improve. A character who failed may push (gaining +1 Corruption) and compare their new total against the same Difficulty. If the group wants to push sequentially to check whether the threshold is met before risking more Corruption, resolve pushes one character at a time in any order.

Each character manages their own Corruption independently. A group roll gone wrong — four agents all pushing, all gaining +1 Corruption — creates the kind of compounding pressure that makes the Corruption system matter.

4.9. Worked Examples

Standard Roll: Searching the Burned Office

Situation: Agent Reyes is searching a ransacked office before the local police return. The DA sets Investigate Difficulty 2.

- **Reyes rolls:** Investigate (WIT 4 + Investigate 2) = 6 dice. Rolls: 6, 6, 5, 4, 2, 1 2 successes.
- **Result:** Reyes succeeds. He finds the hidden ledger, but has no extra successes to spend.

- If Reyes had rolled 3 successes instead, the third success would become 1 Stunt Point — enough to find the ledger faster or uncover a second clue.

Opposed Roll: The Tail Job

Situation: Agent Petra Vasquez (Recovery) is tailing a suspected Compact operative through a crowded airport. The operative gets a feeling he's being watched and starts scanning the crowd.

- Petra rolls: Sneak (AGI 4 + Sneak 3) = 7 dice. Rolls: 6, 5, 3, 3, 2, 1, 1 1 success.
- Operative rolls: Investigate (WIT 3 + Investigate 2) = 5 dice. Rolls: 4, 4, 3, 2, 1 0 successes.
- Result: Petra wins — she stays undetected and follows him to his contact.

If Petra had rolled 0 successes and the operative also rolled 0, the tail continues but something shifts — maybe Petra loses him in the crowd, or the operative ducks into a bathroom and the DA advances the clock.

Opposed Roll with Push: The Interrogation

Situation: Wayfinder Agent Reyes is trying to lie to a frightened historian who knows where the artifact is. The historian is already Guarded, so the DA sets Manipulate Difficulty 2 and also calls for an opposed Psychoanalyze roll because the historian is actively trying to spot the lie.

- Reyes rolls: Manipulate (EMP 4 + Manipulate 2) = 6 dice. Rolls: 5, 4, 4, 3, 2, 1 0 successes.
- Reyes decides to push (gains +1 Corruption, now at 1). Re-rolls all 5 non-6 dice: 6, 6, 3, 2, 1 2 successes.
- Historian rolls: Psychoanalyze (EMP 3 + Psychoanalyze 1) = 4 dice. Rolls: 6, 4, 3, 2 1 success.
- Result: Reyes meets the Difficulty and wins the opposed roll (2 vs 1). The lie holds, and the historian cracks. There are no extra successes left for stunts because one success was needed to beat the historian and the other was needed to meet Difficulty 2.

Helping: Cracking a Locked File Cabinet

Situation: Stack agent Kowalski is picking a government-grade lock. Deft Hands 2 (AGI 3 + skill 2 = 5 dice). Keep agent Osei has Deft Hands 1 and offers to hold the flashlight steady and narrate the tumblers. DA approves.

- Osei adds +1 die. Kowalski rolls 6 dice total instead of 5.
- Result: 6, 6, 5, 3, 2, 1 2 successes. The lock opens, and the extra success means it opens fast — no time lost.

Group Roll: The Silent Entry

Situation: Four agents must all enter a research facility quietly before a guard completes his patrol. **DA sets threshold:** all succeed (failure means the guard hears movement).

- Petra (Sneak 3, AGI 4): 7 dice 6, 4, 3, 2, 1, 1, 1 1 success
- Reyes (Sneak 1, AGI 2): 3 dice 5, 4, 2 0 successes
- Osei (Sneak 0, AGI 3): 3 attribute dice 6, 3, 1 1 success
- Kowalski (Sneak 2, AGI 4): 6 dice 6, 6, 3, 2, 1, 1 2 successes

Reyes failed. Threshold not met. The DA rules the guard hears something from Reyes' direction and starts to turn. Reyes pushes (gains +1 Corruption): re-rolls 3 dice 6, 4, 2 1 success. The group just barely makes it — but Reyes is now at 1 Corruption and the tension meter has ticked up.

CHAPTER 5. ATTRIBUTES AND SKILLS

Characters are defined by four core attributes, representing their fundamental physical and mental foundations. In Project Neon Relic, these traditional YZE attributes are updated to fit the modern, investigative tone of an occult thriller:

Attribute	Description
Strength	Physical power, raw endurance, and fortitude against physical trauma.
Agility	Gross and fine motor skills, physical reflexes, balance, and precision.
Wits	Sensory perception, formal education, memory recall, and deductive reasoning.
Empathy	Raw charisma, social intuition, ability to read human behavior, and emotional resilience against psychological horror.

Attributes serve two purposes simultaneously:

1. **Dice pools.** When you roll a skill check, you add dice equal to your relevant attribute score to your skill dice. A Wits 4 agent has 4 attribute dice on every Wits-based skill roll.
2. **Health pools.** When your agent takes damage — physical, mental, or emotional — it reduces the relevant attribute. If any attribute reaches 0, your agent is Broken. See [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

This means high attributes give both better rolls and more capacity to absorb punishment. When you spend attribute dice on a push, you are not just trying harder — you are paying in physical or psychological capital.

5.1. The Thirteen Core Skills

The thirteen core skills are mapped to these four attributes, tailored to support urban exploration, analog hacking, and occult research:

Attribute	Skill	Application in the 1980s Occult Setting
Strength	Force	Breaking down sealed bunker doors, forcing open containment chambers.
	Brawl	Hand-to-hand combat with cultists, wrestling cursed objects from hostile hands.
	Endure	Resisting the physical toll of harsh environments, toxic substances, or sustained injury.

Attribute	Skill	Application in the 1980s Occult Setting
Agility	Sneak	Infiltrating corporate research facilities, bypassing analog security systems.
	Deft Hands	Picking locks, pocketing small artifacts, disarming mechanical traps.
	Firearms	Utilizing period-accurate weaponry (.38 revolvers, pump-action shotguns).
Wits	Investigate	Searching crime scenes for anomalous evidence, analyzing forensic data.
	Tech	Operating 1980s mainframes, hacking BBS networks, repairing analog equipment.
	Lore	Decoding ancient occult texts, identifying mythological creatures and artifact origins.
	Heal	Field medicine, triage, emergency stabilization, and treating physical injuries in the field or at base.
Empathy	Manipulate	Bribing informants, deceiving rivals, leveraging secrets, or extracting sensitive disclosures.
	Command	Directing panicked civilians, asserting emergency authority, and coordinating team actions under fire.
	Psychoanalyze	Reading psychological states, detecting deception through behavior, and stabilizing traumatized witnesses so they can talk.

Division Key Skill: During character creation, each Division designates one Key Skill with a starting cap of 4 instead of the standard maximum of 3. See the Character Creation chapter for details.

Skill Rating Caps

- **Character creation:** All skills max at 3 except your Division's Key Skill, which may start at 4.
- **During play:** Any skill may advance to a maximum of 5 via XP expenditure.
- **Rolling unranked skills (0):** Roll only your Attribute Dice. No "untrained" penalty applies — you simply have fewer dice.

5.2. Skill Stunts

When you roll more 6s than the minimum needed to succeed, each extra 6 is a Stunt Point. You may

spend Stunt Points to achieve effects beyond simple success.

Stunt Economy

- 1 extra 6 = 1 Stunt Point.
- You must succeed first (roll successes equal to or greater than the Difficulty), then extras are stunt points.
- Stunt Points must be spent immediately — within the same action resolution, before the result is narrated. They cannot be saved, banked, or carried between rolls.
- You may split stunt points across multiple effects if both effects are available on the same skill.
- On a pushed roll, stunt points still apply from the new result.

What "immediately" means: Once the dice stop rolling and successes are counted, you declare all stunt point expenditures at once. You cannot wait to see how the scene develops before choosing. If you forget to declare them, the moment passes — the DA narrates the bare success and moves on.

Combining stunts — example: Riku rolls Investigate (WIT) and gets 3 successes against Difficulty 1. She has 2 Stunt Points. She spends 1 on Pattern Lock (the DA tells her the context of the evidence) and 1 on Clock It (the DA tells her when it happened). Two stunt effects from one roll — both purchased simultaneously before the DA narrates.

Cross-reference: Combat stunts — spending stunt points during an attack roll — are defined in the Combat chapter ([Combat](#)). The stunt economy is the same.

Generic Stunts (Available on Any Skill)

The following stunts may be purchased on any successful skill roll, regardless of which skill is being used. They represent clever execution rather than specialized technique.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Faster	Accomplish the action in half the expected time. No narrative explanation needed — you just find the short path.
1	Quieter	Accomplish the action without leaving a detectable trace. The DA cannot use evidence of this action as a future complication.
1	Precise	Your result is exactly as intended — no collateral effects, no ambiguity, no partial outcomes.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Aid	Your success automatically assists an ally's next related roll this scene. They gain +1 die on it.
2	Extended Effect	The outcome of your action lasts an additional scene or at least one hour longer than it otherwise would.
2	Additional Target	Your action's results apply to one additional target in the same zone (the DA determines relevance).

Skill-Specific Stunts

The following stunts are available only when rolling the listed skill. They represent specialized applications of trained technique.

Strength Skills

Force

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Controlled Break	You force open the door/lock/container without damaging the contents or triggering adjacent mechanisms. Finesse in violence.
1	Intimidating Display	Your feat of strength is visibly dramatic. One NPC present must make a Corruption Burst (Burst Rating 1) or immediately comply with your next simple demand. See Corruption Burst .
2	Clear the Room	A shove, flip, or sweep clears all loose objects from the zone simultaneously (useful for destroying a cultist's ritual setup, or just making a scene).

Brawl

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Stay Down	Target cannot stand up until the start of your next turn (they must spend a Slow Action to rise but simply cannot).
1	Weapon Strike	You've slapped or struck their weapon arm. Target suffers -1 die on all attack rolls until the end of the round.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
2	Neck Crank	Target is immediately Grappled (see Combat) without requiring a separate maneuver roll. Costs 2 Stunt Points — you spend both at once to achieve a control hold in the same action that caused the hit.

Endure

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Grind Through	You remain focused and are able to push through the physical task at hand. You may ignore one penalty on your next roll. Only one stunt point may be spent this way per success.
1	Inspire	Your visible physical resilience gives allies heart. One ally in the scene recovers 1 point of Agility.
2	Unfazed	You succeed and take no Agility damage from whatever environmental or physical threat triggered the roll (extreme cold, sleep deprivation, toxic air).

Agility Skills

Sneak

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Shadow Step	You can take one additional move action as part of the same turn/scene phase without breaking your stealth. You haven't just crept in — you've repositioned perfectly.
1	Identify Exit	As you infiltrate, you map the fastest withdrawal route. You have +2 dice on any Sneak roll to leave this location later this scene.
2	Ghost Pass	Your passage through this location leaves zero physical trace (no footprints, disturbed dust, or thermal record). You cannot be tracked from this location. This applies only to your entry and movement during this scene — it does not retroactively erase evidence from earlier in the session, and it does not cover actions you take once inside (items moved, locks broken, witnesses seen).

Deft Hands

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Undetected	The target of your pick-pocket, lift, or plant does not notice the action even after the immediate scene ends. They will assume the item was misplaced, not taken.
1	Speed Lock	You open a lock in seconds. No time resource is consumed; the DA cannot use the time you spent as a complication.
2	Perfect Plant	You plant an item on a target in a way that will implicate them credibly. Subsequent investigation will find the planted item and treat it as the target's possession.

Firearms

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Aimed Shot	The shot hits exactly the intended location (specific limb, lock, cable, tire). DA treats the result as precision even at range.
1	Suppression	Target is pinned behind cover until start of your next turn. They cannot move zones or fire back without losing their cover bonus.
2	Warning Shot	You visibly miss by design, close enough to be terrifying. The target must make a Corruption Burst (Burst Rating 2) or drop to the ground and remain there for 1 round. No ammo die roll required for this shot. See Corruption Burst .

Wits Skills

Investigate

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Pattern Lock	You not only find the evidence — you identify why it matters. The DA must tell you one piece of context about the object's history or origin.
1	Clock It	You determine precisely when an event occurred (within the hour, or narrowed to a 30-minute window). Time is often as revealing as the event.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
2	Hidden Compartment	You find something the scene intended to conceal — a room the blueprints don't show, a file folder in a false wall, a trapdoor. DA must reveal one hidden element they had established for the case, but not yet disclosed. If there are no more hidden elements in the case, the stunt points are forfeit.

Tech

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Trace	Successfully accessing a system also identifies who else accessed it recently — one account or one physical terminal is revealed.
1	Improvised Repair	The item you're repairing also gets a temporary improvement: a degraded weapon gets +1 Gear die this session; a damaged radio broadcasts on a sealed channel.
2	Ghost Session	Your access to this digital system leaves no log entry. No one can prove you were connected. This applies to digital access only (mainframe, terminal, BBS, phone system) — it does not cover physical surveillance cameras, witnesses, or analog records of your presence.

Lore

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Deep Context	Your knowledge is not just what this thing is — you know what it was used for. DA provides one historical or ritual context detail beyond what would normally be available.
1	Weakness Identified	Your lore grants you tactical information: an entity type's vulnerability, an artifact's known failure condition, a ritual's interruption point. +1 die on the next relevant roll.
2	Primary Source	You recall a specific source — a text, a case file, a person — that would contain detailed operational information about this entity or artifact. The DA must confirm the source exists and tell you how to find it. If the DA has not pre-established such a source, they invent one that is consistent with the setting and the case — it now exists and can be found.

Empathy Skills

Manipulate

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Bought Silence	The target doesn't just comply — they will not mention this conversation to anyone for at least 24 hours. The DA may extend this window if the narrative warrants it (extreme fear, deep loyalty, significant leverage). The silence expires if the target is directly threatened or compelled by a more powerful authority.
1	Read the Room	Beyond this individual, you gauge how the wider group or faction feels about the situation. The DA tells you one faction-level attitude or intention.
2	Turned Asset	On an already-successful Manipulate, the target now actively wants to help you beyond the scope of your request. They will volunteer additional information or assistance once this session.

Command

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Rally	One Broken ally in the scene immediately acts on their next turn as if they had recovered — they can take their full action once before the impairment resumes.
1	Coordinated Action	Your directive enables two allies to act at the same initiative card slot this round. Both take their normal actions — neither loses their action to assist the other. This does not grant extra actions; it simply synchronizes timing so both effects land simultaneously (useful for simultaneous entries, simultaneous attacks, or flanking maneuvers).
2	Hold the Line	All allies who can hear you gain +1 die on their next roll this round. The effect of strong leadership under pressure.

Psychoanalyze

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Pressure Point	You've identified something this person fears or desperately needs. The DA must reveal one personal vulnerability, driving motivation, or exploitable need.
1	Decompress	The person you're treating recovers 1 additional Wits or Empathy point beyond the normal healing (max to their normal maximum).
2	Full Read	You have comprehensively understood this person's psychological state. For the rest of this scene, all Psychoanalyze rolls against them gain +2 bonus dice and are treated as Difficulty 1 — you know their cues, their resistances, and their breaking points. This benefit applies to this scene only. If the same NPC appears in a future scene under different emotional circumstances, they are not pre-read.

5.3. General Talents

General Talents are not defined in this chapter. The canonical advancement rules and full General Talents catalog live in [Advancement and Talents](#).

At character creation, an agent may choose one General Talent in place of their starting Division Talent, as described in [Character Creation](#).

CHAPTER 6. COMBAT

Combat in Neon Relic is fast, brutal, and consequential. Agents of the Covenant are capable individuals — but they are not soldiers. A prolonged firefight drains attributes that also serve as their sanity and stamina. Every round of violence is a resource you cannot easily recover before the next case.

Combat rules are designed for investigation-first play: most situations should be solvable without combat, combat should resolve quickly when it happens, and the aftermath (injury, Corruption, gear degradation) should matter as much as the outcome.

6.1. Initiative

At the start of any hostile confrontation, each participant draws an Initiative Card from a standard deck of playing cards (Ace through 10, face cards removed or kept — DA preference). Higher card value acts first. Tied cards are broken by each tied participant drawing one replacement card — compare and re-resolve until the tie is broken.

Initiative Card Draw

- Each participant — PC or NPC — draws one card from a shuffled deck.
- Participants act in descending card order (10 acts before 9, etc.).
- Aces are low (value 1) — drawing an Ace means you act last.
- Cards are discarded after the round. Reshuffle and redraw at the start of each new round.

Why cards? The card draw creates genuine unpredictability without arithmetic. It also creates a sense of narrative suspense — drawing a 10 is a small victory; drawing an Ace before a firefight is quietly dreadful. In an investigation game where combat is exceptional, this ceremony matters.

Initiative Procedure Note

Initiative uses card draw only. Do not add initiative modifiers for posture, terrain, or gear. Those factors still matter through cover, surprise, action economy, and range penalties.

Talent exception: Certain Division Talents (such as the Recovery Division's Combat Reflexes) modify the card draw. These are the only source of initiative modification — they represent specialized tactical training, not equipment bonuses.

Surprise and Ambush

A surprise occurs when one side is unaware of the other at the moment combat begins.

- To attempt an ambush, the attacking side must succeed on a Sneak (AGI) roll opposed by the target's Investigate (WIT). If multiple ambushers are involved, use the Group Roll rules (the best roller leads; others help): see [Core Resolution](#).
- If the ambush succeeds: the ambushing side takes a free full round of actions before initiative cards are drawn. Each ambusher may take one Slow Action and one Fast Action during this surprise round, in any order they choose among themselves (since they are coordinating). Targets cannot use Reactive Actions (Dodge, Parry) during the surprise round.
- If the ambush fails: draw initiative normally; no advantage granted.

6.2. Action Economy

Each character's turn consists of one Slow Action and one Fast Action, plus any number of Free Actions.

Slow Actions

A slow action represents a committed, focused effort requiring your full attention.

Slow Action	Description
Attack (melee or ranged)	Roll to hit and deal damage. Core offensive action.
First Aid	Use Heal skill to restore Strength or treat a Critical Injury (requires a First Aid Kit).
Reload	Reload a firearm that has run dry. No roll required; consumes ammo.
Use an Artifact	Activate an artifact's properties. Generates Corruption per artifact tier.
Activate Division Talent	Use your Division Talent (if it requires sustained effort).
Manipulate NPC	Attempt to talk someone down, issue commands, or negotiate during combat.
Help an Ally	Add +1 die to an ally's next roll this round (must be present, skill >= 1).
Barricade / Fortify	Use Force to move heavy objects for cover or block a doorway.
Treat Broken Ally	Stabilize a Broken ally so they do not die (requires Heal roll).

Fast Actions

A fast action is a quick, reactive, or secondary effort.

Fast Action	Description
Move one zone	Move from your current zone to an adjacent zone.
Draw or holster a weapon	Ready a weapon you are carrying. Holstering allows you to pick up something else.
Take cover	Move into cover within your current zone (+2 Armor Rating bonus, see Cover rules).
Stand up	Rise from prone or from a knocked-down state.
Grab / pick up an item	Retrieve a dropped item or item at Engaged range.
Dodge	Reactive. See Reactive Actions below.
Use a quick item	Apply a stim, crack a light stick, or use a single-use item.

Free Actions

Free actions can be taken at any point during your turn, in any number.

- Speak briefly (one sentence or a shout)
- Drop a held item
- Look around / assess the situation (no roll)
- Toggle a device that is already in hand (safety off, flashlight switch)

6.3. Zones and Range

Combat space is divided into abstract zones rather than measured distances. A zone is any coherent area of space — a room, a corridor, an alley, a rooftop section. The DA defines zones when establishing a scene.

Zone Size and Movement

Moving one zone costs one Fast Action. Moving two zones (running) costs both your Fast Action and your Slow Action for the round — you forgo your attack.

Movement economy summary: 1 zone = 1 Fast Action. 2 zones = 1 Fast Action + 1 Slow Action (your whole turn). You cannot move more than 2 zones in a single turn under normal circumstances. A Talent or stunt may modify this.

Range Category	Definition
Engaged	Same zone; within arm's reach. Required for melee. Most melee weapons can only be used at Engaged range.
Near	Same or immediately adjacent zone. Close pistol range; thrown weapons; point-blank shotgun.
Short	1-2 zones. Standard pistol and shotgun range; melee not possible.
Long	3-4 zones. Rifle range; pistols at -1 die penalty.
Distant	5+ zones. Sniper range. Only applies to designated long-range weapons; everything else is out of range.

Zone-to-Grid Conversion (Optional)

Zones remain the canonical movement/range system. For VTT or tactical play, use this translation layer.

Zone Range	Squares (5 ft grid)	Meters (approx.)	Notes
Engaged	0-1 square	0-2 m	Same zone, arm's reach.
Near	1-4 squares	2-10 m	Same or adjacent zone.
Short	5-12 squares	10-30 m	Typical pistol/shotgun practical range.
Long	13-24 squares	30-60 m	Typical rifle lane.
Distant	25+ squares	60 m+	Specialized long-range fire only.

Movement translation: 1 Fast Action to move one zone is usually 4 squares (about 20 feet / 6 meters) in open terrain. In cramped or rough terrain, treat one zone as 2 squares.

Verticality: Moving one significant elevation change (one story, catwalk, roof transition) usually costs one zone even if square distance is short.

Large or open zones: Some zones (car parks, fields, warehouse floors, concert halls) are physically large. The DA sets zone extent before combat begins. A large zone may span 20-50 squares; players and the DA should confirm expected grid width before the first round. Open-zone features do not reduce zone count — only the Fast Action cost applies.

Zone Features

Every zone has optional terrain features the DA can invoke:

Feature	Mechanical Effect
Cramped (closets, crawlspaces, car interiors)	Long-armed weapons (rifles, shotguns) suffer -2 dice. All movement into/out of zone takes a Slow Action.
Rough (rubble, debris, slick floor)	Moving into this zone requires a Fast Action and an Agility roll (Difficulty 1). On failure, character is prone.
Darkness	All Investigate, Firearms, and ranged attack rolls lose half their dice (round down, minimum 1 die) unless the character has a light source. Sneak rolls gain +2 dice.
Open (parking lots, fields)	No cover available in this zone. All ranged attacks against targets here gain +1 die.
Elevated	Characters here gain +2 to their Initiative card value; ranged attacks against them suffer -1 die.

6.4. Armor

Armor Rating (AR) measures how many Gear Dice of protection a piece of armor provides. When an attack hits, roll a number of d6s equal to the armor's AR. Each 6 rolled absorbs 1 point of damage before it reaches the target's Strength.

Armor Type	AR	Notes
Light jacket / heavy clothing	1	Standard civilian outer layer. Minimal ballistic protection.
Leather jacket / reinforced coat	2	Better against blunt and blade. Poor against firearms.
Kevlar vest (standard)	3	Covenant-issue soft armor. CL 3 requisition.
Tactical plate vest	4	Hard plate inserts. Heavy — +1 Encumbrance. CL 4 requisition.
Full tactical kit (vest + plates)	5	Maximum field armor. Unwieldy in confined spaces.

How armor Gear Dice work: If you're wearing AR 3 armor and take 4 damage, roll 3d6. Each 6 absorbs 1 damage. If you roll two 6s, you take $4 - 2 = 2$ Strength damage. If you roll three 6s, you take 1 damage. If you roll zero 6s, you take all 4.

Armor degradation: When you roll an armor die and get a 1, the armor's condition degrades — reduce its AR by 1 permanently until repaired. See [Equipment](#) for repair rules. This represents sustained damage to the protective layers that a brief field inspection cannot fix.

Armor and vehicles: Vehicles have an Armor Rating that functions identically to personal armor but absorbs Wear rather than personal attribute damage. See Vehicle Combat below.

6.5. Melee Combat

Basic Melee Attack

Declare your target (must be at Engaged range). Roll your dice pool:

- Heavy melee (knife, crowbar, brawl against an armored target): Force (STR) + Weapon Gear Bonus
- Fast melee (unarmed strikes, quick knife work): Brawl (STR) + Weapon Gear Bonus

Heavy vs. Fast melee: A weapon's classification (Heavy or Fast) is listed in the Equipment tables (see [Equipment](#)). As a rule of thumb: weapons requiring two hands or significant force to wield effectively are Heavy; light, one-handed, or improvised strikes are Fast. When improvising with an unlisted object, the DA determines which skill applies based on how the agent is using it.

On a hit (meeting the attack's Difficulty, usually 1), deal the weapon's flat Damage value directly to the target's Strength. Armor intercepts first — see Armor below.

Successes beyond the attack's Difficulty are Stunt Points — see Combat Stunts below.

Unarmed Combat

Unarmed attacks use the Brawl skill. Bare hands deal 1 Damage on a hit.

For unarmed grapples, shoves, and disarms, see Special Melee Maneuvers below.

Special Melee Maneuvers

All maneuvers require a successful melee attack roll. If the attack misses (no 6s), the maneuver fails entirely.

Maneuver	Skill	Effect
Grapple	Brawl (STR) opposed by Force or Brawl (target's choice)	Target is grappled: they cannot move zones, use two-handed weapons, or take Slow Actions until they break free (costs their Slow Action, opposed Brawl/Force roll). They can still take Fast Actions (draw a one-handed weapon, attempt to break free as their Slow Action) and use Reactive Actions (Dodge counts as a Fast Action and is still permitted). Being Grappled does not prevent speaking, using a single-handed item, or making an unarmed attack against the grappler (Brawl, -2 dice, one-handed only).
Shove	Force (STR) opposed by Endure (STR)	Target is pushed back one zone and is knocked prone. If target is already at a zone edge (stairs, window, rooftop), this may be lethal.
Disarm	Deft Hands (AGI) opposed by Force or Brawl	Target drops their held weapon. It lands at Engaged range on the floor.
Feint	Brawl (STR) opposed by Wits	No damage this turn. On success: target cannot Dodge or Parry your next attack this round — the feint commits their reaction to the false opening. You gain +2 dice on your next melee roll against them.

6.6. Ranged Combat

Basic Ranged Attack

Roll Firearms (AGI) + Weapon Gear Bonus. On a hit, deal flat Damage to the target's Strength (armor applies).

Range Penalties

Weapon Type	Engaged	Near	Short	Long	Distant
Pistol (.38, 9mm)	-1 die	—	—	-1 die	Out of range
Shotgun	+1 Damage	—	—	-2 dice	Out of range
Assault Rifle	-2 dice	-1 die	—	—	-1 die
Thrown weapon	—	—	Out of range	Out of range	Out of range

Engaged penalty for pistols: At arm's length, controlling a pistol one-handed while someone is grappling you is harder than a clean stance shot. The -1 die reflects that.

Cover

A character in cover benefits from partial physical shielding.

- Soft cover (car door, wooden desk, drywall): +2 Armor Rating against ranged attacks only.
- Hard cover (concrete pillar, stone wall, engine block): +4 Armor Rating against ranged attacks only.
- Taking cover requires a Fast Action (move into cover within the current zone).
- A character who fires from cover loses the cover bonus against any return fire that round — you must expose yourself to shoot, and that window persists until your next turn when you can take cover again. Cover returns automatically at the start of your next turn if you do not fire again.

Ammunition

Ammunition is tracked using a Resource Die that steps down as you fire. Full ammunition tracking rules — including the ammo die table, when to roll, and full automatic fire — are in [Appendix: Advanced Combat Ammunition Tracking](#).

6.7. Reactive Actions

Dodge

- Type: Fast Action (reactive — used on someone else's turn, not yours)
- When: After a melee or ranged attack is declared against you, before the attacker rolls.
- Effect: Add your Agility dice to your "defense pool." The attacker must beat your dodge roll (attacker needs strictly more successes than you — ties favor the defender). Compare successes; if equal, the dodge succeeds and you take no damage.
- Cost: You lose your Fast Action on your next turn.
- Limitation: You cannot dodge if you have no Fast Action remaining this round (already spent), if you are prone, if you are Grappled, or if the attack was from ambush (surprise round).

Parry

- Type: Slow Action (reactive — used on someone else's turn)

- **When:** After a melee attack is declared against you, before the attacker rolls. Requires a held melee weapon.
- **Effect:** Roll Brawl or Force (your choice). If you match or exceed the attacker's successes, you take no damage — the parry is clean. If you beat the attacker's successes by 2 or more, they also lose their Slow Action next round (weapon arm numbed or off-balance). If the attacker beats your parry, you take the attack's full damage (the parry failed).
- **Cost:** You lose your Slow Action on your next turn.
- **Limitation:** Cannot parry ranged attacks, unarmed shoves, or any attack from a weapon with Damage 4+.

6.8. Combat Stunts

Extra successes (6s beyond the attack's required Difficulty, usually 1) are Stunt Points. Spend them from the table below. One stunt point = one effect unless listed otherwise. You may spend multiple stunt points on different effects from the same attack — purchase all effects simultaneously before the DA narrates the outcome.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
1	Knock Prone	Target is knocked to the ground. They must spend a Fast Action to stand.
1	Disarm	Target drops their held weapon at Engaged range (without a full Disarm maneuver roll). The weapon lands at Engaged range from the target — either party could pick it up.
1	Target Limb	Attack hits a specific limb. DA applies a situational penalty (hobbled, one-armed, etc.) until treated.
1	Push Back	Target is forced one zone away.
1	Scare	Target must immediately make a Corruption Burst (Burst Rating 1) even if no supernatural trigger is present — the violence itself is the threat. See Corruption Burst .
2	Double Damage	Deal the weapon's Damage value twice instead of once.
2	Suppressive Fire	Target is pinned — they cannot move zones until the start of your next turn unless they succeed on a Wits roll (Difficulty 2).
2	Destroy Cover	Target's cover is destroyed or invalidated after this attack.

Cost	Stunt	Effect
3	Critical Hit	Attack triggers a roll on the Critical Injury table, regardless of whether the target is Broken. See Critical Injuries .

6.9. Advanced Combat Rules

The following situational combat systems are detailed in [Appendix: Advanced Combat Rules](#):

- Chase and Pursuit — foot chase structure, escape/recapture rules.
- Combat Around Vehicles — vehicles as cover, attacking vehicles and occupants.
- Vehicle Conflict — Contact Track, chase rolls, speed modifiers, vehicle maneuvers (Ram, PIT, Gunfire, Off-Road Break, Blending In), vehicle damage and breakdown.
- Group Combat (Mob Rules) — treating multiple NPCs as a single mob with shared Strength.

6.10. Ending Combat

Surrender and DA Adjudication

There is no mandatory surrender mini-system. Surrender is a Director of Agents adjudication call based on morale, stakes, and faction doctrine.

Use these guidance triggers:

- Likely surrender: Isolated hostiles, badly wounded opponents, mercenary or self-preserving factions.
- Unlikely surrender: Fanatics, entities, or actors with existential stakes in the artifact outcome.
- False surrender risk: Trained operatives, cornered faction elites, or anyone buying time for extraction.

Player characters may always choose to surrender — it is never forced mechanically.

Retreat and Withdrawal

A character may disengage from combat freely on their turn as long as:

- No enemy is Engaged with them (Engaged = melee), OR
- They succeed on an Agility roll (Difficulty 1) to break from Engaged contact.

After disengaging, they may move up to two zones in the same turn (spending their Fast Action and Slow Action on movement).

Broken in Combat

When any NPC attribute reaches 0, they are Broken (incapacitated). The DA chooses: dead, dying, unconscious, or surrendering based on context, damage type, and narrative stakes.

When any PC attribute reaches 0, they are Broken:

- They collapse and are incapacitated.
- They must roll on the appropriate Critical Injury table (see [Critical Injuries](#)).
- They are out of the fight unless stabilized by an ally (Heal roll, costs a Slow Action, requires a First Aid Kit).
- An unstabilized Broken PC dies at the end of the scene — defined as when the immediate danger has passed and the group can act freely, not at the end of the round in which they fell. This means teammates have a window during the fight to stabilize them. If combat ends and the PC has not been stabilized, they die.

DA Guidance — When does the scene end? The scene ends when the DA declares it over — typically when the last hostile threat is neutralized, has fled, or has been contained. If all enemies are down and the team's only remaining action is stabilizing a downed ally, the scene is not over yet — the agents are still acting under combat urgency. The DA should not call scene end while a teammate is actively bleeding out and allies are attempting to reach them. The scene ends when the group transitions from combat urgency to free action: looting the room, securing the perimeter, calling for extraction. If in doubt, give the team one more round to act before calling it.

Capture over kill: The Covenant defaults to capturing hostile humans for interrogation. NPCs with relevant information are more valuable alive. DAs should give players narrative opportunities to take prisoners rather than mandating lethality.

CHAPTER 7. SOCIAL CONFLICT

Investigation games are social games. Most of what agents do in Neon Relic is talk to people: witnesses who saw something and won't say it, cult members who believe what they're doing is righteous, informants who want to help but are terrified, supervisors who need to believe the cover story. The skill of the agent is reading people and moving them.

Social conflict in Neon Relic uses the Disposition model — a lightweight system that tracks where an NPC stands and shifts based on agent actions. It does not require rounds or "social HP." It uses the existing dice pool mechanics and resolves quickly.

7.1. NPC Disposition

Every NPC who is not immediately cooperative has a Disposition — a state describing their current openness to engagement. Disposition exists on a 5-point track:

Score	State	Behaviour
5	Open	The NPC wants to help. They volunteer information. No roll needed for basic cooperation.
4	Cautious	The NPC is willing to talk but holds back. They answer simple questions but hedge on anything sensitive.
3	Guarded	The NPC is resistant. They answer direct, low-risk questions, but social rolls on sensitive subjects are Difficulty 2.
2	Hostile	The NPC is actively uncooperative. They may lie, deflect, or attempt to end the scene. Social rolls are Difficulty 3.
1	Closed	The NPC will not engage. They may call for help, alert others, or physically leave. Raise them to 2 before social rolls are possible.

Starting Disposition

The DA sets starting Disposition based on the NPC's relationship to the agents and the situation. Suggested defaults:

- Covenant superior with a legitimate inquiry: 4 (Cautious)
- Cooperative civilian eye-witness: 4 (Cautious) — usually wants to help but scared
- Rogue cultist in custody: 2 (Hostile)
- Paid informant: 3 (Guarded) if money is involved, 4 if a relationship has been built

- Hostile faction member: 1 or 2 (Closed / Hostile) by default
 - Mid-level Vantablack Compact operative: 2 (Hostile)
-

7.2. Shifting Disposition

Disposition shifts up (toward Open) or down (toward Closed) based on agent actions, NPC reveals, and roll outcomes. All disposition shifts are done at the DA's discretion and may vary depending on the situation.

Actions that Shift Disposition Up (+1)

- A successful Psychoanalyze roll used to calm, stabilize, or reassure the NPC
- A successful Manipulate roll that makes the NPC feel their interests are served
- The agent voluntarily reveals information that helps the NPC (demonstrates good faith)
- The NPC is shown physical evidence that confirms what they suspected
- An agent successfully makes a roll to perform a service for the NPC before asking anything

Actions that Shift Disposition Down (-1)

- A failed Manipulate roll (the NPC sees through the attempt)
- The NPC detects an agent's deception (DA's judgment, or the NPC wins an opposed Psychoanalyze or Empathy roll against the agent's Manipulate — see NPC Social Defense below)
- An agent makes a physical threat or veiled threat while the NPC's Disposition is 3+
- A successful Psychoanalyze roll by the DA on behalf of the NPC (they read the agents — see NPC Social Defense below)
- An agent reveals information that endangers the NPC or confirms they are a target

Disposition Thresholds

- Disposition 3 or higher: The NPC will answer direct, low-risk questions truthfully (though not necessarily fully). No roll required for general cooperation. Sensitive asks, incriminating admissions, or requests against self-interest still call for a roll.
- Disposition 2: The NPC requires a successful social roll to answer even basic questions. They will lie by default.
- Disposition 1: The NPC is done with the scene. They must be brought back to 2 before any social rolls are possible. Physical containment is required for continued interrogation.

Recovering from Disposition 1

At Disposition 1, social rolls are impossible. The agents must take non-roll actions to restore openness before any roll can be attempted:

- Voluntarily reveal information that demonstrates good faith (show them the agents are on the same side of something)
- Show physical evidence that validates the NPC's position or confirms a shared threat
- Remove a perceived threat (uncuff them, step back, send the intimidating agent away)
- Make a concrete, verifiable concession — offer protection, return a possession, give them their phone back
- Allow time to pass — at DA discretion, minutes to hours depending on how the scene ended

These actions do not require rolls. The DA judges when the accumulated effort is sufficient to shift from 1 to 2. Do not rush it — a convincing recovery from Disposition 1 should feel earned.

Disposition Between Scenes

When agents re-encounter an NPC in a later scene, the DA sets a new starting Disposition informed by the previous interaction:

- If the last scene ended positively (Disposition 3+), the NPC starts at their previous Disposition or one step lower (they've had time to reconsider what they shared).
- If the last scene ended badly (Disposition 1-2), the NPC starts at 1 or 2 at DA discretion. Significant time passed, a changed situation, or a concrete show of good faith can allow a higher starting point.
- If a Closed source consequence was applied, the NPC will not engage again this mission regardless of Disposition — the window is gone.

What Counts as a Roll-Free Question?

At Disposition 3 or higher, use the following rule of thumb:

- Direct, low-risk question: No roll. The NPC answers truthfully, though briefly or with omissions. Example: "Where were you when it happened?"
- Sensitive disclosure: Roll required. The answer would expose fear, shame, a relationship, or knowledge the NPC would rather keep contained. Example: "Who else was there with you?"
- Against self-interest: Roll required. The answer would endanger the NPC, implicate them, expose an ally, or materially help the agents at the NPC's expense. Example: "Give me the supplier's name."

The point of raising Disposition is to move the scene from access problems to leverage problems. Once an NPC is talking, stop rolling for every ordinary question.

7.3. Social Rolls in Practice

Social rolls use the normal dice pool (Attribute + Skill). When a roll is required to gain cooperation or extract something sensitive, the baseline Difficulty is set by current Disposition unless a skill entry says otherwise. You are always rolling against the NPC's current state, not their willpower or an abstract resistance.

Use these defaults when a roll is actually required:

- Disposition 4 or 5: Difficulty 1 for sensitive asks.
- Disposition 3: Difficulty 2 for sensitive asks.
- Disposition 2: Difficulty 3 for almost any ask.
- Disposition 1: No social roll possible until the NPC is brought back into the scene.

Manipulate (Empathy)

Used to deceive, persuade, bribe, leverage, or appeal to self-interest. Manipulate specifically targets the NPC's wants and fears — it works through the gap between what they want the world to be and what it is.

- On success: NPC complies with the specific request, AND Disposition shifts +1 (they feel the interaction was productive, even if later they're not sure why).
- On failure: Request denied. Disposition shifts -1. The NPC has clocked the attempt.
- On a pushed failure: As above, but Disposition shifts -2 (instead of -1). The NPC is now certain they are being worked, and they know by whom. As with all pushed rolls, the agent also gains +1 Corruption (see [Core Resolution](#)).

Command (Empathy)

Used to assert authority, direct behavior under pressure, or coordinate. Command does not persuade — it compels through confidence and force of presence. It works when the NPC is uncertain what to do, when the agents represent a legitimate authority, or when the situation is dangerous enough that someone taking charge feels like relief.

- Command normally does not create cooperation at Disposition 2. At Disposition 2, it only works for immediate emergency direction when the agents clearly have situational authority: "Get down," "Move away from the door," "Stay behind me." It does not extract information or create trust.
- Command does not work at Disposition 1. An NPC who is fully closed will not accept authority from the agents at all. If an agent attempts Command at Disposition 1, the DA should inform them before the dice are rolled — no action is spent, and no roll is made.
- At Disposition 2, emergency commands (immediate physical directives only — "Get down,"

"Step back," "Don't call anyone") are resolved at Difficulty 2. Command at Disposition 2 cannot extract information or build cooperation.

- On success: NPC complies fully for the immediate scene. No Disposition shift.
- On failure: NPC fails to comply. No Disposition shift, but the failed authority assertion may have social consequences at the DA's discretion.

Opposed roll: If the NPC is actively arguing or bargaining their way out of compliance (rather than just passively refusing), the DA may call for an opposed roll: Command (EMP) vs the NPC's Manipulate (EMP). On a tie, the agent wins — see [Core Resolution](#) for opposed roll tie-breaking rules. On NPC win, the agent's authority is undermined: no Disposition shift, but the NPC gains visible confidence and may escalate.

Psychoanalyze (Empathy)

Used to read, understand, or heal. In social conflict, Psychoanalyze has two modes:

Reading: You are trying to understand the NPC's underlying state — what they need, what they fear, what they're not saying.

- **Difficulty:** Set by the DA based on how defended or emotionally opaque the NPC is, usually 1–3. Current Disposition is a guide, not a hard rule.
- On success: DA must reveal one true thing about this NPC's psychological state, motivation, or deception. This grants two benefits on the agent's next social roll (Manipulate or Command) against the same NPC in the same scene:

+1 bonus die

The effective Difficulty of the follow-up roll is reduced by 1 (minimum Difficulty 1)

- These benefits expire if not used in the same scene, or if the NPC's Disposition drops before the follow-up roll. A Disposition increase (from evidence shown, a service performed, etc.) does not invalidate Reading benefits — the agent's insight remains relevant as the NPC warms up.

Stunt interaction: Extra successes on a Reading roll become stunt points as normal (see [Stunts in Social Conflict](#) below). Spending the Pressure Point stunt on a Reading roll causes the DA to reveal an additional detail beyond the standard Reading reveal. Spending Full Read (2 SP) grants its scene-long benefits (+2 dice, Difficulty 1) in place of the standard single-use benefits — Full Read is strictly superior and replaces them.

Example: An agent faces a Hostile NPC (Disposition 2, Difficulty 3 for social rolls). The agent first uses Psychoanalyze (Reading) to understand the NPC. On success, the follow-up Manipulate roll is made at Difficulty 2 (reduced from 3) with 1 bonus die. This means a roll generating 3 successes now produces stunt points, compared to needing 4+ successes without the Psychoanalyze step.

Stabilizing: You are treating an NPC's fear, trauma, or distress to make them more communicative.

- On success: Disposition shifts +2 (the NPC feels seen and safe). Stabilizing cannot raise Disposition above 4 (Cautious) — reaching Disposition 5 (Open) requires the NPC to genuinely want to help, which comes from sustained positive interaction, not a single calming roll.
- Difficulty by distress source: supernatural trauma (entity exposure, artifact terror) = Difficulty 3; mundane fear (physical danger, intimidation) = Difficulty 1; complex emotional distress (grief, moral conflict, deeply held belief) = Difficulty 2.
- On failure: Disposition shifts -1 (you probed and made it worse).

7.4. NPC Social Defense

NPCs can also read agents. A canny NPC may actively attempt to read or manipulate the agents in return. The DA may call for:

- Opposed Psychoanalyze roll: DA rolls on behalf of the NPC. Use this when the NPC is actively reading the agents rather than merely resisting. On NPC success, Disposition shifts are reversed for that action, OR the NPC identifies a specific agent as the social focal point (they will now direct deflection at that agent).
- Lie detection: When an NPC is actively trying to catch an agent in a deception, the DA rolls opposed: NPC Empathy + Psychoanalyze (if the NPC is trained — intelligence operatives, therapists, con artists, experienced detectives) or NPC Empathy with no skill dice (untrained NPCs) vs the agent's Manipulate roll. On NPC win, the deception is detected and Disposition shifts -1 immediately. This aligns with the opposed roll pairing in [Core Resolution](#) (Manipulate vs Psychoanalyze).

If the DA calls for active social defense during a Manipulate attempt, treat it as a combined test: the agent must meet the Disposition-based Difficulty and beat the NPC's opposing roll. Count the agent's total successes against both thresholds simultaneously — the agent needs to meet the Difficulty number AND exceed the NPC's successes. Stunt points are successes in excess of whichever threshold is higher.

These are at DA discretion, not every NPC has this capability. When building NPC cards for case files, add a Social Defense note if the NPC has active resistance capabilities. Suggested baseline: NPCs with social defense have Empathy 3+ and Psychoanalyze 2. Untrained NPCs use Empathy alone with no skill dice — they can feel the attempt but can't precisely identify it. See [Case Files](#) for NPC card format.

7.5. Consequences of Failed Social Scenes

When a social scene ends badly (Disposition reaches 1, or the agents leave having gained nothing), the DA applies one or more consequences:

Consequence Type	Example
Closed source	The NPC will not speak to the agents again this mission. The information they held may be inaccessible.
Alert raised	The NPC warns someone — their employer, their family, or the Vantablack Compact. Agents' activities are now known to a new party.
Physical escalation	The scene tips into violence. The NPC or their contacts move against the agents. If combat begins, see Combat for initiative and action economy. The NPC or their contacts typically act first — treat as a Surprise round if the agents didn't anticipate violence.
Faction response	A rival faction learns that the Covenant is investigating. Their own response begins accelerating. See Rival Factions for faction escalation mechanics.
Trust erosion	A Covenant contact or superior is told about the agents' approach. Standing within the Covenant takes a hit for the current case. See Headquarters for Standing mechanics.

7.6. Social Pressure and Corruption Burst

Social encounters with entities, artifacts, or cult members may cross into supernatural territory. When the content of a conversation triggers a Corruption Burst:

- Direct supernatural revelation during a Manipulate scene (the NPC says something that cannot be explained naturally): Corruption Burst, Burst Rating 1 or 2.
- Psychoanalyze roll on a contaminated NPC (someone who has long-term artifact exposure): Roll Psychoanalyze as normal. On any failure, the agent picks up a psychic echo — immediate Corruption Burst, Burst Rating 2. On success, the agent gets the information but gains +1 Corruption.

Exception: This is the only roll in Neon Relic where a success costs Corruption. Reading a contaminated mind means absorbing a fragment of what contaminated it. The information is accurate — but the contact is inherently dangerous. This cannot be mitigated by skill or luck. See also the cross-reference in [Corruption and Healing](#).

See [Corruption and Healing](#) for full Corruption Burst rules.

7.7. Worked Example: Interrogating a Cultist

Setup: The agents have detained Brother Elias — a mid-level member of The Ember Accord cult — in the back of a van. He believes the artifact they recovered is a holy relic and resents being

treated as a criminal.

Starting Disposition: 2 (Hostile). He's in zip ties. He's praying under his breath. He won't look at the agents directly.

Round 1: Agent Petra Vasquez attempts Psychoanalyze (Read) — she wants to understand what Elias actually believes before making any demands. The DA sets Difficulty 2: Elias is hostile, but reading him is easier than persuading him or getting him to volunteer anything.

Petra rolls Empathy 3 + Psychoanalyze 2 = 5 dice. Rolls: 6, 6, 4, 3, 1 — two successes. Meets Difficulty 2 exactly — no extra successes, no stunt points. This reinforces the rule: stunts require exceeding the Difficulty, not merely meeting it.

DA reveals: Elias genuinely believes the artifact protected his sister during a cancer diagnosis two years ago. He is not performing faith. He is terrified that if it leaves his possession, she will relapse. He is not lying about any of this.

Round 2: Using that information, Petra shifts from reading to Psychoanalyze (Stabilizing). She stops pressing Elias about doctrine and instead speaks to the real fear: his sister is sick, he thinks the artifact kept her alive, and now he is trapped in a van with strangers who want to take it away.

Petra rolls Empathy 3 + Psychoanalyze 2 = 5 dice. The DA sets Difficulty 2: Elias is distressed and hostile, but Petra is addressing the real wound. Rolls: 6, 6, 4, 2, 1 — two successes.

Success: Elias calms enough to talk. Disposition shifts from 2 to 4. He stops reciting under his breath and finally meets Petra's eyes.

Round 3: Elias is now at Disposition 4 (Cautious). Marcus asks a direct, low-risk question: "Where is your sister right now?" No roll is required. Elias answers truthfully: Providence. She's alive. She's with an aunt.

Round 4: Marcus now pushes for something against Elias's interests: the name of the fence who moved the relic. That would expose Elias to retaliation, so the DA calls for a Manipulate roll.

Note: Petra passed the social focal point to Marcus — this is a tag-team approach. Petra's Psychoanalyze Reading bonus (+1 die, -1 Difficulty) applied only to Petra's follow-up roll (she used it in Round 2 for Stabilizing). Marcus makes a fresh Manipulate roll at the current Disposition-based Difficulty. His Reading benefit comes from re-reading Elias himself (or trusting Petra's briefing — the DA should decide if a second Read is needed).

Manipulate roll: Empathy 4 + Manipulate 3 = 7 dice. Difficulty 1 (Disposition 4, sensitive ask). Rolls: 6, 6, 5, 4, 2, 2, 1 — two successes. Two successes at Difficulty 1 = 1 extra success = 1 stunt point.

Marcus spends the stunt point on Bought Silence (see [Attributes & Skills](#) for Manipulate stunts): Elias won't mention this conversation to anyone for at least 24 hours — enough time for the agents to move on Talvez before Elias has a chance to warn him.

Success: Elias gives the name: a fence named Talvez, operating out of a pawn shop on the East Side. He works for several clients. Elias doesn't know who.

Outcome: The scene demonstrates the full loop. Read first to find the leverage. Stabilize to move the NPC into conversation. Ask direct questions for free once Disposition is high enough. Roll only when the agents want disclosure that still carries risk for the target. Spend stunt points on skill-specific effects to shape what success means.

7.8. Pushing Social Rolls

All social rolls may be pushed per the standard push rules (see [Core Resolution](#)). Pushing always costs +1 Corruption, in addition to any Disposition penalties listed here. Push before knowing the outcome is final — the push replaces your non-6 dice.

Skill	Pushed Failure	Note
Manipulate	Disposition -2 (instead of -1). NPC now certain they are being worked. +1 Corruption.	Most punishing push in the social system.
Command	No Disposition shift. NPC recognizes desperation. They may become emboldened or dismissive (DA discretion). +1 Corruption.	No extra Disposition penalty because Command doesn't move Disposition on success either.
Psychoanalyze (Reading)	DA provides misleading information (agent projects their own fears). No Disposition shift. +1 Corruption.	Pushed Reading failure is narratively dangerous — the wrong read leads to wrong leverage.
Psychoanalyze (Stabilizing)	Disposition -2 (instead of -1). Agent pressed a raw nerve and made it significantly worse. +1 Corruption.	Match the severity of Manipulate pushed failure.

7.9. Stunts in Social Conflict

Extra successes on social rolls become stunt points, as normal (see [Core Resolution](#)). These may be spent on the relevant skill's stunt list in [Attributes & Skills](#):

- Manipulate stunts (Bought Silence, Read the Room, Turned Asset) apply in addition to the automatic Disposition +1 shift from success.
- Command stunts (Rally, Coordinated Action, Hold the Line) apply in addition to the NPC's compliance.
- Psychoanalyze stunts (Pressure Point, Decompress, Full Read) apply in addition to Reading or Stabilizing effects.

Stunt effects and Disposition effects are cumulative — they are separate outcomes of the same roll. Stunt points must be spent immediately (within the same action) or they are lost.

7.10. Multiple Agents in Social Scenes

The Helping rules from [Core Resolution](#) apply to social rolls. An ally present in the scene may add +1 die to another agent's social roll if they have the relevant skill or the DA accepts a narrative justification (silent moral support for Psychoanalyze, physical presence during Command, feeding intel for Manipulate).

Only one agent should be the social focal point for a given NPC at a time. Other agents may:

- Help (add +1 die to the focal agent's roll)
- Wait and observe — a successful Psychoanalyze (Reading) roll by a watching agent can be shared verbally before the focal agent rolls, providing the Reading bonus
- Attempt their own social rolls on subsequent actions

Multiple simultaneous social attempts on the same NPC risk overwhelming them — at DA discretion, aggressive teamwork may impose a -1 Disposition penalty. Rotating the focal point mid-scene (handing off from one agent to another) is legitimate, but per-agent Reading bonuses do not transfer — only the agent who made the Reading roll benefits from it on their own follow-up roll.

CHAPTER 8. HEALTH, DAMAGE, AND ARMOR

In the Year Zero Engine, characters do not possess a traditional, escalating pool of "Hit Points." Instead, your four core Attributes directly serve as your health pools.

8.1. Damage Types

Every source of damage specifies its type and target attribute. The attack defines the damage, not the defender.

Damage Type	Target	Sources
Physical	Strength (violence, toxins, falls) or Agility (exhaustion, prolonged exertion)	Weapons, environmental hazards, physical traps, mundane combat
Mental	Wits (terror, confusion, psychic assault) or Empathy (grief, guilt, emotional manipulation)	Supernatural abilities, psychological attacks, social betrayal
Corruption	Corruption track directly	Pushing rolls, activating Division Talents, occult exposure, artifact activation/feedback, specific creature attacks

Damage Type Rules

1. The source specifies the damage type and target attribute. The defender does not choose.
2. Combination attacks are possible: a supernatural creature might deal Physical (STR) + Corruption damage in the same attack. Both are applied.
3. Weapon stat blocks list Damage, Type, and Target Attribute. In the equipment table ([Equipment](#)) the format is: Gear Bonus | Damage | Type | Range. Example: Knife — Gear Bonus +1, Damage 2, Physical (STR), Range: Engaged. See [Bestiary](#) for creature stat block format.
4. Creature stat blocks list damage per attack. Example: Shadow Tendril — Damage 2, Mental (WIT) + 1 Corruption.
5. Broken state triggers when any attribute reaches 0, as before. Physical Broken (STR/AGI = 0) Physical Critical Injury table. Mental Broken (WIT/EMP = 0) Mental Critical Injury table.

Note on Corruption: Corruption is listed above for completeness, but it functions differently from Physical and Mental damage. Physical and Mental damage reduce Attribute pools. Corruption adds to a separate Corruption track — it cannot be absorbed by armor, and its healing follows different rules (see [Corruption and Healing](#)). When an attack deals both Physical damage and Corruption, resolve each type independently.

What Determines STR vs AGI / WIT vs EMP

- Physical attacks default to STR unless the source is specifically about exhaustion, fatigue, or overexertion (then AGI).
- Mental attacks default to WIT unless the source is specifically emotional, social, or empathic (then EMP).
- The DA does not adjudicate this per-attack. The weapon, creature, or event definition states the target.

8.2. The Broken State

If any Attribute is reduced to 0, your character becomes Broken:

- The character is immediately incapacitated: they collapse where they stand.
 They cannot take actions (Slow, Fast, or Reactive) and cannot push rolls.
 They cannot move under their own power. An ally may drag or carry them at half speed (1 zone per Slow Action).
 They can speak briefly — a few words per round. Enough for last words or calling for help.
 They can perceive their surroundings but cannot take meaningful action.
 They may still make Wits or Empathy rolls if directly targeted (the DA decides when a passive mental roll is appropriate).
- They must roll on a Critical Injury table, which can result in lethal consequences or permanent maiming depending on the severity of the attack.

Simultaneous Injury Resolution

When multiple end-states trigger from a single sequence of events, resolve them in this order:

1. Physical damage resolves first. Apply all damage, check for Broken state, roll Critical Injury if applicable.
2. Death Check resolves second. If the Critical Injury requires a Death Check (†), resolve it immediately. If the character dies, they are dead — no further checks apply.
3. Corruption threshold resolves third. After all physical injury effects are complete, check whether any Corruption gained during the sequence (from Critical Injury results, Corruption Bursts from witnessing an ally's Critical Injury — see [Corruption and Healing](#) for Burst rules — or other sources) has pushed the character over their Corruption threshold. If so, the character enters catatonia.

Corruption timing: Corruption gained from Mental Critical Injury results (the +1 base and any additional listed amounts) is accumulated but not checked against the Corruption threshold until

Step 3. Accumulate all Corruption from the entire sequence, then check the threshold once at the end.

This means a character can survive being shot only to have their mind break from the trauma of the experience. It also means a character who fails their Death Check is simply dead — the Corruption is rendered moot. The physical world moves faster than the psyche unravels.

8.3. Death and Dying

Being Broken is not the same as being dead. Death is a separate, subsequent event — probabilistic, not automatic — that occurs if a Broken character does not receive care in time.

The Three States

State	Status	What It Means
Broken / Unconscious	Any Attribute = 0. Critical Injury rolled.	Character is incapacitated. They can still be saved.
Dying	Broken with a Death Check Critical Injury (result marked †) — and the Death Check has not yet been resolved, or was survived but the underlying injury is active (Bleeding, Guttled).	The window for stabilization is closing. An untreated Dying character will die.
Dead	Death Check rolled and failed, OR a specific instant-death result triggered, OR Dying window expires without treatment.	The character is gone.

The Death Check

A Death Check is a single d6 roll. It is required whenever a Critical Injury is marked with †.

- Roll one d6.
- 1-2: The character dies.
- 3-6: The character survives — the Critical Injury still applies and must be treated, but they cling to life.

Medical Training Talent (Keep): An ally with Medical Training may spend a Slow Action to make a Heal (WIT) roll (Difficulty 2) before the Death Check is rolled. On success: the dying character rolls d6+1 instead of d6 (death only on a natural 1 — result 2 on the table). On failure: no

change; Death Check proceeds normally.

The Stabilization Window

A Broken character who has rolled a Death-Check result (†) has a limited window in which an ally can stabilize them before death becomes inevitable:

- Within the same scene: An ally may attempt to stabilize the Dying character (see First Aid below).
- End of scene without treatment: The character must roll their Death Check unmodified. No ally assistance.
- Extreme Critical Injury exceptions: Critical Injury result 66 (DOA) requires an immediate Death Check — there is no window. The Heal roll to make the check possible (Difficulty 4) must be attempted within the same round (not the same scene). See Extreme Critical Injuries below.

First Aid: Stabilizing a Dying Character

To stabilize a Dying ally during the stabilization window:

- Skill: Heal (WIT)
- Action: Slow Action
- Requirements: A First Aid Kit (+1 Gear Bonus to Heal, Resource Die d10 — see [Equipment](#)) must be present and not exhausted. Without one, the Heal roll is made at -2 dice: -1 from the missing Gear Bonus, and -1 additional penalty for improvising without supplies.
- Difficulty: 2 (normal), 3 (if Gutted or Arterial Strike), 4 (if DOA attempted mid-round)
- On success: The Dying state is resolved. The Critical Injury remains. The character is Broken/Unconscious but no longer dying. They need rest and proper medical care, but they will live.
- On failure: Stabilization attempt failed. The character may try again if time permits (same scene). Each failed attempt reduces the treating agent's current Strength by 1 (the desperate effort physically exhausts the healer). The Broken character's attribute is already at 0 and cannot go lower.

Extreme Critical Injuries

Some Critical Injury results carry extreme conditions that change how the Death Check works:

- Result 66 (DOA): Without immediate intervention, death is automatic — no Death Check is rolled. An ally may attempt a Heal roll (Difficulty 4, same round only) to make a Death Check possible. If the Heal succeeds, the character makes a Death Check with no bonus (plain d6; the Medical Training +1 does not apply here — the Heal action's entire effort went into keeping the patient alive long enough to roll). If no ally attempts the Heal this round (or the Heal

fails), the character dies — there are no further attempts. Surviving: see the Critical Injury table result 66.

- Result 55 (Shattered Will), 46 (Catatonic Episode) — mental death: These require a mental Death Check (mind, not body). The check uses the same procedure (d6, 1-2 = failure). Failure = permanent catatonia, character retirement. These are not physical death — the character is retired from play but may remain as an NPC.

Design note: Result 66 (DOA) is rare — it requires an overwhelmingly lethal physical event to reach the worst end of the D66 table. Most character deaths will come from failed Death Checks, not from this result.

Character Death and Continuity

When a character dies:

1. Gear returns to Stack. Division equipment, the Division Signature Item (Verdant Codex, Warden's Bracer, etc.), and all Covenant-issued gear are logged and returned at the end of the Case File.
2. Covenant notification. The character is officially listed as Fallen in the Line of Duty. The circumstances are filed — truthfully or not, at the surviving team's discretion.
3. Character replacement. A new character enters play at the start of the next Case File. They begin with the same XP total as the lowest-XP surviving member of the team (minimum: the character creation baseline values as defined in [Character Creation](#)). If a character dies mid-Case-File, the DA may introduce the replacement at a narratively appropriate moment in the same mission — a Covenant backup team, a local contact activated as emergency support, or a specialist from HQ. See [Advancement](#) for XP totals and spending.
4. Legacy. The deceased character's player chooses one lasting effect: a significant item the new character carries (with DA permission), an NPC connection inherited, or a reputation within the Covenant that precedes them.

Corruption Death vs. Physical Death

Physical death and Corruption-threshold death are distinct retirement paths:

- Physical death: Any Attribute at 0 Critical Injury possible Death Check failure. The character dies with their body intact enough for others to note.
- Corruption death: Corruption exceeds (strictly greater than) $10 + \text{Empathy}$ permanent catatonia. The character exists but is unreachable — institutionalized, catatonic, or simply lost. Technically still alive, but gone from play.

Permanent Empathy loss and threshold interaction: Several Mental Critical Injuries permanently reduce Empathy. If an Empathy reduction causes the Corruption threshold to drop to or below the character's current Corruption total, the character does not immediately enter catatonia — catatonia only triggers when Corruption exceeds the threshold. But the character is at critical

risk: any further Corruption gain of any amount will trigger catatonia instantly.

Corruption death is in many ways worse. Physical death is clean. Corruption death means your colleagues have to keep making decisions about someone they knew, who is now a stranger in a hospital bed.

8.4. Critical Injuries

When a character is Broken (any Attribute reduced to 0), they immediately roll on the appropriate Critical Injury table. The table used depends on what type of damage Broke them:

- Physical (Strength = 0): Roll on the Physical Critical Injury table.
- Hobbling (Agility = 0): Roll on the Physical Critical Injury table (the body has failed). The DA should reinterpret results for hobbling context — a 'Head Shot' becomes a stroke or aneurysm; an 'Arterial Strike' becomes a cardiovascular crisis; 'Arm Blown Off' represents total muscular collapse. The mechanical effect of the rolled result is unchanged. Only the narrative framing adapts.
- Mental (Wits = 0): Roll on the Mental & Emotional Critical Injury table.
- Emotional (Empathy = 0): Roll on the Mental & Emotional Critical Injury table.

How to Roll D66

Roll two d6. The first die is the tens digit, the second is the units digit. A result of 3 on the first die and 4 on the second = 34.

Death Checks

Some results are marked † (Death Check). When you roll one, roll a single d6:

- On a 1-2: Your character dies.
- On a 3-6: You survive — barely. The Critical Injury still applies.

A character with Medical Training (Keep talent) may spend a Slow Action making a Heal (WIT) roll (Difficulty 2) to give a dying ally +1 to their death check die before it's rolled (effectively making death only on a natural 1 — result 2 on the table).

Critical Injury Severity Categories

Critical Injuries are categorized by severity:

- **Non-lethal (no † marker):** Serious but not immediately life-threatening. Can be treated during downtime at Keep medical facilities ([Headquarters](#)).
- **Lethal (marked with †):** Requires a Death Check. Emergency field stabilization is required before downtime treatment.
- **Permanent (listed as 'Cannot be healed'):** Even Keep facilities cannot clear these injuries. They represent lasting change.

The canonical term is non-lethal (not 'non-fatal'). Both this chapter and Chapter 12 use non-lethal consistently.

Insight: Permanent Bonuses from Critical Injuries

Some Critical Injury results grant an Insight — a permanent mechanical bonus representing hard-won understanding. Insights are shown in *italic* in the tables.

- Insights cannot be removed, even if the underlying injury is treated or cosmetically corrected.
- Insights from different injuries stack (two separate Empathy Insights = +2 dice total).
- Record each Insight on your character sheet with its source injury.
- Insights reflect genuine trauma — they cannot be deliberately sought. If the DA determines a character is intentionally provoking injury to acquire an Insight, the Critical Injury is applied without the Insight bonus. A character cannot gain the same Insight twice.

Broken Attribute Restoration

When a character rolls a Critical Injury, their Broken Attribute remains at 0 unless the result explicitly states otherwise (e.g., 'Strength returns to 1'). A character whose attribute remains at 0 is still Broken and must be stabilized before they can act. Results that do restore the attribute (11, 16, 42) represent impacts that Broke the character through shock alone — the physical damage was not severe enough to maintain the Broken state.

Physical Critical Injury Table (D66)

Roll when Broken by Strength or Agility damage.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
11	Wind Knocked Out	No actions next turn; Strength returns to 1.	Recovers automatically end of scene.
12	Bad Fall	Agility reduced by 1 permanently.	Requires Keep medical facility (downtime).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
13	Bloody Nose	-1 die on Investigate rolls until treated.	Heal roll (Difficulty 1) with First Aid Kit.
14	Cracked Ribs	-1 die on all Force rolls; any violent action costs 1 additional Strength.	Bed rest (1 downtime phase).
15	Sprained Wrist	Cannot use two-handed weapons. -1 die on all AGI rolls.	Splint + 1 downtime phase.
16	Grazed	Strength returns to 1. Scar remains (cosmetic).	No treatment needed.
21	Concussion	Wits reduced by 1 until treated. Disorientation: must succeed on Wits roll (Diff 1) to use Slow Actions.	Heal roll (Difficulty 2) + 24 hours rest.
22	Shoulder Dislocation	Dominant arm useless. -2 dice on all STR rolls.	Heal roll (Difficulty 2); 1 downtime phase.
23	Torn Knee	Movement costs double (2 Fast Actions per zone instead of 1).	Surgery (Keep facility) + 1 downtime phase.
24	Ringing Ears	-1 die on all WIT-based rolls for rest of session.	No treatment needed — fades by next session.
25	Fractured Hand	-2 dice on all AGI rolls. Cannot wield weapons requiring grip.	Splint + 2 downtime phases.
26	Severe Bruising	-1 Strength maximum until healed (cannot be healed above 3).	Heal roll (Difficulty 2) + 1 downtime phase.
31	Deep Laceration	Bleeds 1 Strength per round until treated (First Aid, Difficulty 1).	Bandaging stops bleed; full recovery = 1 downtime.
32	Fractured Arm	Non-dominant arm: useless. Dominant arm: -2 dice STR.	Cast + 2 downtime phases.
33	Broken Nose (Insight)	+1 die on Command rolls made through threat or intimidation forever (you look dangerous now).	No mechanical healing needed. Defect: cosmetic disfiguration.
34	Shattered Kneecap	Movement speed halved permanently (1 zone costs Slow Action). Surgery can restore.	Keep surgical facility + 2 downtime phases.
35	Punctured Lung	-2 dice on all STR and AGI rolls. Strenuous action triggers Endure roll (Difficulty 2) or collapse.	Heal roll (Difficulty 3) + 2 downtime phases.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
36	Blinding Strike	One eye damaged: -1 die on all ranged attack and Investigate rolls permanently. Insight: +1 die on Empathy rolls (you understand fragility now).	Cannot be fully healed; monocle/patch is acquired (CL 1).
41	Severed Tendon	Permanently -1 Agility.	Keep surgical facility restores -1 penalty only.
42	Trauma Shock	Frozen for 1d6 rounds. No actions possible. Strength returns to 1 after unfreezing.	Recovers on its own; stimulants (Fast Action) end it immediately.
43	Broken Vertebra	Agility reduced by 2. Risk of paralysis: any further STR/AGI damage to 0 triggers death check without rolling.	Keep surgical facility (requires 2 downtime phases, Difficulty 3 Heal roll).
44	Organ Damage	Strength maximum reduced by 2 permanently.	Keep surgical facility can restore 1 point.
45	Severed Ear	Permanent -1 die on Investigate rolls. Insight: +1 die on Empathy rolls (you listen more carefully now).	Cosmetic only; scar remains.
46	Gutted †	Bleeding: lose 1 Strength per round. Death check after 3 rounds if untreated. Heal (Difficulty 3) stops bleeding.	Emergency surgery (Keep facility) required; 2 downtime phases.
51	Broken Jaw	Cannot speak coherently. Cannot use Manipulate or Command skills until treated.	Surgical wire (Keep) + 1 downtime phase.
52	Nerve Damage	Permanently -1 Agility. Occasional muscle spasms: on any die roll of all 1s, drop what you're holding.	Cannot be healed.
53	Severe Burns	-2 dice on all STR/AGI actions. Unbandaged burns: lose 1 Strength per scene from infection.	Keep medical facility; 2 downtime phases.
54	Spinal Injury	Agility reduced to 1 until treated. No running (cannot move two zones).	Keep surgical facility (Difficulty 4); 3 downtime phases.
55	Arm Blown Off †	Dominant arm severed. Death check. Surviving: permanently one-armed. All two-handed weapons require improvised rig or aid.	Cannot regrow. Prosthetic possible (Equipment Prosthetics , CL 5).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Healing
56	Skull Fracture †	Death check. Surviving: Wits permanently reduced by 1. Severe headaches: -1 die on Investigate for 1 month.	Keep facility; 1 downtime phase after death check survival.
61	Chest Shot †	Death check. Surviving: Strength maximum reduced by 1 permanently.	Emergency surgery (Keep facility required immediately).
62	Leg Blown Off †	Death check. Surviving: movement reduced to 1 zone per Slow Action, permanently.	Cannot regrow. Prosthetic possible (Equipment Prosthetics, CL 5).
63	Multiple Wounds †	Death check. Surviving: roll twice more on this table (ignoring further †).	As per rolled injuries.
64	Arterial Strike †	Bleeding 2 Strength per round. Death check must be made within 2 rounds or automatic death.	Tourniquet (Fast Action, CL 1) buys 1 extra round; Heal (Difficulty 4) fully stabilizes.
65	Head Shot †	Death check. Surviving: permanently remove 1 from Wits AND Empathy. Insight: +2 dice on Psychoanalyze forever (near-death clarity).	Cannot be healed. Persistent migraines (permanent).
66	DOA †	No automatic Death Check. An ally must attempt Heal (WIT, Difficulty 4) same round to make a Death Check possible. Without the Heal, automatic death — no roll is made. If the Heal succeeds: Death Check at no bonus (plain d6, Medical Training modifier does not apply). Surviving: character is clinically dead for 1d6 rounds, then revives. All Attributes return to 1. +3 Corruption, Empathy -1 permanently.	See Extreme Critical Injuries above.

Mental & Emotional Critical Injury Table (D66)

Roll when Broken by Wits or Empathy damage. Mental criticals always gain Corruption — the occult has left its mark.

All mental criticals: Gain +1 Corruption upon rolling this table, in addition to any listed in the individual result. This +1 applies once per Broken event, not per roll — rerolls triggered by Veil Madness (result 63) or similar effects do not trigger the +1 again. Accumulate all Corruption from the

sequence and check the threshold once at the end (Step 3 of Simultaneous Injury Resolution).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
11	Shaken	-1 die on all WIT and EMP rolls until end of scene. Wits or Empathy returns to 1.	Rest or reassurance (Empathy roll, Difficulty 1).
12	Distracted	Cannot push rolls until the end of scene (mind can't sustain the effort).	ends automatically with scene change.
13	Tremors	Fine motor control impaired: -1 die on Deft Hands and Firearms this session.	No treatment needed — fades by next session.
14	Dissociation	Character acts on autopilot: DA narrates their next turn's actions.	Psychoanalyze check (Difficulty 1) by ally to snap them out early.
15	Paranoid Flash	Character immediately acts on the nearest perceived threat (DA chooses target — may be an ally).	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 1) ends it; 1 Empathy cost to the treating ally.
16	Acute Anxiety	All Difficulty ratings increase by 1 for rest of scene.	Scene change ends it automatically.
21	Night Terrors	Between sessions: character does not benefit from sleep-based recovery. Agility Broken recovery is halved.	Psychoanalyze session (downtime, Difficulty 2) clears it.
22	Intrusive Visions	-1 die on Investigate whenever concentration is needed (DA's discretion).	Psychoanalyze session (downtime, Difficulty 2).
23	Fugue State	Miss one scene entirely (treated as absent). Character wanders or freezes; ally must spend a Slow Action per round to keep them moving.	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) by an ally to restore presence.
24	Emotional Numbing	Empathy reduced by 1 until treated. Cannot Manipulate others — no connection is felt.	Downtime scene of roleplay connection + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2).
25	Hypervigilance (Insight)	Permanently: +1 die on Investigate rolls (always watching). Permanent: -1 die on Empathy-based social rolls (you don't trust anyone).	No recovery needed — rewired.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
26	Compulsion	Character develops a specific compulsion (DA and player define together: counting objects, checking door locks, avoiding red cars). Each scene, must make Wits roll (Difficulty 1) or act on compulsion before other actions.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3) to suppress.
31	Sensory Flashback	Triggered by a DA-defined stimulus (a smell, a sound). When triggered: lose Fast Action that round as flashback fires.	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases, Difficulty 2).
32	Social Withdrawal	-2 dice on all Empathy-based rolls. Character refuses social complexity.	Downtime social scene (roleplay) + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2).
33	Survivor Guilt	If any ally takes damage within the scene, character suffers 1 Empathy damage (involuntary).	Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) + meaningful roleplay scene.
34	Paranoid Ideation	Character believes a specific NPC or faction is surveilling them (DA chooses). Act on it: +1 die on Sneak actions. Suffer it: -1 die on Empathy rolls involving the believed threat.	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases).
35	Dissociative Identity Trigger	+1 Corruption (additional). DA introduces an alternate behavioral state — twice per session, at dramatic moments, rolls a d6: 1-2 = alternate state this scene.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3).
36	Rage Episodes	When Empathy falls below 2, character must succeed on Wits roll (Difficulty 2) or attack nearest person (ally or foe).	Psychoanalyze campaign (2 downtime phases, Difficulty 3).
41	Artifact Corruption (Insight)	+2 Corruption (additional). Permanent: +1 die on all artifact interaction rolls (you opened a channel). Permanent: -1 Empathy.	Cannot be recovered — this is the artifact's mark.
42	Phobia	New phobia defined (DA and player): when triggered, automatic Corruption Burst at Burst Rating 3.	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases, Difficulty 3) reduces to Burst Rating 1.

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
43	Waking Hallucinations	Wits reduced by 1 permanently. Once per session, character perceives a supernatural intrusion that may or may not be real (DA only knows).	Keep's Empathy specialist can reduce severity; Wits loss is permanent.
44	Emotional Bleed	Permanently -1 Empathy. Character becomes emotionally numb — all social skill rolls suffer -1 die for the remainder of the campaign.	Cannot be healed.
45	Fracture Point	Corruption threshold reduced by 2 (permanently). Max Corruption = 8 + Empathy instead of 10 + Empathy. The exposure has cracked something fundamental.	Cannot be reversed.
46	Catatonic Episode †	Death check (mind, not body — failure = permanent catatonia, character retirement). Surviving: Wits and Empathy each reduced by 1. +2 Corruption immediately.	Intensive Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 4, Keep facility) over 2 downtime phases to stabilize.
51	Obsessive Documentation	Character must document everything (Insight: +2 dice on Investigate when reviewing notes from current mission). Compulsion: spends all available time writing; -1 die on social rolls (distracted).	Psychoanalyze campaign (3 downtime phases) to reduce compulsion; Insight remains.
52	Broken Empathy	Permanently -2 Empathy. All social skills lose 2 dice.	Cannot be healed — the connection is severed.
53	Artifact Imprint	+3 Corruption (additional). Character begins hearing the artifact that Broke them. DA may use this as a plot hook: the artifact calls them back.	Shielding ritual (see Containment Rituals) can suppress the call but not eliminate the imprint.
54	Veil Burn	+2 Corruption. Wits permanently -1. Insight: +1 die on all artifact detection rolls (you can feel them now).	Cannot be healed — the Veil has scorched your perception permanently.
55	Shattered Will †	Death check (mind). Surviving: Wits and Empathy max permanently reduced by 1 each. +2 Corruption. Cannot push rolls for remainder of campaign arc until psychological breakthrough (DA milestone).	Keep Psychoanalyze program (4 downtime phases, Difficulty 4).

D66	Injury	Mechanical Effect	Recovery
56	Cosmic Revelation †	Death check (mind). Surviving: character learns something true and terrible about the Covenant's mission or the nature of artifacts. +3 Corruption, -2 Empathy permanently. Insight: +2 dice on all Lore-type rolls forever (Wayfinder skill equivalent). DA defines the revelation — it should reshape how the character sees the world.	Cannot be unlearned. Roleplay is mandatory.
61	Memory Dissolution	Permanently -1 Wits. Character loses one specific skill memory (DA chooses a skill at rank 1-2; it drops to 0).	Cannot recover lost skill without retraining (Advancement Skill Retraining during downtime).
62	Identity Crisis	Character's Division Allegiance wavers. For the remainder of the current Case File, they cannot use Division Talents that cost Corruption to activate (their free foundational healing talent remains available). Restriction ends at the start of the next Case File.	Major roleplay scene with Covenant superior + Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 3).
63	Veil Madness	+4 Corruption immediately. Roll on this table again (ignore result 63 on reroll).	As per second roll result.
64	Prophetic Fugue †	Death check (mind). Surviving: +3 Corruption. Character enters a trance broadcasting the Covenant's location to hostile artifact entities until a Shielding ritual is performed.	Ritual seals the broadcast; Corruption remains.
65	Ego Death †	Death check (mind). Surviving: character personality fundamentally alters. Player rewrites one Drive and one aspect of their biography. +3 Corruption. Insight: +2 dice on all Empathy rolls (dissolution breeds radical compassion — or fearlessness).	Cannot be undone. Roleplay the new self.
66	Unraveling †	Automatic mind death check (no bonus). Surviving: +4 Corruption, -1 to every Attribute permanently, character retires at end of current mission (they cannot continue as an operative). Final scene before retirement should be played.	Retirement is farewell — play it well.

Psychoanalyze Campaign Treatment

Several Mental Critical Injuries require a Psychoanalyze campaign — a structured series of therapeutic sessions during downtime.

- The treating character (an ally with Psychoanalyze skill, or a Keep Empathy Specialist NPC) makes one Psychoanalyze (EMP) roll per downtime phase.
- Roll against the listed Difficulty (default: Difficulty 2 if not specified).
- Each success completes one required phase.
- On failure, the phase is wasted but may be retried next downtime.
- The patient cannot undertake other downtime activities during active treatment phases.

Format guide:

- "Psychoanalyze campaign (X downtime phases)" — X rolls at Difficulty 2 (default).
- "Psychoanalyze campaign (X downtime phases, Difficulty Y)" — X rolls at Difficulty Y.
- "Keep Psychoanalyze program" — same rules, but requires a Keep Empathy Specialist NPC as the treater. Player allies cannot provide this level of care. The Empathy Specialist is a Keep Staff NPC available at HQ ([Headquarters](#)).

8.5. Attribute Recovery

Attributes damaged during play (by physical or mental damage) recover over time. The process is separate from Corruption healing (see [Corruption and Healing](#)).

Standard Recovery

Recovery Type	Attributes Restored	Conditions
Short Rest (1 Shift)	1 point to each damaged attribute	Must be in a safe location (no active threat, no travel). 1 Shift ≈ 4 hours.
Full Downtime	All attribute damage cleared	Between Case Files — the team returns to base, rests, and recovers fully.
Medical Aid (Heal WIT check)	+1 point per success beyond Difficulty	Difficulty 1 for basic aid (cuts, bruises); Difficulty 2 for serious wounds; Difficulty 3 for critical injuries. Requires a First Aid Kit.

Broken Recovery

An attribute at 0 (Broken state) cannot recover through rest alone — the damage is too severe.

To recover from Broken:

1. An ally must succeed on a Heal (WIT) roll, Difficulty 2 (First Aid Kit required).
2. On success, the Broken attribute is restored to 1. The character is no longer Broken.
3. This takes a full Shift and requires the character to rest without interruption.
4. Each failed Heal attempt still requires the Shift of rest before retrying.

Night Terrors (Critical Injury result 21): A character with Night Terrors does not benefit from Short Rest recovery for Agility damage. Recovery is halved (1 point per 2 Shifts instead of 1 per Shift) until the Critical Injury is treated.

Infirmary (HQ Facility)

The Keep's Infirmary (HQ [Infirmary](#)) provides enhanced Short Rest recovery: 3 Attribute points per Shift instead of 1. This is what Ch 12 means by "2 additional Attribute points beyond normal rest" — the baseline 1 + 2 = 3.

8.6. Armor Mechanics

Armor protects against physical damage only. When an agent suffers physical damage targeting Strength or Agility, they roll Gear Dice equal to their Armor Rating. Mental damage (targeting Wits or Empathy) and Corruption damage bypass armor entirely — no amount of Kevlar protects the psyche.

1. When you suffer physical damage, roll a number of Gear Dice equal to the item's Armor Rating.
2. Every 6 rolled absorbs 1 point of incoming damage before it reduces your Strength.
3. **Degradation:** Armor Gear Dice do not degrade on every armor roll. Armor Rating decreases by 1 when: (a) the character pushes a roll while wearing the armor (the desperate effort strains the equipment), or (b) a Combat Stunt or Critical Injury specifically targets the armor. Armor uses flat AR decrement, not the Gear Die step chain used by weapons and tools — this is an exception noted in [Equipment](#).

Gear Dice cannot be pushed. When you push a roll, you reroll all non-6 dice from your Attribute and Skill pools. Gear Dice are never rerolled — they represent equipment performance, not personal effort. If the character pushes any roll while wearing armor, their armor Gear Dice degrade (Armor Rating -1).

Unified armor rule: Armor Rating is a flat number that decrements on qualifying events (pushes, targeted Combat Stunts, specific Critical Injuries). It does not use the Gear Die step chain

(d12 d10 etc.) that weapons and tools use. See [Equipment](#) for standard Gear Degradation rules.

CHAPTER 9. CORRUPTION AND HEALING

Corruption is Neon Relic's signature mechanic — a single ascending number that tracks the cumulative psychic toll of occult exposure, supernatural exertion, and sheer human desperation. It functions as an "inverse hit points" system: every push, every artifact activation, every encounter with the unnatural ratchets the number higher, and there is no coming back from the top.

9.1. The Corruption Track

Corruption starts at 0 and increases from there. It is gained directly from its sources and reduced (slowly) by its methods — there is no buffer, no cascade, and no shortcut.

Maximum Corruption Threshold = 10 + Empathy score

When a character's Corruption exceeds their threshold, their mind permanently fractures. The character enters a catatonic state and is immediately removed from the campaign.

Threshold modifiers stack on top of the base formula:

- Redundant Safeties talent (Stack Division): +2 to threshold (effective threshold = 12 + Empathy).
- Fracture Point Critical Injury (Result 45): -2 to threshold permanently (effective threshold = 8 + Empathy).
- Both modifiers apply simultaneously if relevant.

Retroactive threshold drop: If permanent Empathy loss (Critical Injury or other source) drops your Corruption Threshold below your current Corruption score, you must immediately attempt a Corruption Burst check. On failure, catatonia triggers at once. On success, you remain active but must reduce your Corruption below the new threshold by the end of the next session or face catatonia automatically.

When Corruption threshold is breached simultaneously with a physical Broken state, see the Simultaneous Injury Resolution rule in [Chapter 7: Health, Damage & Armor](#).

9.2. Sources of Corruption

Trigger	Corruption Gained	Description
Pushing a Roll	+1	Exerting your absolute limits invites psychic static.
Activating a Division Talent	+1 (or free)	Most talents that tap the supernatural exact a cost. Talents marked — in their Corruption Cost column are free to activate — healing and passive-support talents carry no Corruption. See each talent's entry in Talents .

Trigger	Corruption Gained	Description
Occult Exposure	+1 to +3	Witnessing entities, reading forbidden tomes, or being targeted by anomalous phenomena. DA sets severity.
Artifact Activation	+1 to +3	Utilizing an artifact's supernatural properties. Cost varies by artifact tier.
Corruption Burst (any 1s rolled)	+1	The mind cracks trying to process the unprocessable. See Corruption Burst rules below.
Failed Corruption Burst	+Burst Rating	On top of any 1s penalty. See Corruption Burst rules below.
Successful Psychoanalyze on contaminated NPC	+1	Reading a corrupted mind transfers a fragment. Unique: the only roll where success costs Corruption. See Social Conflict .
Other sources	Varies	Artifact emissions (passive auras, pulses, Corruption Cascade), creature passive Corruption, Mental Critical Injury results, ritual backlash, and specific supernatural interactions. See Artifacts , Health & Damage , and Bestiary for details.

9.3. Corruption Effects

Corruption	Stage	Mechanical & Narrative Consequence
1-3	Nosebleeds / Migraines	Intense intracranial pressure. Occasional bleeding and severe headaches. The character maintains control.
4-6	Auditory Hallucinations	Distinct whispers from the void — voices of the dead or entities from beyond. Mechanical: Once per session, the DA may describe a specific hallucination and require a Wits roll (Difficulty 1) to distinguish real from imagined. Failure = the character acts on the hallucination for one round.
7-9	Eldritch Tremors	Anomalous energy violently courses through the nervous system. Noticeable physical twitches develop. Mechanical: -1 die on Deft Hands and Firearms rolls. Visible tremors: NPCs and allies may notice. The character cannot fully conceal them.

Corruption	Stage	Mechanical & Narrative Consequence
10-12	Reality Distortion	The localized environment physically warps. Lights shatter, shadows stretch, electronics fry in the character's presence. Mechanical: Electronic Gear Dice in the character's possession degrade one step at the start of each scene. Allies in the same zone gain +1 Corruption at the start of each scene (contamination leaking outward).
13-14	Fugue States	A nearby entity or latent force begins seizing control of the character's motor functions. Lost time and memory gaps. Mechanical: At the start of each scene, the DA rolls a d6. On a 1-2, the character enters a brief fugue (DA controls character for one round; player does not remember it). This is distinct from the Panic Table Fugue (result 6), which is an acute one-time response — the stage Fugue is chronic and recurring.
15-17	Collapse of Self	The character's sense of personal identity begins to dissolve. They speak in third person, lose track of which memories are theirs, and may briefly mistake allies for entities. -1 die on all social skill rolls (they are visibly wrong). This range is only reachable by characters with the Redundant Safeties talent or similar threshold-expanding effects.
Exceeds Threshold	Catatonic Revelation	The character's mind completely breaks upon perceiving the underlying, terrifying geometry of the universe. Permanent catatonic state. Immediately removed from the campaign.

9.4. Healing Corruption

Because Corruption naturally builds toward lethal levels, characters must actively seek to heal their psychological wounds.

Methods of Recovery

Method	Effect	Requirements
Anchor Scene	Heal 1d4 Corruption	Once per session. Engage with your Anchor — a personal source of solace — in a safe, unhurried moment. Player describes the interaction. See detailed rules below.

Method	Effect	Requirements
Safe Scene Recovery	Heal 1 Corruption	Once per session. Dedicate a quiet scene to personal decompression — sleep, a meal, a walk, listening to music, a phone call with family. The scene must be safe (no active threats, no time pressure). Must be a different scene than the one used for an Anchor activation — the two recovery methods cannot share the same moment. No specific Anchor required; just the absence of pressure.
Full Rest (24 hours)	Heal Corruption equal to Empathy score	Full 24-hour cycle resting in a secure, non-anomalous location (defined as: no active artifact emissions, no supernatural entities, no uncontained occult material in the building). Covenant HQ with an active Faraday Cage qualifies. A hotel room or safe house qualifies. Full Rest is typically available only between Case Files or during extended downtime within a case (at DA discretion); it cannot be taken during an active shift. Faraday Cage stacking: Full Rest and the Faraday Cage (Headquarters) stack — a character who takes Full Rest at HQ with access to the Cage recovers Empathy score + up to 4 additional Corruption.
Healing Talents	Varies by talent	See Division Talents and General Talents marked with (Healing).

Anchor Scene vs. Safe Scene — what's the difference?

An Anchor Scene requires the character to actively engage with their personal source of solace — their Anchor. This might mean praying, running laps around the parking lot, playing guitar in the motel room, or calling a loved one. It heals more (1d4, potentially 2–4 Corruption) because it's doing psychological work — confronting the thing that grounds the agent to who they are outside the Covenant.

A Safe Scene requires only the absence of threat and pressure — no supernatural contact, no mission urgency. A character can share a meal, sit quietly, or simply sleep. It heals less (1 Corruption, flat) because it's passive recovery, not active processing.

Both count against the per-session active recovery cap of 5 Corruption. You may use both in the same

session, but they must be separate scenes.

Design note: Corruption healing is intentionally slow. An agent with Empathy 3 heals 3 Corruption per full day of rest — but gaining 3+ Corruption in a single scene is easy. The economy is deliberately asymmetric: you gain faster than you heal, and the only way to stay safe is to make fewer desperate choices.

Session cap math: From Ch 8 sources alone (Anchor + Safe Scene), the maximum in-session active recovery is up to $1d4 + 1 = 5$ Corruption. Division Healing talents ([Divisions](#) — Confessor, Gallows Humor, etc.) may add 1-4 additional Corruption healing per session depending on team composition. Between Case Files, HQ Facilities ([Headquarters](#) — Faraday Cage) provide further recovery. The Session Healing Cap (see below) ensures even optimal play cannot fully erase a bad session's Corruption.

Session Healing Cap: Regardless of all sources combined — Anchor Scenes, Safe Scenes, Talents (Confessor, Duct Tape & WD-40, etc.), or HQ Facilities (Faraday Cage) — an agent may heal no more than 5 Corruption per session from active in-session sources. Full Rest (24-hour downtime between sessions) is not subject to this cap. This cap enforces the asymmetric economy: even perfectly optimized play cannot fully reset Corruption within a single session. Multiple agents using Talents on the same target also count toward that target's session cap — not the user's.

Anchors

Every character begins with an Anchor — a personal source of solace that grounds the agent against the psychological toll of Covenant work. An Anchor is not a physical object; it is the practice, habit, or connection where the character finds peace. In a moment of quiet downtime, a character can dedicate a scene to engaging with their Anchor. This grounded roleplay provides powerful mechanical healing.

Anchor Scene Requirements:

- The character must actively engage with their Anchor — not just mention it. Pray, meditate, run, call a loved one, play an instrument, write in a journal.
- The scene must be safe — no active threats, no time pressure, no combat.
- The player should describe the interaction (at least a sentence or two of roleplay).
- Anchor scenes can occur during a Case File if the team has a genuine moment of safety (a secured safe house, a quiet vehicle, a defended position at the DA's discretion).
- If the Anchor becomes inaccessible: If circumstances deny the character access to their source of solace (e.g., a loved one dies, a faith is shaken by supernatural revelation, the character is isolated from all human contact), they cannot use this recovery method until they establish a new Anchor during a downtime phase — a meaningful roleplay scene with the DA. The new Anchor must feel earned, not transactional.
- One Anchor at a time. A character cannot maintain multiple Anchors.

Anchor Sources (Roll d66 or choose)

Roll	Category	Example Anchors
11-16	Faith / Spirituality	Prayer (any tradition). Lighting a candle for the dead. Reading scripture. Meditation with rosary beads. Visiting a church, mosque, or temple. A private ritual from a tradition nobody else at the table needs to understand.
21-22	Physical Exertion	Running laps. Push-ups until the shaking stops. Boxing a heavy bag. Swimming. The point is exhaustion — the body takes over when the mind won't stop.
23-24	Music / Art	Playing guitar in the motel room. Sketching in a field journal. Singing — badly, alone, in the car. Listening to a specific album that means something.
25-26	A Person	Calling your mother. Writing a letter to your daughter that you'll never send. Sitting with a teammate who doesn't need to talk. The person doesn't have to be alive — visiting a grave counts.
31-32	Routine / Ritual	Cleaning and maintaining your weapon. Cooking a specific meal. Ironing your shirt. The ritual matters because it's the same every time — the world is chaos, but this one thing is yours.
33-34	Logic / Rationalization	Writing out what happened in clinical language. Diagramming cause-and-effect until it makes sense. Convincing yourself it's all explainable. It isn't, but the exercise helps.
35-36	Substance	A drink. A cigarette. Something stronger. It works in the short term. The DA may eventually ask what happens when it stops working.
41-42	Nature / Solitude	Sitting outside at 3 AM. Watching the sunrise. Finding a park, a river, a patch of sky with no buildings. Silence and distance from anything human-made.
43-44	Animals	A stray cat that lives behind the motel. A dog you kept from a case that went wrong. Feeding pigeons in a plaza. Animals don't know what you've seen, and they don't care.
45-46	Writing / Journaling	A private journal. Poetry nobody reads. Letters to someone who won't write back. The act of putting it into words — even bad words — externalizes what's rattling inside.

Roll	Category	Example Anchors
51-52	Games / Puzzles	A Rubik's Cube. Crosswords. Chess by mail. Solitaire with a real deck. Something with rules and solutions — a closed system where effort produces results.
53-54	Memory / Nostalgia	Looking at photographs. Holding a keepsake. Replaying a specific moment — a birthday, a last good day, a conversation you keep returning to. The memory is the Anchor, not the object.
55-56	Humor / Connection	Telling jokes — bad ones, dark ones. Making someone laugh. Being around people who don't know what you do. Pretending, for an hour, that the world is normal.
61-62	Service / Helping	Fixing something for a stranger. Volunteering. Doing something kind that has nothing to do with the Covenant. Proof that you're still capable of ordinary good.
63-64	Professional Craft	Working with your hands — carpentry, electronics, mechanics. Building or repairing something that exists in the real world and stays fixed.
65-66	Denial / Compartmentalization	Refusing to think about it. Going to a bar and watching the game. Acting as though nothing happened. Not healthy, but functional. For now.

9.5. Corruption Burst

The Corruption track governs the long arc of psychological decay. A Corruption Burst governs the acute, in-the-moment shock of direct supernatural confrontation — what happens to your body and your mind in the next thirty seconds when reality breaks in front of you.

A Burst is not always fear. It might manifest as a wave of dread, static electricity crawling across skin, a cold mist rolling in, a nosebleed, a migraine spike, or a momentary sensory distortion where the room feels wrong in a way you can't articulate. The flavor varies by artifact and entity, but the mechanic is unified under Corruption.

What Triggers a Corruption Burst

The DA calls for a Corruption Burst when a character directly confronts a source of genuine supernatural phenomena. Not everything unusual triggers one — strange sounds, unusual smells, or reading an old text do not. A Burst requires direct sensory confrontation with something that violates the natural order.

Trigger	Examples
Encountering a supernatural entity	Seeing a bound entity, a possessed human, or a manifestation for the first time this scene
Artifact activation failure	An artifact the character is handling detonates, tears reality, or emits a vision that cannot be explained
Witnessing violent supernatural death	An ally or bystander is killed or consumed by occult means in front of the character
Occult revelation	Irrefutable proof of something the human mind cannot accommodate — a genuine miracle, an impossible geometry, a speaking dead
Sustained entity presence	For each additional round a character remains within Engaged range of an active, hostile entity (after the initial check)
Contact with contaminated minds	Attempting Psychoanalyze on an NPC with artifact exposure or long-term occult contamination. Burst Rating per DA (typically 1-2). See Social Conflict for Psychoanalyze procedure.

One check per trigger: If the same entity is already known to the character from a prior session and has been observed before, no new Burst is required merely for seeing it again — only for new escalations (it doing something new, getting closer, attacking, or changing in a way that increases its threat such as revealing a new form or escalating its Burst Rating).

Edge cases: A character who is Broken, unconscious, or in a Fugue panic state does not roll for Corruption Bursts. A character who failed a Burst check and is currently suffering a Panic result does not make additional checks until the Panic result ends. Sustained presence checks (each additional round) apply even to characters who succeeded on their initial check.

The Corruption Burst Procedure

Corruption Bursts are a special binary roll. They do not use the standard Difficulty system from [Core Resolution](#).

1. The DA calls for a Corruption Burst when a character directly confronts supernatural phenomena.
2. Roll dice equal to your current Wits attribute (no skill modifier — the mind's response to the impossible is instinctual, not trained).
3. One or more 6s = success. You hold it together.
4. Any 1s rolled (one or more) = +1 Corruption. Only one Corruption regardless of how many 1s. This applies whether the check succeeded or failed.
5. No 6s = failure. Gain Corruption equal to the Burst Rating of the source AND roll d6 on the Panic Table.

Corruption Bursts cannot be pushed and cannot receive helping dice.

The supernatural overwhelms the rational mind — there is no "trying harder" against something that violates physical law. Pushing assumes deliberate effort; that option does not exist when the primal response has already engaged. Similarly, no ally can steady your mind against a direct encounter with the impossible. The Psychoanalyze skill and certain Talents address the aftermath of a failed Burst (see Panic Table and Healing Talents) — but they cannot intervene in the moment between perception and reaction.

Four Outcomes

Rolled 6s?	Rolled 1s?	Result
Yes	No	Clean pass. No consequence.
Yes	Yes	Pass, but +1 Corruption. The exposure marks you.
No	No	Fail. +Burst Rating Corruption + Panic Table.
No	Yes	Worst case. +1 Corruption (from 1s) + Burst Rating Corruption (from failure) + Panic Table.

Why higher Wits means more Corruption on success: Rolling more dice increases both the chance of a 6 (success) and the chance of a 1 (Corruption). A Wits-5 character who succeeds on a Burst check has a ~60% chance of still gaining +1 Corruption from the 1s rider. This is intentional — sharper minds process more of what they saw, and that awareness has a cost. Supernatural exposure is never free. The consolation is that Wits 5 characters almost never fail the check entirely.

Why Wits? The Burst strikes the rational, pattern-recognizing mind first. The brain tries to explain what the eyes are seeing — and fails. Empathy governs emotional processing (grief, bargaining, despair); that comes later, through the Corruption track's long-term effects.

Why can't I push or get help on a Corruption Burst?

Corruption Bursts deliberately break the standard resolution pattern. Every other roll lets you apply training and experience — that's what skills are for. The Burst is different. No training prepares the human mind for direct sensory confrontation with something that violates natural law. The Wits-only roll represents your rational mind, stripped of professional scaffolding, trying to hold itself together. Skills can't help. Other people can't help.

What can help is recovery: Psychoanalyze and Healing Talents address the aftermath of panic, not the moment of confrontation. Presence, preparation, and swift containment reduce the number of Bursts you're forced to face — the best defense is never being in a position to need the roll.

The Panic Table

On a failed Corruption Burst (no 6s), roll d6:

Roll	Response	What Happens
1	Fight	Attack nearest creature (ally or foe) with bare hands. Cannot use weapons. Resolve as a single Brawl attack: Agility + Brawl skill dice (no Gear Dice — bare hands only, unarmed damage = 1). Ends automatically after the single strike.
2	Flight	Run at maximum speed (2 zones per round) away from the source for 1d6 rounds, or until reaching a dead end. Drop held items when the panic begins. An ally may physically restrain the fleeing character (opposed Brawl/Force roll, spending a Slow Action).
3	Freeze	Paralyzed. Cannot move, speak, or act. Allies can move the character (Slow Action). Exit: An ally spends a Slow Action and makes a Psychoanalyze (EMP) roll (Difficulty 1) to snap them out, OR the source is no longer visible.
4	Denial	Treat the supernatural as mundane for rest of scene. Cannot acknowledge entity as real. Early exit: An ally may attempt Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) to break denial. On success, character acknowledges the entity but is Shaken (-1 die on all rolls for the remainder of the scene).
5	Compulsion	Locked in repetitive behavior. Cannot take meaningful action until ally Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 2) frees them.
6	Fugue	DA takes character sheet. DA narrates character for rest of scene. Player regains control next scene. Early exit: An ally may attempt Psychoanalyze (Difficulty 3) to recover the character mid-scene. On success, the player regains control but is disoriented (-2 dice on all rolls for the remainder of the scene).

Panic Attacks Against Allies

When a Fight panic result targets another agent, resolve it as a single Brawl attack: Agility + Brawl skill dice (no Gear Dice — bare hands only). The target may Dodge (spending their Fast Action as normal) but cannot Parry — the attack is a surprise strike with no warning (treat as a surprise attack per [Combat: Surprise](#); Parry requires anticipation that the attack is coming). The panicked agent cannot spend stunt points, cannot push the roll, and cannot continue attacking after the initial strike. After the single attack resolves (hit or miss), the panic breaks and the agent regains control on their next turn, disoriented but aware of what they did.

If the attack Breaks the target, proceed with normal Broken/Critical Injury rules. The panicked agent gains +1 Corruption from the guilt of harming an ally.

Burst Ratings

Burst Rating is how the DA classifies the supernatural intensity of a creature or event on a 1–5 scale. It appears in Bestiary stat blocks and determines how much Corruption a failed Burst check inflicts.

What Burst Rating does mechanically:

- Burst Rating 0 = this entity or event does not trigger a Corruption Burst. No check is called.
- Burst Rating 1–5 = this entity or event triggers a Corruption Burst when a character first directly confronts it. On failure, the agent gains Corruption equal to the Burst Rating.
- Burst Rating does not modify the dice pool or success threshold — the roll is always Wits dice, binary success. The Rating determines the consequences of failure.

Escalation: Some creatures have a Burst Rating that increases during an encounter (e.g., "Burst Rating 2 initially; 4 once its nature is understood"). An escalation is a new trigger per the rule above — it calls for a new check even if the character has already made one this scene. An escalation includes: the entity doing something new, getting closer, attacking, revealing a new form, or increasing its Burst Rating.

DA Frequency Guidance: Burst Rating 1–2 — call for one check on first direct confrontation per scene. Burst Rating 3–4 — call for a check each time the entity acts directly against a character (not just passive presence). Burst Rating 5 — call for a check every round the entity is within sight. These are guidelines, not hard rules; the DA adjusts for pacing.

Rating	Threat Level	Examples
1	Unsettling	A shadow that moves wrong. A sound that shouldn't exist. A photograph with an extra figure.
2	Disturbing	A possessed civilian. A minor entity (shadow-form, bound spirit). A fresh, inexplicably ritualistic death scene.
3	Horrifying	A mid-tier entity fully manifested. An artifact consuming a living person. A Covenant vault breach in progress.
4	Shattering	A major entity (ancient, named, deliberate). An artifact performing an impossible act of scale (restructuring a room, erasing a person).
5	Annihilating	A Class-5 entity. A tear in physical space. Direct contact with whatever the artifacts are for.

Burst Ratings are a property of supernatural entities and events, not of individual characters. Add the Burst Rating stat to entity stat blocks in the Bestiary ([Bestiary](#)).

9.6. Attribute Healing

This chapter covers Corruption healing. Attribute damage (Strength, Agility, Wits, Empathy) is healed separately through rest and medical treatment:

- Field treatment and First Aid: See [Health, Damage & Armor Attribute Recovery](#).
- Downtime recovery at HQ: See [Headquarters Infirmary](#).
- Psychoanalyze for mental attribute recovery (Wits/Empathy): See the Psychoanalyze skill in [Attributes & Skills](#).



CLASSIFIED

PART IV — THE WORLD OF NEON RELIC

Classification: Secret — Clearance Level 2+ Required
Distribution: Restricted — Need-to-Know Basis



IMAGE PLACEHOLDER

176 mm × 120 mm

CHAPTER 10. COVENANT DIVISIONS

In Project Neon Relic, players are sworn members of The Verdant Covenant. Because no single person possesses the brains, brawn, network, and magical guardianship required to hunt dangerous artifacts, players choose a Division (their core class) which dictates their starting attributes, skills, and Clearance Level (CL). A Division marks expertise and responsibility, not a higher power tier than the danger facing the cell.

Within that Division, players select a Department background. At character creation, agents choose three starting talents:

- One Division Talent — chosen from the Division's talent list in this chapter — or one General Talent from [Advancement and Talents](#).
- One Wing, Paradigm, or Department Talent — chosen from the talent list of the specific Wing, Paradigm, or Department the agent belongs to in this chapter.
- One Background Talent — chosen from the Background Talents list in [Advancement and Talents](#).

Most Division and sub-unit Talents cost +1 Corruption to activate, feeding directly into the game's risk-reward loop. Each talent list includes one Healing talent usable freely once per session.

Corruption cost summary: Talents marked with +1 Corruption in the Cost column require gaining 1 Corruption to activate. Talents marked with — are free to use — these are always passive effects, per-session healing talents, or reactions that carry no Corruption cost. This distinction is consistent across all Division and sub-unit lists. Healing talents are specifically noted with the (Healing) tag and are always free.

Unless a Talent explicitly says otherwise, read these abilities as scene-shaping leverage, not complete scene resolution. They should reveal a lead, buy time, create access, or improve odds under pressure rather than trivialize artifacts, rivals, or core investigation procedures.

Design note — healing talent triggers: Each Division and sub-unit has one (Healing) talent. Trigger conditions vary intentionally: some require a completed field action (covert objective, combat win), others spend a Shift in deliberate recovery activity. The principle is that the trigger should match each sub-unit's operational philosophy — a Wayfinder heals through learning, a Recovery agent heals through action, a Keeper heals through duty. If a specific session's circumstances make a healing trigger unreachable, the DA may rule a comparable equivalent (e.g., a Warden who performed emergency vault security during active combat may count that as a completed "guard mission").

Covenant Organizational Structure

The Verdant Covenant

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Global Structure

The Verdant Covenant operates across five continents through a cellular structure designed to maintain operational secrecy. No single member — not even the most senior leadership — knows the full scope of the organization.

Tier	Description	Approximate Count
Central Council	The governing body. Location unknown to field agents. Communicates only through intermediaries. Sets strategic priorities, arbitrates inter-division disputes, and authorizes Tier 3 artifact operations.	7-12 members

Tier	Description	Approximate Count
Regional Hubs	Continental coordination centers managing cells within a geographic zone. Each hub has a Regional Director (one per Division) who handles assignment routing, resource allocation, and inter-cell mediation. Hubs are not permanent buildings — they rotate locations every 18-24 months.	6 hubs (Americas, Europe, Africa/Middle East, Central Asia, East Asia/Pacific, Oceania)
Field Cells	The operational units. Each cell is assigned a home city and operates semi-autonomously within its region. Cells do not know each other's locations unless leadership authorizes contact.	~80-120 active cells globally
Extended Network	Civilian contacts, academic consultants, sympathetic law enforcement, and retired agents who provide intelligence and logistical support without being sworn members. They know pieces of the truth — never the whole picture.	~400-600 individuals

Total active personnel: Approximately 500-700 sworn members globally, plus the extended network. For an organization protecting the world from supernatural threats, this is a skeleton crew — and that's the point. The Covenant cannot afford to be large. Every new member is a potential leak, a potential compromise, a potential vessel for Corruption. Growth is slow, vetting is brutal, and attrition is constant.

Secrecy at scale: The Covenant survives because of three structural safeguards: (1) cellular isolation — cells cannot contact each other without hub authorization; (2) cover diversity — the organization has no unified public identity, no logo, no letterhead; and (3) plausible deniability — the extended network believes they're helping a private research foundation, a government intelligence subcontractor, or an eccentric philanthropist. The truth is compartmentalized so thoroughly that even a captured and interrogated agent can only compromise their own cell and their regional hub contact.

Inter-Division Dynamics

The three Divisions are not a harmonious machine. They are three departments within a clandestine organization under constant pressure, and they behave accordingly.

Why Divisions Sometimes Pursue the Same Artifact

It happens more often than leadership would like:

- Competing intelligence. A Wayfinder Research Wing identifies an artifact through historical records. Simultaneously, a Counterintelligence Wing detects a rival faction moving on the same artifact through signals intelligence. Both routes generate a case — and both routes reach different regional hubs before anyone cross-references.
- Different threat assessments. The Keep classifies an artifact as contained (stable, in a museum, not actively dangerous). A Wayfinder analysis disagrees — the artifact is dormant, not contained, and will wake up. Both assessments are valid. Both generate operational responses.
- Bureaucratic friction. A Recovery cell recovers an artifact and begins transport. A Keep team arrives claiming they have transfer authority. Both have legitimate paperwork. The regional hub issued contradictory orders because two Directors signed off on different operational plans.

This is not a bug in the Covenant's structure — it's an unavoidable consequence of compartmentalization. The same secrecy that protects the organization from external threats creates internal blind spots.

When Competition Helps

- Redundancy. If one cell fails, the other is already in position. The Covenant loses fewer artifacts to single points of failure.
- Accountability. Cells that know another team is watching perform better. Sloppy containment gets reported.
- Fresh perspective. A Wayfinder team and a Recovery team approach the same problem differently. Sometimes the answer requires both approaches.

When Competition Hurts

- Friendly fire. Two cells operating on the same target without knowing each other's identities can and do interfere with each other's operations. In extreme cases, they've fought.
- Resource waste. Two cells burning DP, contacts, and cover identities on the same artifact is expensive for an organization that can't afford waste.
- Standing games. Cells competing for the same artifact are also competing for Standing. The temptation to sabotage a rival cell's operation — even subtly, even passively — is real.

How Leadership Mediates

When overlapping operations are discovered:

1. The Regional Director for the affected zone contacts both cells and issues a priority ruling — one cell takes point, the other supports or withdraws.

2. If the cells are in different regions, the Central Council arbitrates. This takes time. The artifact doesn't wait.
3. In practice, the cell that's closest to containment usually wins priority. The other cell is reassigned with +1 DP as compensation for operational disruption.

Design note for DAs: Inter-division tension is a rich source of Case File complications. A rival Covenant cell showing up mid-operation — are they here to help or to take over? — creates drama that doesn't require supernatural threats. Use it sparingly (once per arc at most) but don't avoid it.

10.4. Division 1: The Wayfinder

"What is found must be known."

The Wayfinder Division serves as the primary investigative arm of the Covenant. Wayfinders are scholars, hackers, and researchers whose directive is uncovering the existence and historical locations of lost artifacts before rival factions do. They work to assemble and preserve knowledge from historical records, archaeological reports, religious texts, folklore, academic publications, government archives, museum collections, and contemporary news reporting.

Wayfinder Key Stats

Primary Attribute	Wits (guidance, not a rule — see note below)
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Lore
Starting Clearance Level	3



Primary Attribute: "Primary Attribute" in the Key Stats tables is a design recommendation, not a mechanical rule. It describes the attribute most central to a Division's playstyle and is intended as guidance for players deciding where to invest Attribute points — it does not grant any inherent bonus.

Key Skill: Each Division has one Key Skill that may be raised to 4 during character creation (the normal cap is 3). This represents the Division's signature competency.

The Verdant Codex (Division Item)

All Wayfinders bear the Verdant Codex, an enchanted field journal for recording discoveries. The Codex provides the following benefits:

- Writing in the Codex secures knowledge in the memory of the author
- Maintains historical records in an organized and cataloged fashion
- Assists in decoding languages and symbols
- Automatically preserves documents placed within its pages
- Stores large scrolls without damage
- Faintly glows near ancient magic
- Contains a living map lining that slowly reveals suspected artifact correlations and previously researched sites

Codex mechanical functions:

- **Research bonus:** Once per scene, when making a Lore (WIT) or Investigate (WIT) roll supported by notes you've written in the Codex, gain +1 bonus die.
- **Lore preservation:** Any Lore (WIT) roll that succeeds while using the Codex automatically records the result — the DA must confirm that the information cannot be "forgotten" by later Corruption or injury effects.

Wayfinder Wings

Research Wing

The Research Wing is responsible for the discovery, documentation, and verification of artifacts. Research personnel identify artifacts before they are lost, misused, or fall into the possession of hostile actors.

Specialty	Description
Research Desk Analyst	Focuses on research within Covenant archives and partner repositories. Studies historical documents, translates ancient texts, analyzes cultural and religious records, and monitors scholarly publications. Maintains artifact catalogues, cross-references historical reports, and identifies patterns indicating the presence of significant artifacts.
Research Field Analyst	Conducts investigative work outside Covenant facilities. Visits archaeological sites, examines ruins, interviews scholars or local witnesses, and verifies Desk Analyst intelligence. Gathers firsthand observations, photographic documentation, and environmental readings.
Research Liaison	Embeds with academic institutions, museums, and partner agencies to cultivate intelligence relationships through official channels. Maintains scholarly cover identities, attends conferences, and routes actionable field intelligence back to the Desk.



Research personnel do not retrieve artifacts. Once an artifact's existence and location have been confirmed, the Wing prepares a formal assessment and forwards the case to the Recovery Division.

Research Wing Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Pattern Recognition	+1 Corruption	When examining a document, site, or artifact for the first time, identify one plausible connection to a previously catalogued case — the DA must reveal a useful lead, not the entire answer.
Deep Archive Access	+1 Corruption	Spend an action consulting restricted Covenant records. Gain +2 bonus dice on your next Lore or Investigate roll this scene.
Methodical Review (Healing)	—	Spend a Shift organizing and cross-referencing your field notes. Heal 1 Corruption and grant one ally +1 bonus die on their next Investigate roll.

Counterintelligence Wing

The Counterintelligence Wing protects the Covenant from external threats and preserves the secrecy of the organization's existence, operations, and holdings. The Wing maintains continuous surveillance of known and emerging groups with an interest in relic acquisition, including rival secret societies, criminal networks, illicit antiquities traffickers, extremist religious movements, and private collectors.

Specialty	Description
Counterintelligence Desk Analyst	Monitors global communications, public records, academic publications, and intelligence reports for indications that artifacts have been discovered, trafficked, or targeted. Maintains profiles of known rival organizations, tracks patterns of artifact-related activity, and compiles threat analyses.
Counterintelligence Field Analyst	Operates outside Covenant facilities to investigate threats directly. Conducts surveillance of suspicious organizations, infiltrates groups seeking artifacts, observes illicit antiquities markets, and disrupts activities that could expose the Covenant. May be authorized to engage hostiles when necessary.
Counterintelligence Technical Analyst	Specializes in signals intelligence, electronic surveillance, and cryptographic analysis of intercepted communications. Operates wire-taps, intercepts radio traffic, and deciphers coded correspondence from rival factions and hostile actors.



Through the vigilance of the Counterintelligence Wing, the Covenant ensures that what is known remains contained, and that those who would misuse the past are stopped before they can act.

Counterintelligence Wing Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Burned Asset	+1 Corruption	When caught in a lie or exposed during infiltration, immediately generate a plausible cover story. The target must make an Empathy (Psychoanalyze) roll at Difficulty 2 to see through it.
Signal Intercept	+1 Corruption	Tap into a nearby communication channel (radio, phone line, intercom). For the remainder of the scene, you overhear all traffic on that channel.
Compartmentalized Mind (Healing)	—	Once per session, after completing a successful counterintelligence action (surveillance, interrogation, or exposure prevention), heal 1 Corruption.

Wayfinder Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
The Antiquarian's Eye	+1 Corruption	On first inspection, identify either an artifact's activation trigger or its base effect without a Lore roll.
Ghost in the Machine	+1 Corruption	Use Tech to read data from electronic devices jammed or possessed by anomalous entities, bypassing the entity's interference.
The Hunch	+1 Corruption	Ask the DA one yes/no question about a crime scene or NPC's motive. The DA must answer truthfully.
Academic Grounding (Healing)	—	Spend an hour researching an entity and framing it in academic terms. Heal 1 Corruption for yourself or one ally.
Eldritch Empathy	+1 Corruption	Sense the immediate emotional state, hunger, or primary intent of an invisible or disguised supernatural entity.

10.5. Division 2: The Recovery

"What is known must be contained."

The Recovery Division serves as the field arm of the Verdant Covenant. Where the Wayfinders uncover knowledge and the Keep guards what has already been secured, the Recovery Division is

responsible for bringing artifacts safely into Covenant custody.

Recovery agents operate in the world beyond the Covenant’s halls, traveling wherever relics are rumored to exist. They investigate ruins, ancient vaults, forgotten temples, private collections, corporate archives, black markets, and the holdings of religious or political institutions. Their mandate is simple and absolute: recover the object and return it to the Covenant.

Recovery agents are trained to operate in a wide variety of environments. Some recover artifacts from abandoned ruins and dangerous landscapes. Others negotiate with collectors, institutions, or governments. At times, they must retrieve relics from those who knowingly misuse them or seek to exploit their power. Characters here often come from military or law enforcement backgrounds.



Unlike other Divisions, the Recovery Division has no internal departments. Every member shares the same purpose and authority. Instead, agents are distinguished by their operational paradigm and the specialty within it.

Recovery Key Stats

Primary Attribute	Agility (guidance, not a rule — see note in Wayfinder Key Stats)
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Firearms
Starting Clearance Level	2

The Verdant Satchel (Division Item)

All Recovery agents carry the Verdant Satchel, a specially enchanted field bag designed to safely transport relics. The Satchel provides the following benefits:

- Suppresses the magical aura of items placed inside
- Warns when nearby artifacts become unstable
- Allows temporary sealing of cursed items
- Contains a small dimensional containment compartment
- Keeps a small selection of ordinary field tools immediately accessible (rope, chalk, spikes, vials, etc.)
- Enchantment of Warding obscures any magical object placed inside from detection

Satchel mechanical functions:

- **Aura suppression:** Artifacts inside the Satchel do not emit passive Corruption to nearby characters. Remove passive aura triggers for as long as the artifact remains sealed inside.
- **Instability warning:** When an artifact inside the Satchel approaches a Volatile or

Catastrophic rating (per the Catalogers' classification system), the Satchel becomes warm and vibrates — a warning sign the agent can detect without a roll, giving time to stop and reassess.

- **Artifact stabilization:** Once per scene, delay an artifact's activation or emission by one round without a roll — giving the team a brief window to react before the effect triggers.

Recovery Paradigms

Choose one paradigm that defines your agent's prior experience:

Ex-Agency Operative

Former intelligence or special forces. Trained in infiltration, extraction, and covert operations.

Specialty	Description
Handler	Runs covert assets and informants. Expert in managing human intelligence networks, dead drops, and clandestine communications. Coordinates with Wayfinder Counterintelligence when operations overlap.
Breacher	Specializes in hostile entry and extraction under fire. Trained in demolitions, close-quarters combat, and rapid building clearance. First through the door when negotiations fail.
Ghost	Operates deep undercover for extended periods. Maintains false identities, embeds within hostile organizations, and reports intelligence without breaking cover.

Ex-Agency Operative Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Dead Drop Protocol	+1 Corruption	Establish an instant covert information exchange with any NPC contact. Gain one actionable piece of intelligence from the DA without a roll.
Exfiltration Specialist	+1 Corruption	When retreating or extracting under fire, you and all allies within Short range gain +1 bonus die to their next Agility roll this round.
Spycraft Discipline (Healing)	—	Once per session, after successfully completing a covert objective without being detected, heal 1 Corruption.

Heavy-Hitter (Brawler)

Brute-force specialist. Comfortable in direct violent confrontation above all else.

Specialty	Description
Enforcer	The Covenant's blunt instrument for hostile recovery operations. Specializes in intimidation, physical domination, and overwhelming force when artifacts are held by armed or dangerous opposition.
Close Protection	Bodyguard and security specialist. Shields Recovery teams and high-value Covenant personnel during dangerous field operations. Trained to absorb punishment and keep others alive.
Wrecker	Expert in destruction and demolition. Removes structural obstacles, breaches fortified positions, and disables vehicles or equipment. When the path forward is blocked, the Wrecker opens it.

Heavy-Hitter Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Wrecking Ball	+1 Corruption	When attacking an inanimate object or structure (door, wall, barricade, vehicle), gain +3 bonus dice to the Force roll and inflict +2 damage on a success.
Stand Your Ground	+1 Corruption	Plant yourself and refuse to move. Until your next turn, you cannot be pushed, knocked down, or forcibly moved, and you gain +2 Armor Rating.
Blunt Trauma Recovery (Healing)	—	Once per session, after winning a physical confrontation through brute force, heal 1 Corruption.

Acquisition Specialist (Thief)

Expert in bypassing security, stealing valuable objects, and getting in and out unseen.

Specialty	Description
Infiltrator	Defeats physical and electronic security systems. Expert in lock-picking, alarm bypass, safe-cracking, and navigating laser grids, pressure plates, and motion detectors.
Grifter	Operates through social engineering and deception. Assumes false identities, manipulates targets through conversation, and acquires access through charm, forgery, or confidence games.
Wheelman	Specialist driver, pilot, and escape planner. Handles pursuit, evasion, and extraction logistics. Ensures the team reaches the target and leaves cleanly with the artifact.

Acquisition Specialist Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Ghost Entry	+1 Corruption	Bypass a single ordinary locked door, security system, or physical barrier without a roll. Against hardened or anomalous protection, you may spend additional Corruption (1 per required success) to bypass it instead of rolling. Leave no trace of entry.
The Long Con	+1 Corruption	After at least one scene spent building rapport with an NPC, gain +3 bonus dice on a Manipulate roll to extract one specific piece of information or gain one specific favor.
Clean Getaway (Healing)	—	Once per session, after successfully completing a theft, infiltration, or escape without triggering an alarm, heal 1 Corruption.

Recovery Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Conditioned Mind	—	Declare before you push the roll. Once per session, you may push a roll and entirely ignore the +1 Corruption that pushing costs. The push happens normally; only the Corruption is negated. This is not retroactive — if you push without declaring Conditioned Mind first, the Corruption is already spent.
Unstoppable Force	+1 Corruption	Your next successful melee or unarmed attack inflicts +2 damage.
Shadow Walker	+1 Corruption	For the duration of a scene, you are entirely imperceptible to mundane guards and cameras — they do not see you, register you on film, or notice your presence. Limitations: (1) Attacking breaks the effect immediately and it cannot be reactivated this scene. (2) Speaking to, touching, or otherwise interacting with an NPC in a way that demands acknowledgment breaks the effect for that NPC only. (3) Supernatural perception (entities with non-human senses, artifact-enhanced security, possessed observers) is not fooled — Shadow Walker only bypasses mundane human and electronic detection.
Adrenaline Junkie	—	When your Strength has taken at least 1 point of damage (i.e., your current Strength is below your starting score), gain +2 bonus dice to all Agility rolls. This bonus applies for as long as your Strength remains below its normal value and disappears once Strength is fully healed.

Talent	Cost	Effect
Gallows Humor (Healing)	—	Once per session, immediately after a combat encounter ends (all hostiles are neutralized, fled, or surrendered), crack a dark joke about what just happened. You and all allies who can hear you (same zone or adjacent zone) heal 1d4 Corruption. "Surviving" means the encounter ended without the team being captured or forced to flee the scene. This talent cannot trigger during a chase or while combat is ongoing.
Combat Reflexes	—	When initiative cards are drawn, draw two cards and keep one. Discard the other face-down. Alternatively, after all cards are drawn, you may swap your initiative card with a willing ally's card.

10.6. Division 3: The Keep

"What is contained must be guarded."

The Keep serves as the custodial authority of the Verdant Covenant. Once artifacts have been recovered and delivered to Covenant custody, responsibility for their handling, documentation, containment, and protection is transferred to the Keep.

Members of the Keep are entrusted with the stewardship of the Covenant's most sensitive holdings. Their work ensures that artifacts — whether magical, religious, occult, or culturally significant — are properly cataloged, secured, and prevented from causing harm.

Keep Key Stats

Primary Attribute	Empathy (guidance, not a rule — see note in Wayfinder Key Stats)
Key Skill (Cap 4 at creation)	Command
Starting Clearance Level	3

The Warden's Bracer (Division Item)

All Keepers wear the Warden's Bracer, marking them as guardians of the Covenant's vaults. The Bracer symbolizes that the Keeper is bound to guard what others must never wield. It provides the following benefits:

- Dampens artifact emissions in close proximity long enough for controlled handling
- Warns the wearer if containment fails
- Allows safe handling of cursed objects

The Bracer has two distinct mechanical functions:

- **Armor:** +1 Armor Rating (applies to physical damage only, following standard armor rules in [Health, Damage & Armor](#))
- **Corruption Absorption:** Once per session, passively absorbs 1 point of Corruption that would be gained from any source. This does not require activation — the Bracer intercepts the first Corruption point automatically. This ability refreshes each session.

Keep Departments

The Department of Catalogers

The Catalogers are responsible for the documentation, classification, and containment planning of all artifacts. Every item recovered by the Recovery Division is delivered first to the Catalogers for formal intake. They maintain the Covenant’s master artifact registry — detailing origin, cultural context, physical properties, historical significance, and known risks for each artifact in custody.

The Department also designs containment chambers tailored to each artifact’s characteristics: sealed vaults, protective casings, environmental stabilization systems, isolation chambers, or other specialized safeguards. Catalogers conduct periodic inspections to verify that artifacts remain secure and containment measures remain effective.

Specialty	Description
Intake Officer	First point of contact for newly recovered artifacts. Assesses risk level, initiates containment protocol, performs initial hazard classification, and opens the formal Registry entry.
Archivist	Maintains the Covenant’s master artifact registry. Expert in historical context, cultural origin, and known hazard documentation. Coordinates with Wayfinder records to verify provenance and cross-reference research findings.
Containment Architect	Designs and maintains the specialized vaults, sealed chambers, and environmental stabilization systems that keep artifacts secure. Conducts periodic inspections and redesigns containment when artifact behavior changes or escalates.

Cataloger Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Hazard Classification	+1 Corruption	Upon first contact with an unknown artifact, instantly determine its danger rating (Inert / Active / Volatile / Catastrophic) and one primary containment requirement — no roll needed.

Talent	Cost	Effect
Registry Cross-Reference	+1 Corruption	Consult the master artifact registry to identify a connection between the current artifact and a previously catalogued item. The DA must reveal one actionable link.
Archival Calm (Healing)	—	Spend a Shift updating the artifact registry with new findings. Heal 1 Corruption and grant one ally who contributed field data +1 bonus die on their next Lore roll.

The Wardens

The Wardens serve as the defensive arm of the Keep. They are responsible for the physical protection of Covenant facilities, personnel, and artifact vaults. Primary duties include:

- Guarding headquarters, satellite facilities, and vault complexes
- Enforcing access protocols and escorting authorized personnel through sensitive areas
- Responding to security incidents
- Coordinating with Counterintelligence on infiltration threats
- Conducting field operations to disrupt hostile activities or recover stolen property when credible threats emerge

Specialty	Description
Vault Guardian	Stationed within Covenant facilities. Responsible for physical security of vaults and sensitive areas. First responders to containment failures, breaches, or unauthorized access events.
Escort Warden	Accompanies artifact transports and personnel through restricted or external environments. Provides mobile security during inter-facility transfers and high-clearance field movements.
Field Warden	Deploys externally when hostile threats escalate beyond passive monitoring. Conducts disruption operations against rival factions and recovers property stolen from Covenant custody.



Through the actions of the Wardens, the Verdant Covenant ensures that what is contained remains guarded, and that those who would misuse the relics of the past are prevented from doing so.

Warden Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Lockdown	+1 Corruption	Seal a room, corridor, or building entrance. No entity — mundane or supernatural — may pass through it for one full round without making a Strength (Force) roll at Difficulty 2.
Threat Assessment	+1 Corruption	When entering a new area, instantly identify the single greatest physical threat present (hostile actor, structural weakness, hidden trap). The DA must describe it.
Sentinel's Vigil (Healing)	—	Once per session, after completing a guard shift, patrol, or escort mission without a security breach, heal 1 Corruption.

Internal Counterintelligence

Working in coordination with the Wayfinder Division's Counterintelligence Wing, Internal CI agents investigate individuals or groups seeking to infiltrate the Covenant, steal artifacts, or expose the organization. They safeguard the Covenant's secrecy by identifying information leaks, preventing public exposure of operations, and ensuring that knowledge of sensitive artifacts remains tightly controlled.

Specialty	Description
Counter-Exposure Analyst	Monitors internal communications and personnel behavior for signs of information leaks, unauthorized disclosure, or ideological compromise. Conducts silent internal audits and compiles findings for Warden action.
Infiltration Investigator	Investigates active external threats against Covenant facilities, personnel, or networks. Tracks hostile actors, builds operational cases against suspected infiltrators, and coordinates takedowns with the Wardens.
Vetting Officer	Conducts background assessments and ongoing clearance monitoring for Covenant recruits and active personnel. Identifies vulnerabilities and security risks before they can be exploited by rival factions.

Internal CI Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Silent Audit	+1 Corruption	Gain access to one person's recent communications, personnel file, or activity log without their knowledge. The DA must reveal one compromising or actionable detail. This talent can target anyone, including fellow Covenant agents, though doing so may have consequences.

Talent	Cost	Effect
Loyalty Test	+1 Corruption	During a conversation, make a concealed Empathy roll at +2 bonus dice to determine if the target is actively deceiving, withholding critical information, or operating under external influence.
Debriefing Protocol (Healing)	—	Once per session, after conducting a successful internal investigation or clearing a suspect, heal 1 Corruption.

Stack (Logistics Department)

"Queue up, agents."

The Department of Logistics — informally known as "Stack" — is a department of the Keep composed of technicians, quartermasters, archivists of equipment, engineers, and inventors who maintain the Covenant's stores of specialized gear.

Stack is not a separate playable Division. Agents choose The Keep at character creation, then select Stack as their department if they want the Covenant's logistics, engineering, and requisition-focused play style.



Origin of the name: During the global espionage boom of the 1970s, younger Recovery agents began jokingly referring to Logistics as the "Q Department," a nod to the famous James Bond armorer. Given the notoriously long requisition lines outside the Logistics offices, the nickname evolved into "Queue." Over time, Covenant humor shortened it further, and the department became known as Stack — a name that has endured ever since.

Stack agents design, modify, and distribute the tools used by Covenant agents — from standard field supplies to experimental devices developed specifically for artifact recovery and containment. Though rarely leaving Covenant facilities themselves, Stack agents ensure that when Recovery teams enter the field, they do so properly equipped for whatever dangers await.

Specialty	Description
The Quartermaster	Manages the Covenant's equipment stores. Expert in acquisition, logistics, and knowing exactly what's available.
The Retro-Engineer	Specializes in modifying and repairing existing technology. Can coax impossible performance from aging hardware.
The Paratech Inventor	Designs entirely new experimental devices that blend analog technology with paranatural principles.

Stack Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)



Design note — talent count: Stack has six talent options compared to three for

every other sub-unit. This is intentional. Stack's role is the most operationally broad of any Keep department — covering logistics, repair, modification, invention, and field support. The wider talent list reflects Stack's unique position as the Covenant's primary technical backbone, with different agents specializing in very different aspects of the department's work.

Talent	Cost	Effect
Requisition Expert	+1 Corruption	During the Equipping Phase, automatically acquire any one non-artifact item, bypassing the CL roll entirely.
Jury-Rig	+1 Corruption	Immediately restore a broken or degraded piece of gear to maximum bonus during combat or a high-tension scene.
Prototyper	+1 Corruption	Grant a piece of mundane gear an Artifact Die (d8) for a single skill roll. The item is permanently destroyed immediately after.
Duct Tape & WD-40 (Healing)	—	Spend a Shift at base tinkering. Automatically repair all degraded gear for the entire party without a roll, and heal 1 Corruption.
Experimental Shielding	+1 Corruption	Once per session, completely ignore the degradation penalty of rolling a 1 on a Gear Die.
Redundant Safeties	—	Passive. Your Maximum Corruption Threshold increases by 2 (to 12 + Empathy). Years of handling unstable prototypes have hardened your psyche.

Keep Talents (Choose 1 at Creation)

Talent	Cost	Effect
Containment Protocol	+1 Corruption	Spend a Fast Action improvising a ward using mundane materials (salt, copper wire, chalk markings). Make a Lore (WIT) roll at Difficulty 1 to set it. On success, any supernatural entity must make a Force (STR) roll at Difficulty 2 to cross the ward. On failure, the ward still goes up but lasts only one round. The ward persists until an entity breaks through it or the scene ends.
Shield of the Covenant	+1 Corruption	When an ally within Engaged range is attacked, you may step in front of the blow as a Reactive Fast Action. You take the damage instead of your ally. Halve the damage you take (round down, minimum 1). Your armor applies normally against the redirected attack.

Talent	Cost	Effect
The Inquisitor's Gaze	+1 Corruption	While conversing with someone, instantly know their current Corruption score and whether they are possessed (defined as: under active supernatural domination by an entity — their will is overridden, not merely influenced). This does not detect high-Corruption individuals who are acting of their own will, only those actively controlled. The target does not know you used this talent.
Medical Training	—	Spend a Slow Action and make a Heal (WIT) roll at Difficulty 2 before an ally rolls their Death Check. On success, the ally rolls d6+1 instead of d6 (death only on a natural 1). On failure, no change. Does not apply to DOA (Result 66) intervention rolls — those are separate emergency Heal actions.
Sanctuary Master	—	When inside Covenant HQ, automatically succeed on any Lore (WIT) roll regarding the history of a registered artifact in the Covenant's inventory. This only applies to artifacts formally catalogued by the Catalogers — unknown or newly recovered artifacts require a normal Lore roll.
The Confessor (Healing)	—	Spend a quiet moment outside combat listening to one ally share a fear, a failing, or a burden they have been carrying. Both you and the ally heal 1d4 Corruption. Limit: once per target per scene. The same ally may not confess again to receive Corruption healing until at least one scene has passed — partial confessions or trivial admissions don't count.

CHAPTER 11. 1980S EQUIPMENT AND ANALOG GEAR

This chapter covers the physical tools available to Covenant agents: investigative gear, weapons, armor, vehicles, and consumable supplies. It also describes the Requisition system (how agents acquire equipment through their Clearance Level), the Resource Die system (tracking consumable supplies), Encumbrance (what agents can carry), Vehicle Rules (chases, damage, and repair), and the Crafting and Repair rules (maintaining and improvising gear in the field).

Repairs and gear degradation connect to the core system described in [Ch 7 — Health, Damage & Armor](#) and [Ch 3 — Core Resolution](#). Refer to [Ch 5 — Combat](#) for the Ammo Die and vehicle chase rules that run during active scenes.

Navigating the neon-lit streets and abandoned industrial sectors of the 1980s requires specialized equipment. Items provide a Gear Bonus (extra black d6 dice) to specific skill rolls. Pushing a roll can cause the item to break, temporarily reducing its bonus.

To reflect the covert nature of the Covenant, characters do not use personal cash. Instead, they utilize their Clearance Level (CL) during the Equipping Phase to requisition supplies from Stack. Items are categorized by their required CL.

11.1. Investigative & Paranormal Tech

Item	Gear Bonus & Effect	Enc.	CL
Heavy-Duty Maglite	+1 to Investigate in the dark. Can act as blunt weapon (Damage 1).	1/2	1
Micro-Cassette Recorder	+1 to Psychoanalyze. Captures EVPs (Electronic Voice Phenomena).	1/2	1
Polaroid SX-70 Camera	+2 to Lore when studying a crime scene. Produces instant evidence.	1	2
Air Ion Counter	+1 to Investigate. Bulky spirit detector measuring static drops.	1	2
Acoustic Coupler Modem	+1 to Tech. Interface with remote mainframes via payphone.	1	2
P-SB7 Spirit Box Prototype	+2 to Lore when deciphering entity motives. Sweeps radio frequencies.	1	3
Thermal / Infrared Camera	+2 to Investigate when tracking heat signatures, cold spots, or invisible entities. Heavy early-80s tech.	2	4

11.2. Standard Tools & Survival Gear

Item	Gear Bonus & Effect	Enc.	CL
Basic First Aid Kit	+1 to Heal. Bandages, antiseptics, painkillers.	1	1
Lockpick Kit	+2 to Deft Hands when bypassing mechanical locks.	1/2	2
Crowbar / Bolt Cutters	+2 to Force when breaking through chains or sealed doors.	1	2
Long-Range Walkie-Talkies	Communication over a few miles (no supernatural interference).	1/2	2
Trauma Surgical Kit	+3 to Heal. Sutures, adrenaline, blood-clotting agents.	2	3

11.3. 1980s Weaponry

Weapons provide a Gear Bonus (added to Firearms or Brawl) and a flat Damage rating. All mundane weapons deal Physical (STR) damage unless noted otherwise.

Weapon	Gear Bonus	Damage	Type	Range	Special Traits	CL
Brass Knuckles	+1	1	Physical 1 (STR)	Engaged	Concealable.	1
Switchblade	+1	2	Physical 1 (STR)	Engaged	Concealable; puncture criticals.	1
Stun Gun / Taser	+2	—	Physical 1 (STR)	Engaged	No Strength damage. Target is Stunned: loses their next Slow Action.	2
.38 Snub-nose Revolver	+2	2	Physical 1 (STR)	Short	Reliable — when pushing the roll, ignore the first 1 that appears on a Gear Die (preventing one degradation step).	2
9mm Semi-Auto Pistol	+2	2	Physical 1 (STR)	Short	High capacity. Extra successes beyond the first may each be spent to hit an additional target in Engaged range (declare before resolving damage).	3
Pump-Action Shotgun	+3	3	Physical 1 (STR)	Short	+1 Damage at Engaged range. Loud and bulky.	3

Weapon	Gear Bonus	Damage	Type	Range	Special Traits	CL
M16 Assault Rifle	+2	3	Physical (STR)	Long	Full Auto — see Ch 5 Full Auto rules for the two-attack-roll, two-Ammo-Die procedure. Consumes extra ammunition each turn fired.	4

11.4. Armor

Armor	Rating	Enc	Special	CL
Concealed Kevlar Vest	3	1	Wearer passes as civilian at distance.	3
Tactical Riot Armor	6	3	Bulky; -2 penalty to Agility rolls.	4

11.5. Consumables and Resource Dice

Consumable supplies — ammunition, medical gear, batteries, and rations — are tracked with Resource Dice. A Resource Die is a single die (d4, d6, d8, d10, or d12) that represents how much of a supply remains. Larger dice mean more supply. When supply runs low, the die steps down.

How Resource Dice Work

When to roll: After each scene in which a consumable is meaningfully used — not for every bullet fired, but for every fight involving firearms, every Heal action using a medical kit, every device run on battery power for an extended period.

The roll: Roll the current Resource Die:

- Result 1-2: Supply is diminishing. Step the die down one size (d12 d10 d8 d6 d4).
- Result 3+: Supply is adequate. No change.

At d4, a result of 1-2: The supply is depleted. Remove the resource from the character's gear. The activity is completed (if mid-scene), but no more uses remain.

Die	Supply Level
d12	Fully stocked — fresh from Stack.
d10	Well supplied — no concerns yet.

Die	Supply Level
d8	Adequate — a couple of heavy uses left.
d6	Running low — ration carefully.
d4	Critical — final uses. Do not count on it.
Depleted	Gone. Cannot be used.

Restocking

Supplies can be restocked:

- During the Equipping Phase at the start of each Case File: any supply can be restocked to its starting die size at no cost (subject to CL restrictions).
- During a Case File, at a credible source: a hospital supply room, a hardware store, an abandoned military cache. The DA determines availability; resupply takes time and may require a Tech or Deft Hands roll (Difficulty 1-2) to access without authorization.
- Cell Underground Field Medic (Personnel): once per Case File, restocks any medical supply to d8 automatically.

Supply Categories

	Ammunition is NOT tracked here. Ammo is tracked exclusively using the Ammo Die system in Ch 5 — Combat (rolling after every turn fired). There is no separate scene-level Resource Die for ammunition — those rows are removed. The Supply Categories table below covers non-ammo consumables only.
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Supply	Starting Die	CL	Notes
Basic First Aid Kit	d10	1	Roll after each Heal roll that consumes supplies (bandages, antiseptic, splints). Does not roll for passive access checks.
Trauma Surgical Kit	d8	3	Roll after each surgical Heal action (treating Critical Injuries, field surgery). High consumption.
Battery Pack (general electronics)	d8	1	Roll after each scene in which an electronic device (flashlight, radio, recording device) is used continuously for more than 30 minutes. Devices operated briefly do not trigger a roll.

Supply	Starting Die	CL	Notes
Specialized Battery (thermal camera, IR devices)	d6	3	These batteries are expensive, proprietary, and hard to replace in the field. Roll after each scene of active use.
Field Rations	d8	1	Only tracked on extended journeys (overnight+) or during prolonged operations without a hot meal. Roll once per day in the field. Not required for standard Case Files.
Artifact Components (optional)	d6	—	Ritual components, containment salts, reactive chemicals. Roll after each artifact interaction requiring preparation materials. DA may waive this for simple artifact containment.

Scarcity in the 1980s Field

In the 1980s, certain supplies are significantly harder to replace in the field:

- Specialized batteries (lithium, proprietary formats for early specialist equipment) may not be available at the nearest grocery store — a Tech roll (Difficulty 2) to substitute or a Contact call to track one down.
- Trauma medical supplies require pharmacy or hospital access — risky in circumstances where the team is operating off the books.
- Rifle ammunition requires a gun shop or military supply — not every rural area has one, and a city purchase is traceable.

The DA should use scarcity as an atmospheric element, not a mechanical trap. Resource depletion should create pressure and decision points, not dead ends.

11.6. Encumbrance

Every agent can carry a limited amount of gear before it slows them down. Encumbrance (Enc.) is listed for each item in the equipment tables above.

Encumbrance Scale

Enc.	Examples
1/2	Small concealable items: a pocket recorder, lockpick kit, walkie-talkie.

Enc.	Examples
1	Standard field gear: first aid kit, camera, crowbar, pistol.
2	Heavy or bulky gear: trauma surgical kit, thermal camera, shotgun.
3+	Oversized or special items: heavy weapons, large artifact containment cases.

Carry Capacity

An agent's carry capacity is $\text{Strength} \times 2$ Enc. points.

Wearing armor adds its Enc value to your total Enc (Concealed Kevlar = +1; Tactical Riot Armor = +3).

Encumbered

If your total Enc. exceeds your carry capacity, you are Encumbered:

- -1 die on all Strength and Agility rolls.
- Moving to a new zone costs a Slow Action instead of a Fast Action.

You remain Encumbered until your load drops back within capacity — drop gear, stash it in the car, or pass it to a teammate.

Overloaded

If your Enc. exceeds $\text{Strength} \times 3$, you are Overloaded:

- You cannot move to a different zone at all.
- At the DA's discretion, you cannot take Fast Actions for movement.
- You must drop excess gear before you can move.

Overloaded is a hard stop. You simply cannot move until weight is reduced.

Clearance Levels (CL) and Requisition

Every item lists a Clearance Level (CL) requirement. CL governs equipment requisition only — it does not control information access or institutional authority (those are governed by Covenant Standing; see [Covenant Standing](#)).

Agents requisition gear during the Equipping Phase between Case Files through their Division's Stack contact. Your character's current CL determines which items you can request:

CL	Who Can Access
1	All agents — basic field supplies.
2	Agents at Division default (Recovery) or with one completed Case File.
3	Agents at Division default (Wayfinder, Keep) or with field commendations — this is the starting CL for Wayfinder and Keep agents.
4	Senior agents and Warden rank — restricted hardware and experimental tech.
5	Maximum clearance — prototype equipment and Covenant legacy assets.

Starting CL is set by Division and Age Group (see [Character Creation](#)). CL advancement is handled through the Requisition Authority general talent (see [Advancement](#)).

11.7. Vehicle Rules

Vehicles are field assets — tools to get there, get away, and occasionally get between a colleague and a bullet. They are not invulnerable, and the 1980s makes every breakdown feel earned.

Vehicle Stat Block Format

Each vehicle has five stats:

- **Speed:** A relative rating — Slow, Medium, Fast, or Very Fast. Sets the Difficulty modifier on chase pursuit rolls (see Chase Rules below).
- **Armor Rating (AR):** Damage reduction against attacks targeting the vehicle directly (ramming, gunfire). Characters inside an armored vehicle use the vehicle's AR instead of their worn armor while they remain inside — the vehicle's protection replaces, not adds to, personal armor (consistent with [Ch 5 cover rules](#)). Wearing armor outside the vehicle provides the worn AR as normal.
- **Reliability:** The vehicle's maximum Wear before breakdown. Each instance of vehicle damage or a pushed vehicle roll adds 1 Wear. At half Reliability (round down): -1 die on all vehicle rolls. At full Reliability Wear: the vehicle stops. Example: a vehicle with Reliability 4 takes a -1 die penalty at 2 Wear and stops at 4 Wear.
- **Handling:** A bonus or penalty applied to all pursuit and evasion rolls (Wits or Agility depending on maneuver type). Represents how nimble the vehicle is.
- **Capacity:** Number of occupants (passengers + driver) and approximate cargo Enc.

1980s Vehicle Roster

Vehicle	Speed	AR	Reliability	Handling	Capacity & Notes
Ford Crown Victoria (Government Sedan)	Medium	1	5	+0	4 passengers, 25 Enc. Inconspicuous government plate — blends at police scenes. Standard Covenant pool car.
Chevrolet Caprice Classic (Full-Size Sedan)	Medium	1	5	+0	4 passengers, 25 Enc. Common, forgettable. The correct answer to most field transport needs.
Dodge Van / Econoline (Panel Van)	Medium	1	4	-1	6 passengers, 50 Enc. Roomy but noticeable. Residential areas trigger 1 Investigate check from neighbors. Good for equipment transport.
Ford F-150 (Pickup Truck)	Medium	0	5	+0	2 cab + bed (40 Enc.). Rural credibility. Bed cargo visible. Excellent in unpaved terrain — no Difficulty penalty off-road.
Ducati 900 SS Motorcycle (or equivalent)	Fast	0	3	+2	1 rider, 10 Enc. Best pursuit vehicle in urban terrain. -2 dice in rain or snow. Rider is exposed — no AR benefit from the vehicle.
Chevrolet Camaro Z28 (Muscle Car)	Fast	0	4	+1	2 passengers, 10 Enc. Fast in a straight line. -1 die on tight-turn pursuit rolls. Loud and memorable — witnesses notice it.

Vehicle	Speed	AR	Reliability	Handling	Capacity & Notes
UH-1 Iroquois Helicopter ("Huey")	Very Fast	2	3	-1	8 passengers, 30 Enc. Conspicuous, loud, and expensive. Requires a Contact or CL 4 requisition. Cannot land on most urban rooftops safely.
Cessna 172 (Light Prop Plane)	Very Fast	0	4	-1	3 passengers (cramped), 15 Enc. For long-distance intercontinental rapid response only. Requires a licensed pilot (NPC contact or PC with Tech 3+).
Zodiac Inflatable Boat (Motorized)	Medium	0	4	+0	4 passengers, 40 Enc. Coastal/river access. Cannot be followed by road vehicles. Night operations: -1 die on all navigation rolls without instruments.

Vehicle Conflict, Damage, and Breakdown

Full vehicle conflict rules — the Contact Track, chase rolls, speed modifiers, vehicle maneuvers (Ram, PIT, Gunfire, Off-Road Break, Blending In), vehicle damage, Wear, and breakdown — are in [Appendix: Advanced Combat Vehicle Conflict](#).

11.8. Crafting and Repair

Gear breaks. In the 1980s, that means hunting down parts, improvising solutions, and relying on whoever in your cell knows which end of a soldering iron is hot. Stack Division agents are the backbone of field readiness — but any experienced agent can manage a field fix if the situation demands it.

Terminology clarification: This chapter uses "Gear Die" (black d6) and "Resource Die" (the stepped d4-d12 supply tracker) as distinct terms. Gear Dice are the black d6 dice in any skill roll pool — rolling a 1 on any Gear Die may degrade the item. Resource Dice are the consumable supply trackers (stepping down from d12 d4 Depleted). These are different systems.

Gear Degradation

Every item with a Gear Bonus risks degradation when any Gear Die in the pool rolls a 1 on the initial roll (not on a push — Gear Dice are never rerolled when pushing). The item’s Gear Bonus is permanently reduced by 1 until repaired. An item reduced to Gear Bonus 0 is Broken and cannot be used.



This degradation system is identical to the one in [Ch 7 — Health, Damage & Armor](#) and [Ch 3 — Core Resolution](#). Ch 7 is the canonical source; this chapter repeats the relevant rules for equipment-specific context only.

This works consistently across all item types:

- **Weapons and tools:** A 1 on any Gear Die reduces the Gear Bonus by 1 (fewer dice on the next roll).
- **Armor:** A 1 on any armor-save Gear Die reduces the Armor Rating by 1.
- **Improvised items:** Begin with Gear Bonus 1 (one black d6). A 1 breaks them immediately — roll on the Improvised Item Failure table below instead of reducing Gear Bonus.

Gear Dice are never rerolled on a push. See [Core Resolution](#) [Gear Degradation](#) for the full rule.

Stack Division Talent Jury-Rig can restore a Broken item mid-scene at the cost of +1 Corruption. Formal repair rules below handle everything else.

Repair Rules

Repairing gear requires time, parts, and a Tech roll.

The Repair Roll

Attribute	Wits (WIT)
Skill	Tech (Stack signature skill)
Base Difficulty	Varies by condition (see table below)
Time Required	Varies (see table below)
Tools Required	Basic toolkit (most repairs); specialized kit for electronics/artifacts

Condition	Gear Bonus	Repair Diff	Time Required
Degraded (Gear Bonus below max)	Below max (1)	1	Quick Repair: 15 minutes (1 scene)
Broken (Gear Bonus 0, non-electronic)	0	2	Full Repair: 1 Shift (~4 hours)
Broken (Gear Bonus 0, electronic/mechanical)	0	3	Full Repair: 1 Shift; requires Power Tools
Artifact-Adjacent Damage	—	4	Requires Occult Lab or Wayfinder consult



Vehicle repair uses a separate system — see [Appendix: Advanced Combat Vehicle Damage](#) (Tech roll Difficulty 2, 30 minutes per 1 Wear cleared). Do not use this table for vehicle Wear.

Success: Each success restores Gear Bonus by 1 (up to the item's maximum). A single Quick Repair roll can restore a Degraded item but not a Broken one — a Broken item requires a Full Repair before it can be used again.

Failure: The repair attempt fails but does not make things worse. **Complication** (Pushed roll only): A pushed Repair roll that fails delivers a Complication roll on the [Breakdown Table](#).

Parts Requirements

Every repair requires at minimum a Junk Die (d6 Resource Die representing scavenged or on-hand parts). Roll the Junk Die after completing repairs:

- **3+:** Parts hold; no step-down.
- **1-2:** Parts ran short; step the Junk Die down one.
- **Junk Die Exhausted:** No spare parts of that type remain. Acquire more (see [Component Sourcing](#)).

Parts Category	Resource Die	Used For
Junk / Scrap	d6	Field repairs, improvised items, basic mechanical fixes
Hardware Components	d8	Electronics, communications gear, vehicle parts
Medical Supplies	d10	See Resource Dice table in Consumables section
Specialized Parts	d6	High-tech, rare, or artifact-adjacent repairs only — not scavengeable

Parts Category	Resource Die	Used For
Covenant Cache Parts	d12	Covenant-supplied; best quality; no acquisition roll needed

Component Sourcing

Not everything is sitting in a Covenant armory. Field agents must scavenge, requisition, or improvise.

Scavenging

When in a setting that plausibly contains usable materials (hardware store, junkyard, abandoned building, mechanic's garage), an agent may spend a Slow Action or Free Move to scavenge. Roll Investigate (WIT), Diff 1.

- **Success:** Find d6 uses worth of Junk/Scrap (or roll on Scavenge table below).
- **Extra Successes (2+):** Upgrade the find to Hardware Components instead of Junk.

Scavenge Location	Typical Find (d6)
Hardware / Home Improvement Store	1-3: Junk; 4-5: Hardware Components; 6: Power Tools (counts as Specialized Parts)
Auto Repair Shop / Junkyard	1-2: Junk; 3-5: Hardware Components; 6: Vehicle-rated Specialized Parts
Office Building / University	1-3: Junk; 4-5: Electronics (Hardware Components); 6: Lab-grade Specialized Parts
Abandoned Farmhouse / Rural Site	1-4: Junk; 5: Hardware Components; 6: Firearms Parts (Hardware Components)
Government / Military Facility	1: Junk; 2-4: Hardware Components; 5-6: Specialized Parts
Active Household	1-5: Junk only; 6: Hardware Components (medical kit, power tools)

HQ Requisition

Any non-scavengeable part (Specialized Parts, Covenant Cache Parts) requires a Covenant requisition. Use the standard CL system (see [\[requisitioning-gear\]](#)). Specialized Parts have CL 3. Covenant Cache Parts are CL 4+ and require approval from the Keep.

Stack Advantage: Stack Division agents treat Specialized Parts as CL 2 when requisitioning

(their workshop connections reduce red tape).

Improvised Items

When time is short and a proper tool isn't available, agents can construct improvised weapons and tools from scavenged materials. Improvised items function at reduced effectiveness and carry a higher risk of failure.

Crafting Improvised Items

Roll Tech (WIT), using the difficulty from the table below. Requires at minimum a Junk Die (d6) as parts; step it down after crafting.

Improvised items begin with Gear Bonus 1 (one black d6 in the pool — never more, they're held together with duct tape and prayer).

Improvised Item	Tech Diff	Time	Notes
Club / Makeshift Bludgeon	1	1 minute	Damage 1, Slow. No Gear Die — it's a pipe.
Shiv / Field Knife	1	5 minutes	Damage 1, Fast. Gear Bonus 1. Breaks on 1 (failure table).
Molotov Cocktail	1	10 minutes	Blast 1, Fire. No Gear Bonus — single use.
Improvised First Aid Kit	2	20 minutes	Functions as Basic First Aid. Gear Bonus 1.
Signal Jammer	2	1 hour	Blocks comms in zone. Gear Bonus 1. Electronics.
Tripwire / Alarm Trap	2	30 minutes	Spend; triggers on intruder entry. Single use.
Garrote Wire	1	5 minutes	Grapple-linked attack. No Gear Bonus — simple tool.
Lockpick Set (crude)	3	1 hour	Deft Hands -1 die compared to proper picks. Gear Bonus 1.
Improvised Bug Detector	3	2 hours	Detect surveillance; -1 die vs. professional gear. Gear Bonus 1.
Field Radio Booster	3	2 hours	Extend comms range by 1 zone. Gear Bonus 1. Electronics.

Improvised items cannot be upgraded with proper parts after the fact — once improvised, always improvised. The exception is Stack Division agents with the Prototyper talent, who may grant any improvised item an Artifact Die (d8) for a single skill roll — after that roll, the item is

permanently destroyed (consistent with the Prototyper talent in [Ch 9 — Divisions](#)).

Improvised Item Failure

When a Gear Die on an improvised item comes up 1, it does not simply reduce Gear Bonus — the item fails outright. Roll on the following table:

d6	Improvised Item Failure
1	Catastrophic Break. Item is destroyed instantly. If a weapon, the wielder takes 1 Strength damage (no roll to avoid).
2	Jams or Jams Shut. Item is unusable this scene. Can be cleared with a free action next round (no roll needed).
3	Splinters / Shrapnel. Item breaks; nearest ally in zone rolls Endure (AGI) Difficulty 1 or takes 1 Strength damage.
4	Power Surge. Electronic items only: short circuit, sparks. Make a Tech (WIT) Difficulty 1 roll; on success, cleared with a Slow Action. On failure, the item is Broken (requires Full Repair).
5	Reduced Function. Item still usable but provides no Gear Bonus die (treat as an improvised item with no dice contribution).
6	Quick Fix. Near-miss — item is stable. Gear Die stays at current step; no degradation.

Stack Division: Crafting Signature

Stack agents aren't just better at repairs — they have a different relationship with gear entirely. Training in Covenant workshops, maintaining equipment under operational conditions, and sourcing parts through a network of trusted contacts gives Stack agents mechanical advantages no other Division matches.



These are background advantages intrinsic to Stack training — always active, no activation cost. They do not replace or conflict with Stack's activated talents (Jury-Rig, Prototyper, Duct Tape & WD-40, etc.) from [Ch 9](#). Both apply independently.

Advantage	Effect
Tech Bonus	Stack agents add +1 die to all Tech rolls made for repair and improvised item creation.

Advantage	Effect
Faster Repairs	Quick Repairs take 5 minutes instead of 15. Full Repairs take 2 hours instead of a full Shift.
Parts Economy	Stack agents never step down a Junk Die on a successful repair — only failed repairs consume parts.
Known Contacts	Once per case, a Stack agent can source Hardware Components (d8) without a Covenant requisition (a contact comes through).
Workshop Access	At a cell location, Stack agents may use the Covenant Armorer capability at no additional cost, even before it is fully established. They improvise the bench themselves.



Default crafting rule: All non-vehicle repairs use a single Parts Die (d8) as the parts tracker. Roll it like any Resource Die after each repair — 1-2: step down; 3+: no change. Replenish it at a cell location or during Equipping Phase. This keeps crafting simple and fast at the table.

Detailed crafting option (DA guidance): For groups that want more granular resource tracking, the full parts economy (Junk Die, Hardware Components, Specialized Parts, Covenant Cache Parts) described earlier in this section provides deeper material management. Use it when your table enjoys logistical gameplay — but the Parts Die is the default rule.

Cross-reference: Stack Division full description, background options, and Talents (including Jury-Rig, Prototyper, Duct Tape & WD-40) are in [Divisions](#).

11.9. Cross-References

- [Ch 3 — Core Resolution](#) — Gear Dice in skill pools, gear degradation (canonical rule), pushing rolls
- [Ch 5 — Combat](#) — Ammo Die system (single canonical ammo tracking), vehicle chases as they apply during combat, cover AR vs worn armor
- [Ch 7 — Health, Damage & Armor](#) — Armor Rating rules, armor degradation, Strength damage, Broken state
- [Ch 9 — Divisions](#) — Stack Division talents (Jury-Rig, Prototyper, Duct Tape & WD-40), Recovery starting CL and armor exception, Clearance Level by Division
- [Ch 12 — Headquarters](#) — Equipping Phase, Covenant Armorer facility, Requisition Authority talent, Standing vs CL distinction

CHAPTER 12. ARTIFACTS OF POWER AND DOOM

This chapter covers the game's treatment of Occult Artifacts — how they work, how they are used, and how they are contained. It includes the Artifact Die and Activation Procedure, the Corruption cost system, emission rules (Aura, Pulse, Burst), the Containment-First play principle, a starting catalog of period artifacts, DA guidelines for designing new artifacts, Containment Profiles, Containment Rituals, and the optional Artifact Decay rule.

Artifact mechanics tie directly to the Corruption system in [Ch 8 — Corruption and Healing](#). Division Instrument interactions (Verdant Codex, Verdant Satchel, Warden's Bracer) are described in [Ch 9 — Divisions](#).

In an occult thriller setting, artifacts are fundamentally dangerous — objects of immense, unknowable power that exact a heavy toll on the human mind and physical reality. Project Neon Relic leans heavily into the "Artifact of Doom" narrative trope, ensuring that utilizing magic is always a terrifying gamble.

12.1. The Mechanics of Occult Artifacts

Within the YZE system, mystical objects are classified as Occult Artifacts. They often appear entirely mundane — a vintage Polaroid camera, a rusted World War I trench lighter, a tarnished silver coin — but are imbued with intense paranatural energy.

To utilize an artifact, a character must trigger its specific activation condition (e.g., speaking a phrase in a dead language, feeding it a drop of blood, or playing a specific frequency). Artifacts function in two interdependent ways:

1. Overwhelming Power — The artifact allows an action far outside normal human capability: viewing past events, turning invisible, commanding the undead, or dealing massive unblockable damage to supernatural entities.
2. The Psychological Toll — Every activation immediately generates +1 to +3 Corruption (by artifact tier), pushing the user closer to the Corruption threshold.

Every artifact also carries an Artifact Die — a usage die that degrades with each activation. See [Using an Artifact](#) for the full activation procedure and die-level guidelines.

12.2. Using an Artifact

The Artifact Die

Unlike Forbidden Lands and other YZE titles where artifact dice add bonus successes to a skill pool, the Neon Relic Artifact Die is a usage die. It works like other usage dice in the system (Resource Dice, Gear Dice): each time the artifact is activated, the player rolls the Artifact

Die. On a result of 1, the die steps down one level on the chain:

d20 d12 d10 d8 d6 d4 Fractured

When the die steps down past d4, the artifact fractures — its metaphysical structure fails catastrophically and the Fracture Condition triggers immediately.

The Artifact Die does not generate successes or add to skill pools. It is purely a measure of how many activations the artifact can sustain before it breaks.

Why this matters: A d20 artifact can absorb many activations before fracture becomes likely. A d4 artifact is one bad roll from destruction. The die level is part of what makes powerful artifacts powerful — and what makes expendable Keep-issue items feel dangerous and disposable.

Activation Procedure

When an agent activates an artifact, resolve the following steps in order:

1. Meet the activation condition. Each artifact has a specific trigger — a spoken phrase, a physical action, a blood offering, a frequency. If the condition is not met, the artifact does not respond.
2. Declare activation. Activating an artifact is a Slow Action (it requires preparation, concentration, or deliberate physical engagement with the activation condition). Some artifact entries may specify a different action cost — those override this default.
3. Pay the Corruption cost. The activating agent immediately gains Corruption equal to the artifact's tier (+1/+2/+3). This cost is paid whether the die fractures or not. It is never reduced, waived, or transferred.
4. The effect resolves. The artifact's stated mechanical effect takes place. Most effects grant automatic successes, bypass skill rolls, or impose conditions on targets. There is no additional roll to determine whether the effect works — the Corruption cost is the price of certainty.
5. Roll the Artifact Die. The player rolls the artifact's current Artifact Die.

On a 1: The die steps down one level (d20 d12 d10 d8 d6 d4). If the die was already a d4, the artifact fractures and the Fracture Condition triggers immediately.

On any other result: The artifact remains at its current die level. No additional effect.

The effect always fires. Even when the Artifact Die rolls a 1 and the artifact fractures, the stated effect still takes place — but the Fracture Condition triggers simultaneously. The agent gets what they wanted and pays the catastrophic price.

Artifact Die Levels

An artifact's starting die is not mechanically locked to its Corruption tier. It reflects the artifact's metaphysical resilience — the depth of its origin event, its age, how many times it

has been activated without containment, and how well-preserved its internal structure remains.

Starting Die	Typical Artifact
d20	Ancient relics with deep historical or mythological roots. Artifacts connected to major events in human history — wars, plagues, empires. Extremely rare; the Covenant may encounter one per campaign.
d12	Powerful artifacts with centuries of history. Objects connected to significant but localized events — a 17th-century plague bell, a Civil War relic, a medieval reliquary.
d10	Established artifacts with documented activation history. Mid-century objects that have been used, studied, or contained multiple times.
d8	Standard field-grade artifacts. Most catalog entries and case-file relics fall here. Dangerous but not inexhaustible.
d6	Lower-tier artifacts, recently formed objects, or items weakened by prior activation. Common among Keep-issue field tools and objects recovered in degraded condition.
d4	Nearly spent artifacts — one activation from fracture. Objects the Covenant issues as disposable emergency tools, or relics that have been pushed to their limit through repeated use.

12.3. Containment—First Play Principle

In Neon Relic, artifact activation is not the default objective. Many missions are won by preventing activation, isolating carriers, or moving an item into secure containment under pressure.

Artifact use should feel like emergency leverage, not a class feature the group relies on every session. If the cell chooses activation, that should signal desperation, a calculated sacrifice, or a failure to preserve a cleaner containment path.

When framing a case, define at least one non-activation success path:

- **Deny use:** Keep all actors from meeting activation conditions.
- **Quarantine:** Isolate artifact and witnesses until corruption spread stops.
- **Transfer:** Secure chain-of-custody handoff to Keep facilities without field activation.

Unknown effects are valid outcomes. If no one can safely predict activation consequences, the DA should treat non-use as a successful and often preferable strategic decision.

Activation Risk Tags

Assign one risk tag to every artifact entry:

Risk Tag	Meaning
Stable	Activation behavior is mostly understood. Fracture remains dangerous, but blast radius is usually local.
Volatile	Activation is partly understood. Misuse, stress, or repeated use escalates side effects quickly.
Catastrophic	Activation can alter the entire scene or case trajectory, including bystanders and infrastructure.
Unknown	The Covenant does not yet understand the activation envelope. Treat field activation as last resort.

Corruption Emission (Aura, Pulse, Burst)

Some high-threat artifacts emit corruption into the environment even when not directly activated by an agent.

Emission Type	Baseline Radius	Typical Corruption Effect	Use Case
Aura	Engaged / same zone	+1 Corruption at scene start for exposed targets	Persistent proximity hazard during transport or containment failure
Pulse	Near (adjacent zones)	+1 Corruption when triggered event occurs	Triggered by alarms, loud noise, blood contact, or ritual disruption
Burst	Short to Distant (up to 4 zones)	+2 Corruption to all targets in range (or +1 on successful Endure (AGI) roll, Difficulty 2, DA choice based on scene severity)	Catastrophic failure mode; major escalation beat

Emission is optional per artifact and should be tied to tier and narrative stakes. Avoid unavoidable no-win loops: telegraph emissions clearly and offer at least one mitigation strategy (distance, shielding, ritual suppression, or rapid transfer).

12.4. Catalog of 1980s Occult Artifacts

Artifact	Risk Tag	Die	Mundane Appearance	Effect	Cost & Fracture	Emission
The Betamax of St. Jude	Volatile	d8	Degraded Betamax tape in unmarked black sleeve.	Displays the immediate 10-minute future when played on a VCR. Auto-success on any opposed Wits or Agility roll in the current scene.	2 Corruption. VCR combusts; user temporarily blinded by visions of their own death.	Pulse — when any VCR in the same building powers on, future-vision fragments leak to all agents in the same zone. +1 Corruption.
The Obsidian Walkman	Stable	d6	Heavy, modified Sony cassette player with stone-like casing.	Hear the ambient frequencies of the dead. Communicate with spirits to discover hidden clues; once per scene, bypass a single Investigate roll automatically.	1 Corruption. User deafened by psychic static; gains permanent phobia of silence.	Aura — the dead broadcast continuously while the Walkman is carried. +1 Corruption at scene start for the carrier and all agents sharing the zone.
The Oppenheimer Lens	Stable	d8	Aviator sunglasses with fused desert-glass lenses.	See the true monstrous forms of entities hiding in human guises. Pierce all supernatural illusions for the remainder of the scene.	1 Corruption. Lenses shatter; shards cause 1 permanent Agility damage.	—

Artifact	Risk Tag	Die	Mundane Appearance	Effect	Cost & Fracture	Emission
The Judas Coin	Volatile	d12	Heavy silver denarius, unnaturally warm.	Target overwhelmed by greed or guilt during social interaction. Auto-success on a single Manipulate (EMP) roll. The Coin is Tier 2 (2 Corruption) despite its single-roll scope because it is uniquely reliable — it never fails to succeed and removes all social opposition.	2 Corruption. Coin burns through user's flesh (1 physical damage); target becomes violently hostile.	Pulse — when any monetary transaction occurs in the same zone (payment, barter, till), the Coin pulses guilt to the nearest agent. +1 Corruption.
The Chronos Polaroid	Stable	d6	Polaroid SX-70 camera smelling of ozone.	Photographs a location as it appeared 24 hours prior. Bypasses tracking or forensic analysis — automatically produces evidence of activities in the past 24 hours.	1 Corruption. Flash acts as beacon, alerting nearest supernatural entity to party's exact location.	—

12.5. Artifact Carry Weight and Corruption Pressure

Artifacts are not merely heavy objects — they exert metaphysical pressure on the agent carrying them. This interacts with the Encumbrance system in two ways:

Physical Weight

Each artifact has a baseline Encumbrance value equal to its Corruption cost tier:

Artifact Tier	Enc.	Notes
Low (1 Corruption)	1	Small objects: a coin, a cassette tape, an old photograph.
Medium (2 Corruption)	2	Larger objects: cameras, walkmen, instruments.

Artifact Tier	Enc.	Notes
High (3 Corruption)	3	Bulky or imposing objects: weapons, mirrors, bound volumes.

Active Artifact Pressure

Carrying an artifact that has been activated at least once this Case File imposes +1 Enc. above its base value for the remainder of the Case File (not just the current session). The artifact’s metaphysical structure is disturbed — it pushes back.

- This additional Enc. is invisible to standard detectors — only characters with the Lore skill or Wayfinder training can sense something is off.
- If an active artifact’s pressure pushes the carrier into the Encumbered state, they also gain +1 Corruption at the start of each scene while carrying it (the corruption leaks passively).



This passive Corruption gain is an additional Corruption source not listed in the Ch 8 Corruption sources table. Add it as a situational entry: "Carrying an activated artifact (Encumbered by it) | +1 per scene" — see [Ch 8 — Corruption and Healing](#).

Stacking Artifacts

Carrying more than one artifact simultaneously is permitted but discouraged:

- Two artifacts: Both active pressure rules apply independently.
- Three or more artifacts: The DA triggers a Corruption Cascade — all carried artifacts leak corruption into the carrier simultaneously. Each artifact applies its Corruption cost at the end of the scene, even if none were used.

Lore roll (Difficulty 2): An agent who succeeds on a Lore roll after picking up an artifact can sense its tier and whether a previous carrier activated it. Failure means the agent is unaware of the added pressure until they notice they are Encumbered or start gaining unplanned Corruption.

12.6. Creating Artifacts (DA Guidelines)

Every Neon Relic campaign arc should have a unique artifact at its heart — a specific, dangerous object with a history, a hunger, and consequences that ripple through the case file. The catalog above provides examples, but DAs need a structured framework for designing originals.

The rules below use a Corruption Budget system: the power of an artifact’s effect is always proportional to the psychological and physical cost of using it. No free rides. No safe

artifacts.

The Artifact Template

Every artifact needs six defined components — five mandatory and one optional. Fill in each section before introducing the artifact to players.

Component	What It Defines	Design Prompt
Origin	Where did this come from? Why does it have power?	"A Civil War surgeon's bone saw used in a field hospital during a thunderstorm that struck the tent. Three hundred deaths witnessed through its blade."
Form	What does it look like? What mundane object is it?	Must appear entirely ordinary. No glowing runes. The horror is the mundane hiding the monstrous.
Effect	What does activating it do?	State the mechanical benefit clearly: what roll it replaces, what it grants, what threat it neutralizes.
Corruption Cost & Tier	How much Corruption does activation generate?	1 Corruption = Tier 1. 2 Corruption = Tier 2. 3 Corruption = Tier 3. See budget guidelines below.
Artifact Die	What is the artifact's starting usage die?	d4 (disposable) through d20 (legendary). Based on the artifact's age, origin depth, and metaphysical resilience. See Artifact Die Levels .
Fracture Condition	What happens when the Artifact Die steps down past d4?	Should be thematically linked to the origin. A surgeon's tool might inflict wounds; a musical instrument might silence the user.

Containment Profile (optional sixth component): What physical or procedural conditions keep this artifact dormant in transport? What inadvertently activates it? See [Containment Profiles](#) below.

Corruption Budget System

An artifact's Corruption cost is not arbitrary — it flows directly from the power of the effect. Use this framework to set the Corruption cost for a new artifact. The Artifact Die is assigned separately based on history and resilience — see [Artifact Die Levels](#).

Tier	Corruption Cost	Effect Power Level
1 — Uncanny	1 Corruption	Grants an automatic success on a single skill roll, or reveals information that would require a Diff 2 roll. No direct combat effect. Minor sensory or perceptual ability.
2 — Threatening	2 Corruption	Replaces a full skill roll with guaranteed success, or grants a significant combat advantage (extra dice, forced complication on enemy). Affects one target in zone.
3 — Catastrophic	3 Corruption	Transcends normal human action entirely — massive unblockable damage, reality alteration, mass psychic attack, temporal displacement of a scene. Cannot be replicated by any mundane skill roll.

Effect Design Rules

These rules prevent artifacts from becoming "I win" buttons:

1. One effect only. Artifacts do one thing. They do it perfectly. They do not do anything else.
2. No healing. Artifacts cannot restore Stress, Corruption, or physical Damage. (They can transfer damage — a Tier 2 artifact might push one agent's wounds to another — but cannot eliminate harm from the fiction.)
3. Always costs something. Even on a "successful" fracture-free roll, the Corruption cost is paid. The artifact does not become safer with use.
4. Fracture scales with Tier. Tier 1 fractures are painful and personal. Tier 2 fractures affect the party or scene. Tier 3 fractures threaten the location or the case.

Containment Profiles

Containment is half the job. Before introducing an artifact, define how it is kept inert during transport and what triggers it inadvertently.

Containment Type	How It Works	Example Trigger (Inadvertent Activation)
Physical Isolation	Wrapped in lead foil, stored in a Faraday cage, or sealed in salt-packed containers.	Unwrapped within 5 meters of a powered device.
Ritual Quiescence	A spoken phrase, symbol, or specific handling order keeps the artifact dormant.	Touched without the quiescence rite being performed within the last 24 hours.

Containment Type	How It Works	Example Trigger (Inadvertent Activation)
Environmental Suppression	Requires specific temperature, darkness, or absence of electromagnetic fields.	Brought into a brightly lit space, or exposed to radio frequencies.
Proximity Restriction	Cannot be within a defined range of another artifact.	Two artifacts stored in the same vehicle for more than 1 hour.
Temporal Lock	Dormant only during specific hours, phases of the moon, or calendar dates.	Activation window opens during a case — may force a ticking-clock constraint.
Cognitive Anchor	Requires a holder with a specific psychological trait (fear, grief, obsession) to remain passive.	Carried by a Corrupted agent (any Corruption stage 2+) — activates involuntarily.

Stack Division Note: The [Covenant Armorer](#) HQ facility and the Keep's Corruption Dampening Vault provide structural support for containment. Without them, field containment relies on improvised measures and Wayfinder knowledge.

Containment Rituals

Containment rituals are not spellcasting talents. They are risky Lore-led procedures used to suppress an artifact, shield a target from occult bleed, or disperse a manifestation long enough to regain custody. Wayfinders most often lead them, but any agent with Lore may attempt one.

- **Who can lead:** Any agent with Lore 1+ may attempt a Quiescence or Shielding ritual. Banishment rituals, or any ritual aimed at a Tier 3 artifact or a fully manifest entity, require Lore 3+ or active Wayfinder support. If no Wayfinder is available in the cell, any agent with Lore 2+ may attempt Banishment at +1 Difficulty — the gap between competent knowledge and specialist training is real and costly.
- **What rituals do not do:** A ritual rarely solves the whole case by itself. If the anchor, artifact, or ritual site remains uncontrolled, the threat can return when the pressure rises again.
- **Pushing:** Ritual rolls may be pushed as normal. If the ritual targets an artifact or entity that is already active, manifest, or broadcasting, the ritual leader gains +1 Corruption when the roll resolves, even on success.

Minimum Inputs

Input	Requirement
Boundary	Chalk, salt, copper wire, black cloth, lead foil, or whatever the artifact's Containment Profile specifically requires.
Target or Anchor	The artifact, contaminated carrier, ritual site, or identified occult origin point must be present, physically reachable, or precisely fixed in the scene.
Key	A true name, activation condition, containment phrase, symbol pattern, or other specific clue learned through play. Rituals are procedures, not guesses.
Working Window	Quiescence: 10 minutes. Shielding or Banishment: one full scene. Combat, vehicle movement, or panicked crowds count as hostile conditions, not valid quiet setup.

If the team lacks proper boundary materials or the correct key, add +1 Difficulty for each missing element. A Verdant Codex or a Keep containment kit counts as proper ritual material support in the field.

Ritual Types

All ritual rolls use Lore (WIT) unless a specific Containment Profile states otherwise.

Ritual Type	Skill	Base Diff	Default Time	On Success
Quiescence	Lore (WIT)	2	10 minutes	Suppress an artifact's activation or emission for one scene or one transport leg. If the artifact uses a Ritual Quiescence Containment Profile, the rite is considered renewed for the next 24 hours.
Shielding	Lore (WIT)	2	One full scene	Seal a person, object, or small zone against passive broadcast, imprint, or occult bleed until the end of the current shift or until the boundary is broken.
Banishment / Dispersal	Lore (WIT)	3	One full scene	Disperse a manifestation, collapse an active ritual site, or force an entity back to its anchor. If the anchor is immediately contained or removed, the effect holds; if not, the threat may return on the next clock advance or major disturbance.

Apply these modifiers unless an artifact or bestiary entry gives a fixed ritual Difficulty:

- +1 if the target is Tier 3, actively emitting, or spreading across multiple people.
- +2 if the target is Tier 3 Catastrophic (spreading across multiple zones or a major active threat that defies normal ritual containment).
- +1 if the ritual is performed while moving, under attack, or amid public panic.
- -1 if the team has the exact containment profile, true name, or recovered ritual notes.
- -1 if the rite is performed in a properly prepared HQ vault, Occult Lab, or equivalent secured site.

Each successful containment ritual advances the artifact's Decay by +1, if the target has a Decay track.

Support Actions

Before the final ritual roll, allies may either help normally or perform one of the following support actions. Each successful support action may only benefit the ritual once:

Support Action	Skill	Effect
Identify the Key	Investigate or Lore	Remove one missing-key penalty by confirming the true name, activation condition, or anchor logic.
Build the Boundary	Tech or Deft Hands	Gain +1 die on the ritual roll or ignore one improvised-material penalty.
Hold the Line	Command, Firearms, Force, or Sneak	The next interruption, hostile push, or panic effect does not automatically break the ritual setup.
Stabilize the Subject	Heal or Psychoanalyze	A contaminated carrier, witness, or panicked ally can remain inside the boundary. On failure, they flee, lash out, or collapse — the ritual cannot begin until the situation is controlled.

In practice, this usually means Wayfinder leads, Recovery secures the target, Keep controls the perimeter, and Stack improvises shielding or material support.

Failure and Backlash

On failure, the ritual does not take hold. The DA chooses or rolls one backlash from the table below. On a pushed failure, apply two different backlash results.

d6	Backlash
1	Corruption Surge. The leader and everyone inside the boundary gain +1 Corruption.

d6	Backlash
2	Boundary Rupture. Materials burn out, spill, or crack. The next ritual attempt in this scene is +1 Difficulty until the boundary is rebuilt.
3	Clock Advance / Activation Spike. Advance the nearest case clock by 1, or trigger the target's emission immediately if no clock is running.
4	Psychic Recoil. The ritual leader takes 1 Wits or Empathy damage (DA chooses to fit the fiction).
5	Anchor Shift. The target relocates, hides, or changes the visible trigger. The team must re-establish the key before trying again.
6	Hostile Backlash. The entity lashes out, a bystander becomes contaminated, or electronics in Near range lose 1 Gear Bonus permanently.

Starter Rituals

- **Field Quiescence Rite:** Re-wrap, re-phrase, or re-seal an artifact before transport. This is the default answer to a Ritual Quiescence Containment Profile and the usual way to renew a temporary seal after mishandling.
- **Lead-and-Salt Shield:** Used on contaminated carriers, artifact-imprinted survivors, and occult broadcasts. This is the default rite for suppressing Artifact Imprint and similar lingering calls. See [Ch 8](#) for Corruption healing conditions that make a Shielding ritual necessary.
- **Anchor Dispersal Circuit:** Used against manifestations such as The Mire or The Listening (see [Ch 19 — Bestiary](#)). It does not destroy them permanently unless the anchor is simultaneously removed, isolated, or neutralized. Critical Injuries sustained during failed Banishment rituals use the standard Critical Injury table in [Ch 7 — Health, Damage & Armor](#).

One-of-a-Kind vs. Replicable Artifacts

Most artifacts are unique — imbued with power because of specific historical events, blood spilled, or metaphysical convergence that cannot be replicated. The DA should treat these as irreplaceable campaign assets.

Replicable artifacts are the exception. They occur when:

- A formula or ritual is rediscovered (Wayfinder research arc)
- A factory or workshop was unknowingly producing cursed items at scale
- A Fragment entity has seeded multiple objects simultaneously

Replicable artifacts follow the same template but have the Replicable tag appended. They may appear in multiple instances throughout a campaign.

Artifact Decay (Optional Rule)

As agents study, handle, and contain an artifact over multiple sessions, its metaphysical coherence may weaken. This is a feature, not a bug — it means containment is working.

Decay Track: Each artifact has a hidden Decay score from 0–5. The DA advances it when:

- The artifact is successfully studied by a Wayfinder (roll Lore, success = +1 Decay)
- A containment ritual is performed correctly (+1 Decay per ritual)
- The Artifact Die steps down due to activation (+1 Decay per step-down)

Decay Score	Artifact Die	Status
0	Starting die	Active and fully dangerous
1–2	Step down one die from current	Effect weakened; Corruption cost reduced by 1 (min 1)
3–4	Step down two dice from current	Severely weakened; the Corruption cost is reduced by 1 (minimum 1) and the effect is noticeably diminished — the DA may describe the effect as partial or uncertain, but the effect still fires (consistent with the Activation Procedure's "the effect always fires" rule). The Corruption cost is paid regardless.
5	—	Inert. Artifact is neutralized and safe for permanent containment. Case closed.

Decay is the core loop of a well-run Neon Relic campaign. Each case should advance decay on the primary artifact by at least 1. A multi-session arc is complete when the artifact reaches Decay 5.

Worked Example: The Stethoscope of Dr. Morrow

To illustrate the framework in practice:

Origin: In 1943, Dr. Eli Morrow performed an experimental surgery in a research hospital outside Chicago. During the procedure, a corruption event — origin unknown — caused Morrow to hear the deaths of everyone in the building simultaneously. He died at the operating table. His stethoscope absorbed the event.

Form: A 1940s-era Sprague Rappaport stethoscope, worn black tubing, chestpiece engraved with

initials E.M. Appears old but functional.

Artifact Die: d10

Effect (Tier 2): When pressed to any living person's chest, the user hears not the target's heartbeat but their greatest fear — precise, immersive, and exploitable. Grants automatic success on any Empathy (Manipulate) or Investigate (interrogation) roll against that target for the rest of the scene.

Corruption Cost: 2 Corruption.

Fracture Condition (on 1): The user hears their own death — vivid, detailed, inevitable. They gain +2 Corruption immediately and cannot take Slow Actions until end of scene (paralyzed by the vision).

Containment Profile: Physical Isolation — wrapped in surgical gauze treated with saline solution. Activates involuntarily if placed against skin without first spoken: "Morrow rests."

Artifact Decay: Begins at 0. Each Wayfinder analysis session can push this toward inert at Decay 5.

Containment-Oriented Worked Examples

The following three artifacts illustrate missions where preventing activation is the primary objective. Each entry includes a Containment Profile, Emission data, and DA Guidance for running the case as a retrieval and containment operation rather than an activation event.

The Broadcast Reel

Risk Tag: Volatile

Tier: 2

Artifact Die: d10

Emission: Pulse

Origin: In 1968, a documentary film crew recorded what they believed was a mass hysteria event at a rural commune. The footage shows nothing unusual — fields, a barn, people standing in a field doing nothing. The editor who assembled the final cut died by suicide three days after completing it. The reel was seized by a government agency in 1970 and has been in federal transit limbo since, never screened, never destroyed.

Form: A 16mm film reel in a yellow plastic canister, labeled in faded typewriter: ARCHIVE ONLY — DO NOT SCREEN. The film appears partially exposed but not degraded. Held to light, it casts no visible image.

Containment Objective: The reel must never be loaded into a projector. Even partial threading — feeding the leader without running the film — has caused documented psychological

disturbance in handling personnel. The case is won when the reel is in a light-sealed transport container and transferred to a Keep vault under Physical Isolation protocols.

Effect (if activated): Everyone within the projected room experiences twelve minutes of vivid, immersive reconstruction of their worst memory. Each target gains +2 Corruption. For 24 hours following exposure, targets cannot make Push rolls — something in them has gone quiet.

Corruption Cost: 2. All occupants of the projected space are affected simultaneously; the activating agent has no special protection against bystander exposure.

Fracture Condition: The projector fuses and cannot be switched off by normal means. The film loops. Any occupant who entered the room cannot perceive the exit until someone outside physically cuts power to the building circuit.

Containment Profile: Physical Isolation. Transport in the original yellow canister inside an opaque black nylon bag, stored in a hard-sided case. Never collocate with projection equipment.

Inadvertent activation: Canister opened in a darkened room while a film projector is running within 5 meters.

Emission (Pulse): When any film projector within 20 meters of the reel is powered on, all agents in the same zone gain +1 Corruption from proximity — whether or not the reel is removed from its case.

DA Guidance: Frame this mission around urgency, not combat. A rival faction or a civilian enthusiast has acquired projection equipment and intends to screen what they believe is a lost documentary. The agents must intercept the reel before it is threaded. Treat The Screening Begins as a time-locked organization that worsens by the hour. The threat is escalating exposure, not a fight.

The Custody Manifest

Risk Tag: Unknown

Tier: 1

Artifact Die: d8

Emission: Aura

Origin: A chain-of-custody manifest from a classified government logistics program believed to have operated between 1959 and 1963. The form is never fully filled out: the "Current Custodian" entry rearranges overnight, updating itself to match whoever last handled the document. No origin facility has been matched. The manifest predates any known program that would have generated it.

Form: A worn, letter-size form on government stock, partially printed and partially handwritten in black ink. The ink in the "Current Custodian" field always appears fresh. A small federal seal in the top corner cannot be matched to any known agency.

Containment Objective: The manifest cannot be signed. Any written mark on the document — even an accidental pen scratch — triggers compulsion. The case is complete when the manifest is sealed in a glassine archival sleeve and logged in Wayfinder records under a chain-of-custody notation maintained externally, never on the document itself.

Effect (if activated): Whoever signs or writes on the manifest becomes compelled to deliver whatever they are currently holding to an address that appears on the form. The address changes with each activation. On a Push roll, the compelled agent may resist for one scene — the compulsion returns at the start of the next with a new address.

Corruption Cost: 1. Paid immediately at the moment of signing.

Fracture Condition: The delivery address resolves to a location within five kilometres of the signing agent. A Shard Construct manifests at that location within the hour, tasked with enforcing delivery — of the signing agent themselves.

Containment Profile: Ritual Quiescence. Handle only with latex gloves. Store face-down with an external handwritten cover note (not typed — the manifest cannot affect marks that do not touch its surface): DO NOT SIGN. DO NOT WRITE ON OR NEAR THIS DOCUMENT.

Inadvertent activation: An agent fills out an unrelated form placed on top of the manifest, pressing through the page.

Emission (Aura): The agent currently listed as "Custodian" gains +1 Corruption at the start of each scene in which they do not actively move toward the listed delivery address. This is passive — the agent need not have read the manifest for the effect to apply.

DA Guidance: This artifact is built for a procedural containment case. The players discover the manifest in the possession of an unwitting civilian who signed something without knowing what it was. The civilian is already being drawn toward a destination they cannot explain. The agents must contain the manifest and manage the civilian's compulsion before the Shard Construct closes in. Key tension: any agent who attempts to document their findings by writing in the margin activates a second compulsion chain.

The Quarantine Bell

Risk Tag: Catastrophic

Tier: 3

Artifact Die: d12

Emission: Burst

Origin: A field quarantine bell used during a 17th-century plague response. Recovered from a site outside Lyon by a French government archaeological survey in 1978; the survey team experienced three fatalities and a collective psychological breakdown before the site was sealed. The bell was transferred to a private collector and has been in circulation since 1979.

Form: A cast-iron hand bell, approximately 15cm tall. No maker's mark. The clapper is absent, yet the bell emits a clear, resonant tone when disturbed — even when padded, even when cradled motionless in a moving vehicle.

Containment Objective: The bell must not ring. Any sound from it — intentional, accidental, or caused by ambient vibration — counts as activation. The case succeeds when the bell is in triple-layer containment and transferred without incident to a Keep Corruption Dampening Vault.

Effect (if activated): All living targets in the same zone who hear the bell test Endure (Difficulty 2) or lose proprioception — they cannot feel pain, hunger, or fear. Affected targets gain +4 dice on Strength and Agility rolls but cannot make Empathy rolls or use Division tactical skills. They act on instinct only. **Duration:** until end of scene.

Corruption Cost: 3 for the activating agent. All targets who hear the bell — whether or not they resist the Endure test — gain +1 Corruption.

Fracture Condition: The bell cannot be silenced. It emits a continuous tone audible across 4 zones for the remainder of the scene. All targets within 4 zones gain +1 Corruption per round until the bell is physically isolated.

Containment Profile: Physical Isolation — triple redundancy required. Layer 1: dense foam-padded hard case interior. Layer 2: lead-lined outer container. Layer 3: ritually sealed outer bag (requires a Wayfinder to succeed on a Lore roll, Difficulty 1). Do not transport over rough terrain without all three layers in place.

Inadvertent activation: Dropped, struck by another object, or brought within 2 metres of a heavy vibration source (vehicle engine at idle, generator, subwoofer).

Emission (Burst): When the bell rings — including accidentally — all targets within 1-2 zones gain +1 Corruption before any activation roll is made.

DA Guidance: The Quarantine Bell is ideal for a ticking-clock transport mission. The agents must move it from a recovery site to a Keep facility — across a city, under possible surveillance, in 1980s vehicles on 1980s roads. Every speed bump, every near-collision, every moment a rival faction closes in is a potential ringing event. Frame this as a logistical thriller, not a combat encounter. The threat is the object itself, not the people pursuing it.

12.7. Division Instrument Interactions with Artifacts

The three Division Instruments (Verdant Codex, Verdant Satchel, Warden's Bracer) each interact with Occult Artifacts in specific ways. Full mechanics are in [Ch 9 — Divisions](#); the relevant interactions from an artifacts perspective are:

- **Verdant Satchel (Recovery):** Artifacts inside the Satchel do not emit passive Corruption (Aura type). The instability warning triggers when an artifact reaches Volatile or Catastrophic rating. The one-round stabilization delays activation or emission. The Satchel does not prevent Burst emissions originating from artifacts outside the bag.

- **Verdant Codex (Wayfinder):** Lore (WIT) rolls supported by Codex notes gain +1 bonus die — this applies to ritual identification rolls, artifact research, and identifying Containment Profiles.
- **Warden's Bracer (Keep):** The Bracer's once-per-session Corruption absorption (1 point, passive) applies to any Corruption source — including artifact emissions, ritual pushing costs, and passive pressure from carrying activated artifacts.

CHAPTER 13. HEADQUARTERS MANAGEMENT

This chapter covers the City Network — your cell's persistent base of operations spread across a single city — and the two systems attached to it: the HQ Upgrade Tree (spending Development Points to expand capabilities) and Covenant Standing (the cell's reputation within the Covenant, which gates access to higher-tier resources and privileged information).

Capabilities are permanent once established. They do not require ongoing maintenance or upkeep costs — the Covenant handles logistics. The cost is in Development Points and time, not recurring expenditure (#648).

In YZE games, a persistent base of operations is a fundamental pillar of long-term campaign play. In *Mutant: Year Zero* it's the Ark; in *Forbidden Lands*, the Stronghold; in *Vaesen*, Castle Gyllencreutz. In *Project Neon Relic*, the City Network serves as a mechanical anchor, a psychological safe haven from Corruption, and an economic resource sink giving players ownership over the world.

13.1. The City Network

At campaign onset, the DA designates a home city for the cell. The Covenant does not issue a single fortified building — it gives the team a network of capabilities spread across the city: a rented lab here, a safe house there, a contact at the morgue, a storage locker behind a laundromat. Each capability is a separate location within the urban landscape.

The number of agents in a cell varies by assignment:

- Major cities (New York, London, Tokyo, Berlin) — 4-6 agents, full Covenant support infrastructure
- Mid-tier cities (Portland, Lyon, Prague) — 3-4 agents, moderate support
- Remote outposts (small towns, rural regions) — 2-3 agents, minimal support, longer response times for Covenant requests

At campaign start, the cell has three baseline assets:

- A primary safe house — an apartment, back-room office, or rented commercial space that serves as the team's meeting point and rest location
- A dead drop — a pre-arranged location for receiving Covenant communications (coded messages left in a library book, a specific payphone number, a P.O. box under a cover identity)
- A cover identity package — each agent has one set of fabricated credentials sufficient for routine law enforcement encounters

Additional capabilities are acquired through the HQ Upgrade Tree using Development Points. Each upgrade represents a new asset established somewhere in the city — a facility, a contact, or a capability.

Earning Development Points

The team earns DP collectively during the Aftermath of each Case File:

Trigger	DP Earned
Case File fully resolved (mystery closed)	3
Artifact securely contained and logged with the Covenant	1
Named Threat neutralized (not just driven off)	1
Primary objective completed under active case pressure (an Organization was escalating or a relic milestone was approaching)	1
Agent rescued from rival faction custody	1

Definitions: A Named Threat is any faction operative or supernatural entity that appears as a recurring antagonist with a Covenant file entry (see [Ch 17 — Rival Factions](#)). Active case pressure means the Operations Board has at least one Organization at Escalation 2+ or a relic milestone triggered during the Case File. The primary objective is the artifact containment goal stated in the Case Brief — not any side objective the cell chose to pursue. Neutralized means captured, destroyed, or otherwise permanently removed from the board for the arc — a threat that flees and returns later does not count.

DP is spent immediately during downtime or banked for future Case Files. There is no cap on banked DP.

13.2. Vault Storage Rules

All recovered artifacts must be transferred to the Covenant's central vault — this is a non-negotiable Covenant regulation, not a suggestion. Field agents (Recovery, Wayfinder) do not have unsupervised access to vault facilities; artifact custody is the Keep's exclusive domain.

Field Custody

During a Case File, agents may temporarily hold artifacts in the field. This is expected and necessary — the vault is not in the next room. However:

- Artifacts must be in transit or in active containment at all times. Storing an active artifact in the safe house overnight without proper containment (Occult Lab containment vessels or Corruption Dampening Vault) is a Covenant infraction: -1 Standing and a formal report filed by Internal CI.
- Transfer to vault must occur during the Aftermath phase. The cell is expected to hand off recovered artifacts to a Keep transport team before beginning downtime. Failure to transfer is treated as unauthorized retention: -2 Standing and an Internal CI investigation (the DA

decides consequences based on the cell's explanation).

- Gear requisition follows proper channels. Taking Covenant equipment off-books — removing items from the Armory without logging them, borrowing from another cell's stores, or acquiring restricted items outside the Equipping Phase — risks -1 Standing per incident if discovered. The DA determines whether a given action qualifies.

Design intent: These rules exist to create tension, not to punish players. The interesting situations arise when circumstances prevent proper transfer — the Keep transport is compromised, the artifact can't be moved safely, or the cell needs to use a contained artifact to resolve a crisis. The Standing cost is the price of those decisions.

13.3. HQ Upgrade Tree

Upgrades are organized into three tiers. Higher-tier upgrades require specific lower-tier capabilities to be established first. Each upgrade represents a new asset within the city — a facility, a contact arrangement, or a capability the cell can draw on.

Tier 1 — Base Infrastructure

Tier 1 upgrades have no prerequisites. Any can be established from the start of the campaign.

Capability	DP Cost	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Secure Communications Room	2	A rented back office with encrypted landline bank, reel-to-reel tape vault, and scrambled HAM radio array. No one outside the Covenant can track calls to or from this location.	+1 die on Command (EMP) rolls when coordinating with Covenant contacts between Case Files. One free contact call per downtime (no CL requirement).
Basic Medical Bay	2	A discreet clinic arrangement — a struck-off doctor's back room, a veterinary practice after hours, or a university lab with a sympathetic researcher. Not elegant, but it keeps people alive.	During downtime, each character recovers 2 additional Attribute points of their choice (beyond normal rest). One character may also attempt to clear a non-lethal Critical Injury (Heal (WIT) Difficulty 2; success removes the injury without Attribute loss).

Capability	DP Cost	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Safeguard Protocol	1	A tripwire perimeter on the primary safe house, a dead-drop early-warning system, and pre-planned extraction routes from every regular meeting point. Not a fortress — a head start.	If any cell location is attacked, the team gains +1 die on the initiative roll during the first round of any defense scene. One random NPC contact (if any recruited) survives even if the location falls.

Tier 2 — Operational Support

Tier 2 upgrades each require at least one Tier 1 capability to be established first. Prerequisites listed per upgrade.

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
The Microfiche Archive	3	Secure Communications Room	A rented storage unit converted into a wall-to-wall collection of newspaper records, police reports, and occult journals on microfilm. A full-time archivist — never seen without reading glasses and cigarettes — maintains the stacks.	Permanent +2 Gear bonus to Lore (WIT) rolls when researching prior to departure. Also grants access to one free Historical Contact per Case File (a scholar, librarian, or researcher who owes the Covenant a favor). > Division interaction: A Wayfinder agent using the Verdant Codex in the Archive gains both the Codex's +1 bonus die and the Archive's +2 Gear bonus on the same Lore (WIT) roll.

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
The Occult Laboratory	3	Basic Medical Bay	A sterile environment in a university basement or condemned hospital wing — chemical analysis tools, EMF meters, and purpose-built containment vessels. Smells permanently of ozone and burnt copper.	Safely identify unknown artifact triggers without risking accidental activation. Lore (WIT) roll to identify artifact tier is Difficulty 1 here (instead of 2). Failed identification rolls do not trigger the artifact. > Division interaction: A Wayfinder agent using the Verdant Codex in the Lab gains +1 bonus die on the Lore (WIT) identification roll in addition to the Lab's reduced difficulty.
The Black-Market Armory	3	Safeguard Protocol	A reinforced storage unit or garage bay with analog combination locks, stocked through underground contacts the Covenant officially denies knowing. The manifest is updated by hand.	During the Equipping Phase, all agents may requisition items up to CL 4 regardless of personal CL. This does not change the agent's CL for any other purpose. High-capacity weapons no longer consume an extra DP to requisition repeatedly.

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
The Faraday Cage	4	Secure Communications Room	A lead-lined room in a rented basement, sealed against electromagnetic and supernatural interference. No phones work inside. No spirits answer. Silence like the inside of a safe.	One character per downtime can heal up to 4 Corruption. Requires a full day (one Case File downtime period) inside — the character is unavailable for other downtime activities that day. See Ch 8 — Corruption and Healing for all Corruption healing rules; the Faraday Cage is an exception that applies only during downtime at a cell location. Division interaction: A Keep agent whose Warden's Bracer provides passive Corruption absorption may still use both the Bracer's per-session absorption AND heal in the Faraday Cage — they do not conflict.

Tier 3 — Advanced Operations

Tier 3 upgrades require at least two Tier 2 capabilities to be established. Prerequisites listed per upgrade.

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Field Intelligence Network	5	Microfiche Archive + Secure Communications Room	A distributed network of informants, dead drops, and off-the-books government contacts who feed intelligence to the Covenant. Managed by a rotation of cutout contacts to maintain deniability.	Before the team departs on a Case File, it receives one free additional clue about the central threat. +1 die on Investigation rolls to identify rival faction involvement.
Covenant Armorer	5	Black-Market Armory	A former Special Forces armorer gone ghost — works out of the armory back room, asks no questions, and charges only in favors and whiskey.	Once per Case File, one item in the team's loadout can be permanently upgraded: +1 Gear Bonus to the item's listed value. The item also gains the Reliable trait (ignore the first 1 when pushing).

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Corruption Dampening Vault	6	Faraday Cage + Occult Laboratory	A reinforced sub-chamber within the Faraday Cage, retrofitted with seven-layer lead shielding, hand-drawn containment circles, and rotating salt-line maintenance. Costly to maintain and terrifying to enter alone.	Store up to 3 active artifacts without passive corruption leaking to carriers. Artifacts in the vault do not add Enc. pressure (see Ch 11 — Artifacts). Vault must be re-consecrated after 3 Case Files (Lore (WIT) Difficulty 2; failure = 1 random artifact "wakes up" — roll d6 to determine which stored artifact). Cage + Vault interaction: The Corruption Dampening Vault is a sub-chamber inside the Faraday Cage. A character healing Corruption in the Cage while artifacts are stored in the Vault sub-chamber is safe — the shielding prevents any passive emission. A Keep agent using the Containment Protocol talent (see Ch 9 — Divisions) may apply the talent's bonus to re-consecration rolls here.

Capability	DP Cost	Prerequisite	Narrative	Mechanical Benefit
Safe House Network	6	Secure Communications Room + Safeguard Protocol	A constellation of bolt-holes, friendly business fronts, and sympathetic contacts spread across the city and its neighboring region — pre-loaded with emergency cash, clean IDs, and a contact pager (each safe house maintains a dedicated pager number registered to a cutout identity).	The team always has a fallback safe house available in any investigation area, no setup required. Removes all "no safe place to rest" environmental penalties while in the field. On failure during a Compromise event, one safe house absorbs the breach instead of the compromised location (one-time use; must rebuild, 3 DP).

13.4. Personnel Recruitment

Beyond infrastructure, the team can recruit individual contacts and specialists using Development Points. Personnel provide passive benefits between Case Files and can be called upon during active missions at the DA's discretion.

Personnel are not combatants. If a cell location is directly attacked, they flee or hide — they do not fight to defend it.

Activating Personnel: Requesting a personnel benefit during a Case File requires only a narrative declaration ("I contact the Dispatcher") — no roll is required unless the DA determines the contact is under surveillance, compromised, or operating outside their stated capability. In those cases, use Command (EMP) Difficulty 2 to reach them. Personnel benefits listed as "once per Case File" reset at the start of each new Case File.

Personnel	DP Cost	Who They Are	Benefit
Station Dispatcher (Police)	2	A civilian 911 dispatcher who owes the Covenant a significant debt. Passes case-relevant police radio traffic when it crosses their desk.	Once per Case File, request police incident records, scanner traffic intercepts, or a 10-minute window of police non-response in one location.
Underground Field Medic	2	A struck-off physician — too many questions asked, too many bullet wounds treated no-questions-asked. Brilliant in a crisis.	During downtime, one character may be treated for a non-lethal Critical Injury (removes the injury without Attribute loss if a Heal (WIT) roll at Difficulty 2 succeeds). Does not replace the Basic Medical Bay; stacks with it.
Black-Market Fence	3	A procurement specialist with connections to military surplus, private security disposals, and the occasional Consortium dropout.	Once per Case File, requisition one CL 4 item without burning the team's CL. The request takes 48 hours in-game. Item arrives at a designated dead drop; no trail.
Covenant Scholar	3	A former academic — history, linguistics, or theology — recruited (or blackmailed) into the Covenant's extended network. Corresponds by mail only.	+1 die on pre-mission Lore (WIT) rolls when the scholar is consulted (same city or via correspondence). Can translate dead languages overnight (remove the "ancient language" investigation obstacle without a roll).

Personnel	DP Cost	Who They Are	Benefit
Signals Technician	4	An ex-NSA field tech — burned, paranoid, and very good at making equipment do things it shouldn't.	Once per Case File, plant a real-time audio tap on a rival faction's communication line (Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 2; success = one scene of intercepted intel). Also: +1 die on all Tech (WIT) rolls at the Secure Communications Room.

13.5. Network Compromise and Attack

The city network is not invulnerable. Rivals, government black-ops, and supernatural entities may target individual locations or the network as a whole.

The Threat Meter

The DA tracks a hidden Threat Meter ranging from 0 to 6. When it reaches 6, part of the network is directly targeted.

The Threat Meter increases by 1 when:

- The team uses explosives or automatic weapons fire in a populated area
- A rival faction agent escapes alive with knowledge of a cell location
- The team fails to contain a corruption leak (active artifact left overnight in open storage — not inside the Corruption Dampening Vault or Occult Lab containment vessels)
- A deceased agent's civilian identity is linked to the Covenant by law enforcement
- The team's case pressure escalates to crisis and breaks containment — meaning an Organization reaches Escalation 3 on the Operations Board and the Case File ends without resolution

The Threat Meter decreases by 1 at the end of any Case File in which the team was completely covert (no civilian witnesses, no law enforcement contact, no corruption incidents).

Compromise Event

When the Threat Meter hits 6, the DA triggers a Compromise Event before the next Case File begins. Roll d6:

Roll	Compromise Type
1-2	Surveillance — A rival team has eyes on one of the cell's locations. The location is not breached, but the Threat Meter resets to 4 (not 0). All Tier 2+ capabilities associated with that location are temporarily offline until the surveillance is identified and dealt with (a mini-investigation, 1 Case File).
3-4	Break-In — Evidence of entry at one location, triggered sensors, one personnel contact goes missing. One capability is compromised — to determine which, number all established capabilities in acquisition order and roll d6 (re-roll if the result exceeds your capability count). The compromised capability is unavailable until re-established at half DP cost. Threat Meter resets to 3.
5	Direct Assault — A hostile team hits a cell location hard. Run a full defense scene (see below). One capability destroyed on failure; none if the team holds. Threat Meter resets to 2.
6	Burned — One or more locations are fully compromised. No defense scene is run — the breach happens between Case Files. The team receives a single scene to extract critical equipment and personnel before the locations are abandoned. Lose all Tier 1-2 capabilities at the affected locations; Tier 3 capabilities survive only if the Safe House Network is established (they relocate to fallback addresses). Threat Meter resets to 0. All banked DP intact; rebuilding begins on the next Case File's Aftermath.

Defense Scene

If the compromise event results in a direct assault (roll 5 only — the Burned result on 6 does not use this procedure), run it as a structured conflict:

- The DA establishes attacker strength (Grunt × team size or Elite × half team size from the Bestiary).
- Safeguard Protocol gives +1 die on the team's first initiative roll.
- Characters who are Broken during a defense scene follow standard Broken rules (Critical Injury + out of fight; see [Ch 7 — Health, Damage & Armor](#)). Stabilization must occur before end of scene to prevent the Dying state.
- If the attackers are driven off or destroyed: Threat Meter resets to 2; location is undamaged.
- If the team retreats: roll on the Compromise Event table again (once) to determine collateral damage (re-roll results of 5 or 6).

Optional — Named Threats: If the Threat Meter has recently been driven up by a specific rival faction, the DA may assign a Named Threat as the assault leader. This escalates the scene but awards +2 DP if the Named Threat is captured or killed. An arc is a sequence of 3-5 Case Files centered on a shared antagonist or artifact thread; the DA determines arc boundaries.

13.6. Covenant Standing (Reputation System)

Covenant Standing is a per-cell meta-progression score that measures how the Verdant Covenant perceives your cell’s effectiveness, discretion, and reliability. It is not glamour — it does not mean fame. A cell with high Standing is one that has been trusted with increasingly sensitive operations because they do not leave messes.

Standing is tracked as a single score from 0 to 20, shared by the entire cell. It never applies to individual agents — the Covenant evaluates teams, not heroes.

Note on CL, Standing, and Requisition Authority: These three systems overlap but serve distinct purposes. A character’s personal CL (Covenant Level) represents their individual combat clearance and affects which weapons they can legally carry (see [Ch 10 — Equipment](#)). Standing is a cell-level score that unlocks collective resource access, case priority, and information tiers. Requisition Authority is an in-fiction narrative mechanism — who you can call to get things. Standing rewards (below) grant cell-wide CL requisition caps that temporarily raise what the whole team can access during equipping — but do not change any agent’s personal CL score.

Standing Ranks

Score	Rank	What It Means
0–4	Unknown	The cell is new or unproven. Covenant resources are minimal; access is limited to Tier 1 upgrades and standard requisitions. Information access: Operational briefings only — the Case Brief as written, no supplementary Covenant archive material. Lore (WIT) rolls using Covenant research assets gain no bonus dice.
5–9	Acknowledged	The cell has delivered results. Wayfinder and Keep division contacts treat the cell as credible. Information access: Standard archive access (Microfiche Archive if established); classified materials are redacted when sent. Lore (WIT) research rolls gain +1 die from Covenant channels (not from personal skill).
10–14	Trusted	The cell handles significant cases. The Covenant routes priority case files through them. Keep reinforcements available. Information access: Full archive access; classified materials available with DA approval. Lore (WIT) research rolls gain +2 dice from Covenant channels. One additional pre-case clue per Case File (DA provides it with the Case Brief).

Score	Rank	What It Means
15-19	Honored	The cell has operated at the highest levels. Named contacts within Covenant leadership. Information access: Unrestricted access including Covenant historical records and cold case files. Lore (WIT) research rolls gain +3 dice from Covenant channels. Cold case files provided on request (no roll required).
20	Covenant Elite	Fewer than a dozen cells in history have reached this. The Covenant treats the cell as irreplaceable. No resource limits. Legacy recorded. Information access: Unrestricted; may request records from allied organizations. Lore (WIT) research rolls gain +3 dice plus one automatic success from Covenant channels.

Gaining Standing

Standing increases at the end of a case when specific outcomes are achieved. All gains are cumulative — multiple criteria can apply in a single case.

Trigger	Standing Gain	Notes
Successful containment of primary artifact	+2	Artifact recovered and secure in transport or Covenant vault
Zero civilian exposure (no witnesses, no media)	+1	Bonus on top of other gains; lost if any civilian knowledge confirmed
Rival faction neutralized (operative captured/fled)	+2	Does not apply if rival escaped with artifact
Tier 3 artifact recovered intact	+3	Replaces standard containment +2 for Tier 3 cases
Cold case resolved (artifact dormant 10+ years)	+1	Bonus; applies when case origins predate the cell
Covenant agent rescued from hostile custody	+2	Applies once per arc, not per session
Case resolved without casualties (any side)	+1	Bonus; Covenant prefers clean operations
Named Threat operative captured (not just fled)	+3	Rare; named threat must be confirmed Covenant-file target

The maximum Standing gain in a single case is +6, regardless of how many triggers apply. If the combined total exceeds +6, cap it at +6. Avoid banking on Tier 3 cases to push the track — those cases

are designed to hurt.

Losing Standing

Standing losses are immediate and cannot be avoided by narrative justification. The Covenant knows. It always knows.

Trigger	Standing Loss	Notes
Confirmed civilian casualties	-2 per casualty	Witnesses who survive and go public count as -3 instead
Supernatural event reported in media	-3	Any press coverage of supernatural phenomena linked to a case
Artifact lost to rival faction or enemy	-3	Lost in the field, stolen post-recovery, or destroyed improperly
Agent compromised, turned, or gone rogue	-4	Applies whether the agent is caught or simply disappears
Case abandoned mid-operation	-2	Cell withdrew without artifact containment or Covenant approval
Cell location exposed to non-Covenant entities	-4	Does not require an attack; exposure alone is the failure
Cover story collapsed (public incident attributed to cell)	-3	Any incident where the cell is publicly connected to supernatural events

Standing cannot go below 0. The Covenant does not formally execute cells with low Standing — it simply stops routing cases to them and begins reassigning their contacts. Effective retirement.

Design Note — Asymmetry: Standing is intentionally harder to gain than to lose. A single civilian casualty costs -2 Standing; a perfect artifact recovery earns +2. This mirrors the **Corruption economy:** the Covenant, like the artifacts themselves, punishes desperation. Cells that stay clean, keep quiet, and contain artifacts properly are the only ones that last. The asymmetry is a feature, not a bug.

Standing Rewards

Standing unlocks access to resources, upgrades, and Covenant infrastructure that cannot be purchased with Development Points alone.

Reward	Min. Standing	Effect
Tier 2 Upgrades Unlocked	5	Cell may begin establishing Tier 2 capabilities (see HQ Upgrade Tree). DP cost unchanged.
CL 3 Requisition Access	5	During Equipping Phase, the entire cell may requisition items up to CL 3 — even agents whose personal CL is still 2. This does not change individual agents' personal CL score; it raises the cell-wide equipping cap only.
Keep Reinforcements	10	Once per arc (3–5 Case Files), request a second Covenant cell for 1 Case File of operational support. They arrive equipped; they do not share Standing.
Tier 3 Upgrades Unlocked	10	Cell may begin establishing Tier 3 capabilities. DP cost unchanged.
CL 4 Requisition Access	10	During Equipping Phase, the entire cell may requisition items up to CL 4 regardless of personal CL. High-tier equipment available via formal request. Does not change individual agents' personal CL scores.
Classified Archive Access	15	Wayfinder Division shares files on cold cases and artifact history normally restricted to senior analysts. +2 dice on Lore (WIT) and Investigate (WIT) rolls during pre-departure research.
Covenant Asset Call-In	15	Once per campaign arc, the Covenant deploys a named asset — insider at a government agency, black-market arms contact, demolitions specialist — to assist directly.
Legacy Standing Bonus	20	When a cell member retires or dies, their Keeper (xp replacement PC) begins play with 3 Standing already gained toward the cell total.
Unrestricted Upgrade	20	Once per arc, establish any single upgrade for 0 DP. The Covenant funds it directly.

Standing and Upgrade Gates

Some capabilities already require specific prerequisites (DP investment and prior capabilities in the upgrade tree). Standing gates apply in addition to those prerequisites for the most sensitive upgrades — meeting the DP and capability prerequisites is not sufficient alone. The capability cannot be established until both the DP/capability prerequisite AND the Standing threshold are met.

Capability	DP Cost	Min. Standing
Microfiche Archive (Tier 2)	3 DP	5
Occult Laboratory (Tier 2)	3 DP	5
Faraday Cage (Tier 2)	4 DP	5
Field Intelligence Network (Tier 3)	5 DP	10
Corruption Dampening Vault (Tier 3)	6 DP	10
Safe House Network (Tier 3)	6 DP	15
Covenant Armorer (Tier 3)	5 DP	10

> Design Note: Standing gates exist because Tier 2 and 3 capabilities represent > the Covenant extending significant trust to a cell. An unproven cell does not get > access to the Occult Laboratory or the Corruption Dampening Vault. They have to > earn it. These gates are separate from the DP economy — you can bank enough DP > to establish the Vault immediately at Standing 10; you cannot establish it at Standing 9 > regardless of DP.

=== Rival Cells (Optional Rule)

At campaign start, the DA may establish a rival Covenant cell operating in the same region. Rival cells compete for case priority, Covenant resources, and Standing.

Roll on this table during the first session:

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| d6 | Rival Cell Relationship

| 1 | Allied. The rival cell is cooperative. Shared cases award both cells +1 Standing if resolved successfully. Loss is shared too. | 2 | Indifferent. The rival cell operates on different case types. They will not interfere — unless cases overlap. | 3 | Competitive. The rival cell is racing the player cell on at least one case per arc. First to contain gains +1 Standing; second gains nothing. | 4 | Hostile (Institutional). The rival cell has filed a formal complaint against the player cell with Covenant leadership. The PC cell's next Standing gain is reduced by 1. | 5 | Compromised. The rival cell has a mole. They do not know. The player cell may — do they report it and lose a potential ally, or use it? | 6 | Shadow. The rival cell does not officially exist. Their operations leave no records. When their cases intersect with the player cell, nothing is as it seems.

Rival Cell Standing: Track the rival cell's Standing separately. If a rival cell reaches a Standing tier higher than the player cell's, the Covenant begins routing priority cases to the rival — the next case the player cell receives is a leftover (roll Complication twice, keep both results).

=== Rival Cell Interaction Mechanics

When the player cell and a rival cell intersect on the same Case File, resolve shared-territory conflicts with these procedures:

* **Contested Artifact Recovery:** Both cells find the same artifact in the same scene. Each cell makes a Sneak (AGI) or Investigate (WIT) contested roll (the cell as a group uses the highest relevant skill). The winner reaches the artifact first; the loser may pursue or withdraw. A tie means the artifact is found simultaneously — negotiate or fight. * **Shared Information:** If the rival cell holds information the player cell needs, they may trade (one clue for one clue), negotiate (Command (EMP) Difficulty 3 to extract it freely), or coerce (Athletics (STR) or Intimidate (EMP) Difficulty 2, but triggers -1 Standing for aggression against a Covenant cell). * **Combined Operations:** If both cells cooperate (DA's call), each cell adds 1 die to all rolls for the duration of the scene. Both cells share the DP and Standing gains. If the operation goes badly, both cells share the losses. * **Hostile Cell Escalation:** A Hostile or Compromised rival cell may actively oppose the player cell. Treat their operatives as NPCs with stats equal to the player cell's average. If the rival cell is destroyed, gain +2 DP and +1 Standing (once per arc).

== DA Pacing Guidance

=== When to Advance the Threat Meter

The Threat Meter should tick up *during play*, not as a between-Case-File bookkeeping exercise. Announce increases openly when they result from visible player actions (explosives, escaped witnesses). Only advance it silently when the cause is something the players genuinely wouldn't know about (a rival faction operative spotting a cell location, a deceased agent's ID surfacing). Keep the meter itself hidden — the dread of not knowing how close they are to a Compromise Event is the point.

Run Compromise Events when the meter hits 6 — do not delay them into the next arc. They're not punishments; they're Case Files. Treat the Surveillance or Break-In results as seeds for a mini-investigation, not as flat negative outcomes.

=== Pacing Upgrades

A typical campaign arc (3–5 Case Files) should end with the cell establishing one Tier 2 capability if they're playing clean. Don't accelerate this — the upgrade tree is meant to feel like tangible progress over a campaign, not an early session loadout. The DP triggers are calibrated so that a cell succeeding on every award earns roughly 7–9 DP per Case File; a Tier 2 capability costs 3–4 DP. Pace accordingly.

The Faraday Cage is the single most important upgrade in the tree. Don't introduce it until the cell has had at least one scene where Corruption was a genuine crisis. Unlocking the Cage should feel like survival, not optimization.

=== Introducing Rival Cells

| # | Debriefing Question

| 1 | Did you participate in the session? (Automatic +1 XP — this is always yes.) | 2 | Did you risk your life for a fellow Covenant member or an innocent civilian? | 3 | Did you interact heavily with your Anchor, or did a personal connection complicate the mission? (An Anchor is a personal solace — a ritual, a memory, a relationship — that grounds the agent against the toll of the work. It is defined at character creation. See [Ch 2 — Character Creation](#).) | 4 | Did the team successfully secure or contain an Occult Artifact? | 5 | Did you learn something new and significant about the supernatural threat or rival factions?

=== Spending XP

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| Upgrade | XP Cost | Limit

| Increase a Skill by 1 | 5 XP | Maximum rating of 5 | Purchase a new Talent | 6 XP | General, Division, or Wing/Paradigm/Department Talent

> Note on CL and Standing: Clearance Level is no longer purchased directly with XP. To increase a character's personal CL, purchase the Requisition Authority general talent (6 XP, repeatable). This raises the individual agent's permanent CL independent of team Standing. Separately, team Standing (see [Ch 12 — Headquarters](#)) grants the entire cell a temporary equipping-phase cap (CL 3 at Standing 5, CL 4 at Standing 10) — but this is a cell-wide access floor, not a personal CL increase. If an agent's personal CL is already higher than the cell's Standing-granted floor, use their personal CL. If lower, use whichever is higher during the Equipping Phase only.

=== Worked Example: Session Debrief and Talent Purchase

The following shows a typical post-session debrief for Agent Yusuf Demi, a Keep Warden currently at Clearance Level 2 with 8 XP carried over from the previous Case File.

The DA runs the debrief questions:

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| Debriefing Question | Answer | Result

| Did you participate in the session? | Yes | +1 XP

| Did you risk your life for a fellow Covenant member or an innocent civilian? | Yes — Yusuf entered the artifact room to pull Agent Skovgaard to safety when triple-layer containment cracked. | +1 XP

| Did you interact heavily with your Anchor, or did a personal connection complicate the mission? | Yes — Yusuf spent a quiet evening shift writing a letter to his mother in Istanbul, a ritual that grounds him after containment work. | +1 XP

| Did the team successfully secure or contain an Occult Artifact? | Yes — the artifact reached

the Keep vault intact. | +1 XP

| Did you learn something new and significant about the supernatural threat or rival factions?

| No — the team already knew the artifact's provenance from prior Wayfinder reports. | —

Result: 4 XP earned this session. Added to 8 XP carried over: 12 XP total.

Yusuf's player spends XP:

* 6 XP Requisition Authority talent (CL 2 CL 3). The Watch Commander issued a formal written commendation during the case closure review, explicitly noting the intact transport as mission-critical. The DA agrees this is a valid fiction trigger and approves the purchase. * 6 XP remain for future sessions.

> DA note: Requisition Authority purchases should be supported by a fiction trigger — a commendation, a formal reassignment, or a documented mission assessment that the Covenant acknowledges. If the trigger hasn't been established in play, ask the player to name one before approving. The increase marks institutional recognition, not just personal growth.

== General Talents

This is the canonical General Talents list used at character creation and during XP advancement. General Talents use the same concise format as the rest of the manuscript's talent lists: talent name plus effect text, with tags only when mechanically relevant.

> Healing Tag and Stacking: Talents with the (Healing) tag can heal Corruption. Each tagged talent's trigger is independent, but a character may heal a maximum of 3 Corruption per session from Healing-tagged General Talents combined — regardless of how many they possess or how many triggers fire. This cap does not apply to Corruption healed by city network capabilities, the Warden's Bracer, or Division talents.

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| Talent | Effect

| Street Medic | Restore 2 physical Attribute points instead of 1 when successfully using Heal (WIT). | Cathartic Release (Healing) | Once per session, dedicate a moment to breaking down, screaming, or venting — this must occur in a scene where you are not actively in conflict. Heal 1 Corruption. | Hair-Trigger | Draw a weapon as a free action instead of a fast action. Critical edge in ambushes. | Paranormal Intuition | When entering a new room or location, roll Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 1. On success, the DA must tell you if a supernatural entity has been here in the last 24 hours. This roll cannot be pushed. | Heavy Packer | Your carry capacity increases to Strength × 3 Enc. (instead of the standard Strength × 2). You are not Overloaded until your Enc. exceeds Strength × 4 (instead of Strength × 3). | Skeptic's Shield | Once per session, when exposed to a minor supernatural effect — defined as any effect that deals 1 or fewer Corruption, does not cause physical damage, and has no lasting duration — you may outright ignore it by rigidly refusing to acknowledge the impossible. Does not apply to Burst or Catastrophic artifact effects. | Night Owl | Ignore all penalties from sleep deprivation. When operating in darkness, you treat Darkness as Dim (-1 die, not -2 dice). | Chain Smoker (Healing) |

Consume a period-appropriate scarce resource (cigarettes, specific 1980s junk food, etc.) during a non-conflict moment. Heal 1 Corruption. The resource must actually be spent and removed from your inventory. | Analog Junkie | Gain +2 bonus dice when using period-accurate 1980s technology (ham radios, acoustic couplers, microfiche, reel-to-reel). The equipment must be correctly identified as 1980s-era gear; the DA rules on edge cases. | Grit Your Teeth | Once per session, ignore a -1 Attribute penalty for a single roll. Declare before rolling. | Desensitized | Gain +1 bonus die on Endure (STR) or Empathy (EMP) rolls when witnessing or investigating horrific or gruesome scenes (DA-designated — typically scenes involving mass casualties, mutilation, or sustained supernatural terror). Does not apply to standard combat or single-casualty crime scenes. | Lucky Coin | Once per session, ignore a 1 rolled on a single Gear die, preventing item degradation. Declare after seeing the roll. | Iron Will (Healing) | When you personally deliver the killing blow to a Named Threat or banish a supernatural entity (using the Banishment ritual in full), heal 1 Corruption. A "killing blow" requires your attack to reduce the target to 0 Strength. Banishment must be a completed ritual, not just an attack on an entity. | Brawler | Unarmed strikes inflict base damage of 2 instead of 1. | Flee the Scene | Gain +2 bonus dice to Agility (ATT) when rolling explicitly to escape a conflict or pursue fleeing targets. | Requisition Authority (Repeatable) | Increase your personal Clearance Level by 1 (maximum CL 5). May be purchased multiple times. No Standing prerequisite — this talent represents individual institutional recognition, useful for agents who want personal CL access before the team's Standing catches up to that tier. Purchasing this talent does not count toward or substitute the team's Standing-based access rewards.

== Background Talents

Everyone was someone else before joining The Covenant. Your background offers a unique perspective on how you interact with the world around you. You may select a background from the list, or work with your Director to create something unprecedented.

Each Background Talent grants +1 bonus die on rolls using a specific skill. This is a bonus die added to the dice pool — it is not a permanent increase to the skill's rating. The skill's rating (1-5) does not change; you simply roll one additional d6 on those rolls. Background Talents have no Corruption cost and no activation requirement — the bonus is always active.

> Design Note — Skill Distribution: The current Background Talent list skews heavily toward Investigate, Lore, and Manipulate backgrounds. This reflects the game's investigation focus but may limit variety for combat-oriented characters. Players who want to reinforce Firearms, Brawl, or Force may find fewer natural-fit options. DAs are encouraged to approve custom backgrounds (one background, one skill, one narrative concept) when the list doesn't match the character concept.

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| Background | Bonus Die Skill | Description

| Accountant | +1 Investigate | You spent years tracking numbers, discrepancies, and hidden financial patterns. Few irregularities escape your trained eye. | Actor | +1 Manipulate | You are comfortable becoming someone else entirely, adopting personas and convincing others of your

performance. | Amateur Astronomer | +1 Investigate | Long nights studying the skies have sharpened your patience and your ability to notice subtle anomalies. | Amateur Radio Operator | +1 Tech | You built and maintained your own radio equipment, speaking across the airwaves with strangers around the world. | Archaeologist | +1 Lore | You studied the remnants of ancient civilizations and learned to interpret artifacts buried by time. | Artist | +1 Investigate | Your eye for composition, pattern, and subtle detail allows you to notice things others overlook. | Athlete | +1 Endure | Rigorous training and competition have hardened your body and stamina. | Bartender | +1 Psychoanalyze | You've listened to countless confessions and learned to read people when they think no one is watching. | Birdwatcher | +1 Investigate | You possess extraordinary patience and observational skill developed from quietly studying wildlife. | Board Game Enthusiast | +1 Command | Strategic thinking and anticipating opponents' moves comes naturally to you. | Bodyguard | +1 Brawl | Protecting others from physical harm is your profession, and you know how to handle yourself in close quarters. | Bookseller | +1 Lore | Years surrounded by literature and obscure texts have broadened your knowledge. | Chess Grandmaster | +1 Command | You think several moves ahead and naturally direct others toward strategic goals. | Collector | +1 Lore | You have spent years hunting, cataloging, and preserving rare and unusual items. | Construction Worker | +1 Force | Heavy labor has made you strong and capable of breaking through physical barriers. | Cook | +1 Endure | Long hours in demanding kitchen environments have built your stamina and resilience. | Courier | +1 Sneak | Moving unnoticed and navigating complex urban spaces is second nature to you. | Detective | +1 Investigate | Solving mysteries and reconstructing events from fragments of evidence is your specialty. | Doctor | +1 Psychoanalyze | Treating patients has given you a keen understanding of human behavior and distress. | Electrician | +1 Tech | You know how to wire, repair, and safely manipulate electrical systems. | Engineer | +1 Tech | Your technical education allows you to understand machines, structures, and mechanical systems. | Factory Worker | +1 Endure | Years of repetitive, demanding labor have toughened your body. | Farmer | +1 Endure | You are accustomed to harsh weather, long days, and physically demanding work. | Firefighter | +1 Force | You are trained to break through barriers and force entry during emergencies. | Fisher | +1 Endure | Working long hours on the water has given you patience and resilience. | Food Service Professional | +1 Manipulate | You have mastered the art of dealing with difficult people while maintaining composure. | Gambler | +1 Deft Hands | You know how to move cards, chips, and small objects without drawing attention. | Gardener | +1 Lore | Your knowledge of plants, natural cycles, and organic growth runs deep. | Hiker | +1 Endure | You are accustomed to long treks through rough terrain and difficult conditions. | Historian | +1 Lore | You have studied the past and understand how ancient events shape the present. | Journalist | +1 Investigate | Asking questions and digging for the truth is part of your nature. | Librarian | +1 Lore | You have spent years cataloging and studying vast collections of knowledge. | Locksmith | +1 Deft Hands | Locks, tumblers, and mechanical security devices are familiar tools of your trade. | Lockpicking Hobbyist | +1 Deft Hands | What began as a pastime has made you remarkably skilled with delicate mechanisms. | Mechanic | +1 Tech | Engines, machines, and broken equipment rarely intimidate you. | Metal Detectorist | +1 Investigate | You've spent countless hours searching for hidden objects beneath the earth. | Military Veteran | +1 Firearms | You received formal training in weapons and battlefield discipline. | Model Builder | +1 Tech | Constructing detailed models has taught you patience and mechanical understanding. | Musician | +1 Manipulate | You know how to influence the emotions of a room through performance and presence. | Nurse | +1 Psychoanalyze |

You are accustomed to comforting the injured and calming frightened people. | Office Clerk | +1 Investigate | Handling paperwork and records has trained you to recognize patterns and inconsistencies. | Park Ranger | +1 Sneak | You are skilled at moving quietly through wilderness environments. | Pharmacist | +1 Lore | You understand medicines, chemicals, and their effects on the human body. | Photographer | +1 Investigate | You instinctively notice visual details others miss. | Pilot | +1 Tech | Operating complex vehicles and navigation equipment is part of your training. | Police Officer | +1 Firearms | You are trained in the proper use of service weapons. | Priest | +1 Manipulate | Your words carry moral authority and influence over others. | Private Investigator | +1 Investigate | Tracking people and uncovering hidden truths is your livelihood. | Professor | +1 Lore | Your academic background grants you extensive theoretical knowledge. | Sailor | +1 Endure | Life at sea has taught you to withstand difficult conditions. | Salesperson | +1 Manipulate | Convincing people to trust and believe you is part of your profession. | Scientist | +1 Investigate | You rely on observation, experimentation, and analysis. | Security Guard | +1 Command | You are trained to maintain order and direct people during incidents. | Shopkeeper | +1 Manipulate | Negotiating with customers and suppliers has sharpened your social instincts. | Sports Fan | +1 Command | Years of studying team strategy and leadership dynamics influence how you guide others. | Student | +1 Lore | Your academic studies have given you a foundation of knowledge. | Survivalist | +1 Endure | You train to endure extreme environments and catastrophic scenarios. | Taxi Driver | +1 Sneak | You know how to navigate cities and move through them without drawing attention. | Teacher | +1 Command | You are skilled at directing groups and keeping people focused. | Technician | +1 Tech | You repair and maintain specialized equipment. | Translator | +1 Manipulate | Understanding language nuances allows you to influence conversations and negotiations. | Urban Explorer | +1 Sneak | You specialize in quietly entering and navigating abandoned structures. | Watchmaker | +1 Deft Hands | You possess remarkable dexterity working with tiny mechanical components. | Woodworker | +1 Force | Years of manual craftsmanship have strengthened your hands and arms. | Writer | +1 Investigate | Research and storytelling have sharpened your ability to uncover hidden truths.

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Classification: Top Secret — Director Eyes Only

Distribution: Director of Agents Materials — Do Not Distribute to Players *

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Running Neon Relic well means understanding what kind of game it is trying to be: an investigation horror game where the real terror is not the monster in the vault, but the agents' growing awareness that the Covenant cannot fully protect them from what they're being asked to do.

This chapter gives you the tools to prepare and run individual cases, develop mysteries that hold together under player pressure, and handle the unexpected. Use it as a working reference, not a rulebook.

== What Makes Neon Relic Work

Before the mechanical tools, three design priorities that should inform every session you run:

- . Clues are discoverable, not gateable. Players should never feel stupid for missing something. Every site has multiple paths to the same revelation. The players will find it. Your job is to make the finding feel earned.

- . The Covenant is not infallible. Headquarters, the Verdant Codex, and the Division protocols exist in tension with the facts in the field. Let them be wrong sometimes. Let the players be right when the institution isn't.

- . The artifacts are not neutral. Every artifact has a trajectory — a direction it pulls the world. Make sure some of that pull lands on the agents. Corruption is not just a penalty; it is the story.

=== Default Protagonist Power Level

Run Neon Relic as a game about competent but vulnerable specialists.

* Agents are trained enough to make plans, read a scene, and act decisively. * They are not safe enough to treat Talents, Division items, or artifact use as guaranteed solutions. * When a player ability fires, it should usually create access, buy time, reveal a lead, or reduce fallout — not erase the need for

| Part | Function

| Name | What the pressure is. This appears in the leftmost cell of the row.

| Starting Value | How many countdown squares remain at case start (e.g., 6 means columns 14-7 are pre-filled, leaving 6 squares). Lower starting values mean the organization is already close to crisis.

| Active / Dormant | Whether the organization starts active or dormant. Dormant organizations are pre-printed on the board with the Active checkbox unchecked. They become active when triggered by agent action, a milestone cross-link, or a relic milestone.

| Milestones (O#M#) | 3-5 milestones labeled with O#M# shorthand (e.g., 01M1, 01M2). Each milestone describes what happens when that square is reached. Milestone text includes any cross-link consequences — instructions to advance other organization rows or trigger events.

| Triggers | What advances the row: time, noise, publicity, violence, packet interception, missed opportunity, or rival confidence.

| Player-Facing Signs | What the agents can notice before or as it worsens.

=== Milestone Cross-Links

Organizations affect each other through milestone text. When writing milestones, include any consequences that ripple across the board:

_ 01M2: Police issue a public appeal for witnesses. Advance 03 (Media) by 1 square.

02M3: A wounded thief surfaces at the clinic. Advance 01 (Police) by 2 squares and 04 (Compact) by 1 square.

Cross-links create cascading pressure without requiring arrows or special notation on the grid.

=== Organization Design Rule

If an organization cannot produce visible signs before it becomes a problem, it will feel arbitrary. Give players ways to notice tightening pressure without announcing the DA's numbers.

Recommend a maximum of ~8 organization rows per case. If you need more than 8, consider whether two organizations are really the same pressure source with different faces.

== Authoring Relic Milestones

Relic milestones define what the anomaly does if it remains uncontained. This is distinct from rival behavior. Relic milestones are keyed to specific days on the Operations Board's shift row — when the DA fills a shift quadrant that crosses a relic milestone, the artifact event triggers immediately.

When authoring relic milestones, answer:

* What does exposure look like early? * What becomes worse after repeated movement, blood, speech, weather, witnesses, or failed handling? * What is the threshold event if the case goes long or loud?

=== Relic Milestone Rule

Do not write relic milestones as generic "things get spooky." Each milestone should push toward the artifact's core logic.

If the artifact is about command, its milestones should produce obedience, claimant behavior, or legitimacy crises. If it is about repetition, its milestones should create loops, reenactments, or false returns.

Write each milestone keyed to a day number and include any cross-link consequences:

Day 10: Dream-bleed begins affecting witnesses within 100 meters.

Day 7: The relic begins selecting a claimant. Advance 01 (Police) by 1 square — unexplained behavior reports increase.

Day 2: Environmental logic around the artifact inverts. Temperature, sound, and gravity become unreliable within 50 meters. _

| Field | Design Note

| Secret | Something the NPC is hiding from the agents. Not necessarily sinister — a witness might be hiding that they trespassed, not that they're a cultist. The secret creates the reason they don't just tell the agents everything at the start. | Goal | What the NPC is actively trying to accomplish right now. Not a background motivation — a current action. They are doing something during this case. | Artifact Connection | How did this NPC encounter the case's artifact, and what effect has that proximity had on them? Even tangential NPCs should have a small Corruption consequence (nightmares, strange certainty about things they can't know). | Starting Knowledge | Information IDs (I#) the NPC knows at case start. A police detective knows the crime scene details (I1). A museum curator knows the artifact's provenance (I3). Starting knowledge determines what the NPC can share from the first encounter. | Gained Knowledge | Information the NPC learns at specific organization milestones. Write these as milestone triggers: "At O2M2: knows Compact handler name (I7)." Gained knowledge makes NPCs feel like active participants in a moving case, not static dispensers. | Positive Result | What happens when the agents engage the NPC successfully — Information IDs shared, introductions made, access granted. Write specific results so the DA reads from the card instead of improvising. | Negative Result | What happens when the encounter goes badly — organization advance on the Operations Board, tail placed, witness spooked, location access revoked. Negative results create consequences without requiring DA judgment calls.

=== The Motivated NPC Test

Ask: If the agents were not present, what would this NPC do? If the answer is nothing — if the NPC only exists as an information dispenser — cut them or give them an active agenda. NPCs with active agendas create situations. Situation creators make sessions run.

== Supernatural Entity Behavior

Supernatural entities in Neon Relic do not think the way humans do. Avoid playing them like slow, dangerous people. Use these behavioral templates:

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| Entity Type | Behavior Pattern

| Echoing Remnant | Acts on memory, not will. Repeats actions associated with its final emotional state. An Echoing Remnant from a violent event will reenact something about that event — not attack intelligently. Agents who understand the echo can sometimes avoid it entirely. | Shard Construct | Single-directive: protect the artifact. No curiosity, no self-preservation beyond mission, no social engagement. Cannot be persuaded or manipulated. Can be outmaneuvered (if you aren't between the Construct and the artifact, it doesn't care about you). | Bound Entity | Has a will, has a history, has something it wants. Bound Entities can be communicated with through Lore and Psychoanalyze (not Manipulate — they see through human social mechanics). They respond to truth, to acknowledgment of what happened to them. They can

be bargained with. | Manifest Presence | A high-tier supernatural intrusion: an entity that has begun to impose its logic on local reality. Does not fight — it redefines the situation. Agents trying to act normally in its presence find that normality is no longer available. These entities are solved through removing their anchor (the artifact) or performing a containment ritual, not fought.

== Improvisation Guidelines

When players go somewhere you didn't prepare:

- . You don't need to have everything ready. You need to know the five elements and the clue web. Everything else can be invented. . Names first. The moment you name an NPC, they become real. Have ten era-appropriate names ready (female and male, surname-friendly for your campaign region in the 1980s).
- . Establish geography. "You pull into the parking lot of a strip mall. One end is a closed sporting goods store. The other end is still lit — a late-night laundromat." Specificity creates presence. . Every new location has one strange thing. Not necessarily supernatural. One thing that's slightly off. This makes the world feel watched, even when nothing is watching.

== 1980s Investigation Complication Table (D12)

Roll when you need an unexpected complication mid-case, when a scene is going too smoothly, or to generate pre-session texture.

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| D12 | Complication

| 1 | The key witness has already spoken to MJ-12. Their story has been changed. They are now afraid of the agents. | 2 | A news crew is covering a tangentially related story. They saw something they shouldn't have. They are currently in their van, developing film. | 3 | The physical evidence the team collected has a fingerprint trace that leads to a Covenant asset who should not be connected to this case. | 4 | The local police are investigating the same location. They are incompetent but present. Their cruiser is in the way. | 5 | A pay phone at a critical location rings as the team arrives. The call is from someone who knows the team's names. | 6 | It's raining. This matters: the evidence site is compromised, the getaway is slower, the team's electronics are at risk, visibility is the wrong kind of limited. | 7 | A civilian has bonded with the artifact without knowing what it is. They are treating it as a lucky object. It has begun affecting them. They are protective and confused by their protectiveness. | 8 | The rival faction's operative is not hostile — they are also following orders and they are also scared. They want to talk. Their faction doesn't know they made contact. | 9 | The building's owner is on-site for unrelated maintenance. They are nosy, unhelpful, and will remember the team's faces. | 10 | A secondary artifact — unrelated to this case — has been stored in the same facility. It has interacted with the primary artifact. Both are behaving unexpectedly. | 11 | The extraction vehicle has been reported stolen. The team's transportation is being tracked by a local

detective who has no idea what he's looking for but is very thorough. | 12 | The case's solution requires a resource that Stack misclassified three months ago. The item exists; it is in the wrong vault. Getting it takes the rest of the session, minimum.

== Running Containment Missions

Not every case ends with an artifact activation. Many of the Covenant's most important operations are containment runs — missions where success means the artifact was never used, never heard, never seen by an unauthorized party. These cases require different framing than activation-centric play.

=== Defining Non-Activation Objectives

Before the session begins, define a concrete containment goal separate from any activation contingency:

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| Containment Objective | Example Mission Frame

| Physical isolation | The artifact is in a civilian's vehicle. Recover it before the civilian reaches their destination. Do not let them open the compartment.

| Quarantine and witness management | Three people have already been exposed. Contain them, suppress their account of what they saw, and move the artifact before the rival faction arrives.

| Chain-of-custody transfer | The artifact must travel from a recovery site to a Keep vault. Every handoff is a risk. The agents must complete the transfer with fewer than three custody breaks.

| Deny use by rival faction | A rival faction intends to activate the artifact at a specific time and place. The agents must prevent the conditions for activation — not necessarily seize the artifact themselves.

=== Pressure Without Activation

Containment missions still have escalating pressure. Use these tools to maintain tension without triggering the artifact:

- * The emission is already active. Even before the agents reach the artifact, nearby NPCs may show early Corruption symptoms — confusion, obsessive focus on mundane tasks, sudden certainty about things they cannot know. This makes extraction urgent without requiring activation.

- * The containment profile creates constraints. If the artifact cannot be exposed to light, the agents must plan their extraction around darkness, covered transport, and power failures. Constraints are interesting problems, not punishment.

- * Rivalry without combat. A rival faction wants the artifact activated; the agents want it contained. This is a race against the Operations Board countdown, not a default firefight. Rival agents may intercept, deceive, or manufacture the activation conditions even as players try to prevent them.

If ritual containment is a possible solution, seed three discoverable facts across Locations, NPC Cards, and Information Cards before play begins:

- * What forms the boundary (salt, copper wire, lead foil, blackout cloth, a drawn sigil, etc.)
- * What the key is (true name, activation condition, phrase, symbol, or anchor logic)
- * What must be physically contained afterward (the anchor object, the carrier, the room, the recording equipment, the ritual site)

Ritual scenes work best when the team earns the procedure through investigation and then executes it under pressure.

Use [Artifacts](#) [Containment Rituals](#) for the actual field procedure.

- * .A Note on Containment Rituals Containment rituals are intentionally unstandardized. The Covenant's centuries of experience have produced one consistent finding: no two artifacts respond to the same procedure. Some require elaborate multi-day ceremonies with precise geometric arrangements and chanted invocations. Others are neutralized by placing them in a lead-lined box, singing a specific lullaby, or — in one documented case — reading aloud from a telephone directory while the artifact sits in a bowl of salt water.

When designing containment rituals for your Case Files, let the artifact's origin and personality dictate the process. The base mechanics (Lore rolls, Difficulty modifiers, Decay advancement) are provided in [Chapter 11 — Artifacts](#). Everything else is yours to invent. The stranger and more specific the ritual, the better. Agents should feel like they're solving a puzzle unique to each artifact, not following a standard operating procedure. *

=== Measuring Success in Containment Cases

A containment case is resolved when all three of the following are true:

- . The artifact is inert — in transit, sealed under its Containment Profile, without activation during the case.
- . Exposure is controlled — no uncontained witness has unsuppressed knowledge of the artifact's effects.
- . Handoff is complete — the artifact is logged with the Keep under a valid chain of custody.

| Undertaking | What It Looks Like

| Scene | Go somewhere, talk to someone, investigate something. This is the heart of most shifts.

| Travel | Move to a new city, region, or country. May cost multiple shifts depending on distance and method. See [Travel and Journey Rules](#).

| Surveillance | Watch a location or person without engaging. Results arrive later. The DA notes what the stakeout will reveal and which shift it pays off.

| Research | Dig through records, study a relic fragment, or analyze a sample. Usually generates a delayed result.

| Preparation | Acquire gear, set up a safe house, prepare a containment site, brief an ally. Not glamorous, but sometimes the difference between a clean recovery and a catastrophe.

| Recovery | Rest, treat injuries, manage Corruption. The world keeps moving while the agents do nothing. That is the cost.

==== Split Operations

Agents may split across different locations during the same shift. Each subgroup resolves their scene independently — the DA handles one group's scene, then the other's, or alternates between them at dramatic moments. This is efficient but dangerous: backup is a full shift away, and agents operating alone or in pairs lose access to skill coverage they may desperately need. A split team can cover more ground but cannot respond to complications together.

Communication between split groups during a shift requires payphones or pre-arranged check-in times. If one group encounters a threat, the other group cannot intervene until the following shift unless they abandon their current undertaking (losing the shift with no benefit).

Split operations do not change how the Operations Board advances — one shift still passes for all active organizations, regardless of how many locations the team covers.

=== Step 3: Send a Packet (Optional)

The team may send one Covenant Request Packet during any shift. A packet is a communication to Covenant headquarters — Wayfinder research, Keep logistics, or Recovery field support — asking for information, analysis, or assistance. Packets are the agents' institutional lifeline, and they are deliberately slow.

=== Step 4: Resolve the Undertaking

Play out the scene, handle the travel, resolve the support action. This is where dice hit the table, NPCs talk, and consequences emerge. When a shift becomes an active scene, use the Scene Resolution procedure described later in this chapter.

=== Step 5: Advance the Board

After the undertaking resolves, update the Operations Board:

. Fill the next shift quadrant on the shift row. If this completes a milestone day, the relic milestone triggers immediately — read the milestone description from the Case Brief and play it out. . Advance any organization rows that were triggered by what happened during this shift. A loud scene, a visible arrest, a failed containment attempt, or simply the passage of time can cause one or more organizations to escalate. Cross out the next empty square on each affected row, moving toward column 1. . Check for organization milestones. If an organization's countdown has reached a milestone square, read the milestone description and execute its consequences. This may advance other organizations, activate dormant rows, or change what is available at a Location.

=== Step 6: Note Delayed Returns

If anything during this shift created a future payoff — a packet sent, a stakeout started, a lab sample submitted — write down three things: what will come back, the earliest shift it can arrive, and what could disrupt it. Delayed returns are one of the main reasons Neon Relic feels like procedural investigation instead of omniscient adventuring.

== Scene Resolution

| Contribution Type | What It Does

| Immediate | Direct support happening right now — covering fire, distraction, medical assist, persuasion backup. Adds dice to the Key Activity roll.

| Shield | Protective action — watching exits, managing witnesses, running interference with police. Does not add dice but reduces consequences on a bad result.

| Position | Setting up future advantage — planting a tracking device, photographing documents, establishing an escape route. Does not affect this scene but creates a benefit for the next one.

| Delayed | Launching a parallel thread — sending a packet, starting surveillance on the back entrance, making a phone call to an asset. The result arrives in a future shift.

. Roll what matters. The Key Activity player rolls their dice pool. Contributions modify the outcome as described above.

. The DA discloses results. The outcome falls into one of five bands:

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| Result Band | What Happens

| Clean Progress | The agents get what they came for. The scene objective is achieved without complications. Information is revealed, access is granted, an NPC cooperates.

| Progress With Cost | The agents achieve the objective, but something goes wrong along the way — an organization advances on the board, a witness is spooked, a trail of evidence is left behind, or someone takes Corruption.

| Partial Progress | Some of what the agents wanted is achieved, but a key piece is missing or a complication arises. They learn part of the truth but not all of it. They get access but the NPC holds something back.

| Setback With Signal | The scene goes badly, but the agents learn something from the failure. They do not get what they came for, but the DA reveals a clue, an NPC's true allegiance, or a direction for the next move. Information should still flow even on failure.

| Breach | The scene goes loud, public, or occultly unstable. An organization row advances immediately, a relic milestone may trigger, and the next shift starts under severe pressure.

The goal of scene resolution is to keep information flowing regardless of dice results. A failed roll should produce movement, not silence. If the agents botch the approach at the church archive, they still notice that someone else has been through the records recently. If the handoff goes wrong at the port, they see the Compact fixer's face before he disappears. Dead air is the enemy of investigation games.

== Organization Rows

Below the shift row, the Operations Board holds organization rows — countdown tracks representing external pressure sources that are reacting to the case independently of the agents with their own agendas and timetables.

=== What Organizations Represent

An organization is any external force that creates pressure in the case. Not every organization is hostile — some are simply institutional, operating on their own timetable and making the agents' work harder through indifference or competing priorities.

Examples:

* A police inquiry consolidating witness reports and closing in on the crime scene * A Compact recovery team replacing burned cutouts and reestablishing their acquisition chain * Church custodians attempting a parallel recovery through their own historical channels * Customs officials tightening port scrutiny after an anonymous tip * A media outlet investigating the same event for entirely mundane reasons

Organizations respond to agent activity, visible anomalies, publicity, money movement, faction paranoia, and missed opportunities. A standard case should have four to eight organization rows — enough to create cross-pressure without overwhelming the DA's tracking. More than eight organizations are rarely needed and tend to produce redundant pressure rather than distinct threats.

=== How Organization Rows Work

Each organization row has:

* A name identifying the faction or pressure source * An Active checkbox — checked when the organization is in play, unchecked for dormant organizations * 14 countdown squares matching the board's 14 columns

At case start, the DA fills in squares from column 14 inward to the organization's starting value. An organization starting at 6 has columns 14 through 7 already filled — only 6 squares remain before catastrophe. That dead space on the board is visual shorthand for how close the threat is.

When an organization escalates, the DA crosses out the next empty square moving toward column 1. When a milestone square is reached, its event triggers. Milestone squares are labeled with O#M# shorthand — O1M1 means Organization 1, Milestone 1; O2M3 means Organization 2, Milestone 3. The milestone descriptions live in the Organization Reference document, not on the grid itself.

=== Cross-Links

| Field | What It Contains

| Name | The location's name — the estate, the police station, the church archive, the clinic.

| Description | What the agents see when they arrive. This is the read-aloud or paraphrased opening.

| Availability | How the Location becomes accessible. Use one of these keywords: open (available from case start), clue-locked (requires specific information), contact-locked (requires an NPC introduction or referral), time-locked (opens on a specific day), or packet-locked (unlocked when a Covenant packet returns).

| NPCs Present | Which NPCs can be found here. This may change at milestones — for example, "After O4M2: Suárez pulled off the case."

| Information Available | The Information Card IDs (I#) discoverable at this location.

| Organizations Present | Which organizations have interest or operational presence here (O# shorthand). This tells the DA which rows might advance based on what happens in this scene.

| Positive Result | What the agents gain from a successful engagement — Information IDs learned, NPC access granted, new Locations opened.

| Negative Result | What happens if the scene goes badly — organization advances on the board, tails established, witnesses spooked, Locations closed.

| Milestone Changes | How this Location changes when specific organization milestones are reached — "When O4M2: Suárez pulled off case. When O4M3: station locked down."

=== NPC Cards

An NPC Card is a playing-card-sized reference that the DA pulls alongside a Location form. Each NPC exists independently — they may appear at multiple Locations and carry their own evolving knowledge.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| Field | What It Contains

| Name | The NPC's name.

| Organization | Affiliated organization (O# shorthand), faction, or independent.

| Secret | What they are hiding — not necessarily sinister, but always relevant.

| Goal | What they are actively trying to accomplish right now during this case.

| Artifact Connection | How they encountered the artifact and what effect proximity has had on them.

| Starting Knowledge | Information Card IDs (I#) they know at case start.

| Gained Knowledge | Information they learn at specific organization milestones — "At O2M2:

knows Compact handler name."

| Locations | Where they can be found (L# or location name).

| Positive Result | What they share if approached well — Information IDs, introductions, access granted.

| Negative Result | What happens if the encounter goes badly — organization advance on the board, tail placed, witness spooked.

A good test for every NPC: If the agents were not present, what would this NPC do on their own? If the answer is "nothing," the NPC is an information dispenser, not a character. Give them an active agenda or cut them.

=== Information Cards

An Information Card is a playing-card-sized reference identified by an I# code. Each card represents a single discoverable fact — a witness statement, a forensic result, a document, or a rumor.

Information Cards are double-sided. The player-facing front states what the agents learn. The DA-facing back lists sources, cross-links, and consequences.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| Field | What It Contains

| ID | Shorthand identifier — I1, I2, I3, and so on.

| Content | What the agents learn — the fact, clue, or piece of intelligence.

| Found At | Location IDs (L#) where this information can be discovered.

| Known By | NPC IDs who possess this knowledge.

| HQ Fallback | Available from HQ on Day X (see [\[hq-safety-valve\]](#)). If blank, the information is only available in the field.

| Type | Containment Truth (essential for solving the case) or supporting intel (useful but not required).

[NOTE] ==== Containment Truth is the term for information that is mechanically necessary for safe artifact recovery. A Case File typically has three Containment Truths:

* Trigger Condition — what causes the artifact to activate. * Appetite — what the artifact is drawn to or seeks (people, emotions, locations). * Quiescence Condition — what suppresses or neutralizes the artifact long enough for containment.

No safe containment is possible without all three. Containment Truths are always Type: Containment Truth on Information Cards, and every one of them must have at least two field sources plus an HQ fallback. See [Artifacts](#) for the full Containment Profile structure. ====

When the agents discover information during play, the DA physically hands them the player-facing side of the card. This makes progress tangible — the growing stack of Information Cards on the table is a visible measure of how much the team has pieced together.

==== Example: A Simple Investigation Web

The following shows how Locations, NPCs, and Information Cards connect for a small case. The artifact is a cursed pocket watch recovered from an antiques dealer. Three Containment Truths (CT) must be discovered before the team can safely contain it.

```

....           L1: Antiques   Shop (crime scene)  NPC: N1 (owner)   Info: I1, I2
                                     L2: County   L3: Victim's  L4: University  Records
Office  Apartment  Library  NPC: N2 (clerk)  NPC: N3   NPC: N4 (prof)  Info: I3 [CT1]  Info: I4
Info: I5 [CT2]                                     L5: St. Anne's Church  NPC: N5 (parish
priest)  Info: I6 [CT3]                               ....

```

* I1 — The watch was sold by a man matching the description of a known Compact fixer. (Leads to L2.) * I2 — The previous owner died holding the watch; cause of death listed as "acute senescence." (Leads to L3.) * I3 [CT1] — County deed records show the watch was part of a 1923 estate sale from St. Anne's Parish. (Containment Truth: provenance.) * I4 — The victim's journal mentions a recurring dream about a church bell. (Leads to L4 and L5.) * I5 [CT2] — Professor Harlan's research notes describe the watch's activation trigger: it responds to sustained skin contact. (Containment Truth: trigger.) * I6 [CT3] — The parish priest knows the original blessing that sealed the watch in 1923 — a specific Latin invocation. (Containment Truth: quiescence.)

The web ensures that every Location leads to at least one other Location, every Containment Truth has a field source, and no single failure can block the investigation entirely. If the agents miss I3 at the records office, HQ can pull the deed history on Day 6 (HQ Fallback).

=== The HQ Safety Valve

Every Information Card can include an HQ Fallback day: "Available from HQ on Day X." This is the structural mechanism that prevents dead ends. If the agents miss a fact in the field — a failed roll, a skipped Location, a spooked witness — they can request it from Covenant HQ through a standard packet. The cost is time: the request consumes one or more shifts while HQ processes records, contacts assets, or runs analysis.

This means the DA never needs to improvise a rescue path or hand-wave a missed clue. If the information exists and HQ can plausibly obtain it, the agents can always get it. They just lose shifts — and the Operations Board keeps counting down while they wait.

| # | Document | Audience | Purpose

| 1 | Case Brief — DA (mystery statement + DA notes) | DA only | The real story. What is actually happening, who is really involved, and how the case resolves. The DA's anchor document — every question about "what is going on?" starts here.

| 2 | Case Brief — Player (agent briefing / mission brief) | Players | An in-world briefing document from the Covenant containing the case name, region, objectives, known organizations, starting NPC dossiers, initial leads, operational parameters, and regional contacts. Only what the Covenant would share with field agents — no secrets, no Containment Truths, no milestone details.

| 3 | Operations Board | DA (visible to players) | Shift row plus organization countdown rows. The single tracking surface for the case.

| 4 | Organization Reference | DA only | All case organizations listed with their O#M# milestone descriptions and cross-link instructions. The DA scans this when crossing out milestone squares on the board.

| 5 | Relic Sheet | DA only | Full artifact profile: Tier (a measure of the artifact's lethality, containment difficulty, and the Corruption exposure it generates — Tier 1 to Tier 3, defined in [Artifacts](#)), activation condition, mechanical effects, fracture table, containment profile, and Containment Truth checklist.

| 6 | Location Pages (one per Location) | DA only | The documents in front of the DA when the players arrive at a Location. Each page matches the Location form described above.

| 7 | NPC Cards (playing-card size) | DA only | One per NPC. The DA pulls relevant cards and places them next to the active Location page.

| 8 | Information Cards (playing-card size, double-sided) | DA Players | Front (player-facing): what the agents learn. Back (DA reference): source Locations, source NPCs, HQ fallback day, type. Players physically receive cards when information is discovered.

For a single-session case with five or six Locations and six to eight NPCs, the typical package is roughly ten to twelve printed pages plus about twenty cards. That is intentional. A Case File should fit in a manila folder, not fill a three-ring binder.

== Case File Generator Tables

Sometimes you need a case in fifteen minutes. The tables below give DAs a fast oracle system for building a playable case file from a handful of dice rolls. Roll on each table in sequence or pick entries that fit your campaign arc. Either way, you will have a functional case at the end — maybe rough, maybe improvised, but functional.

=== d66 Artifact Type

Roll two d6s: the first die is the tens digit, the second is the units digit.

[%header,cols="1,2,4"]

| d66 | Form | Nature

| 11 | Cassette tape | Recordings of events before they happen; playback causes hemorrhaging | 12 | Pocket watch | Stops time in a 5-meter radius for d6 rounds; user ages accelerated | 13 | Hospital chart | Accurate medical diagnosis of anyone named in it; reading causes symptoms | 14 | Photograph | Shows what the subject fears most; viewing drives Corruption Burst | 15 | Book (journal/diary) | Compels reader to continue until finished; knowledge is real and dangerous | 16 | Vinyl record | Music causes compliance in listeners within earshot; player is compelled too | 21 | Military dog tags | Reveals the moment of death of anyone who held the tags | 22 | Children's toy | Locates any child within a mile; toy speaks in the missing child's voice | 23 | Radio receiver | Picks up transmissions from parallel timelines; maddening incoherence | 24 | Compass | Points toward the nearest supernatural entity regardless of direction | 25 | Mirror (compact or full) | Shows true form of all entities reflected; compels the gaze of anyone who looks into it | 26 | Surgical instrument | Wounds inflicted by it cannot be healed by normal medicine | 31 | Film reel | Footage shows crimes not yet committed; watching causes +1 Corruption | 32 | Blueprint or schematics | Construction following these plans creates a corrupted space; builders don't survive | 33 | Coin (antique) | Payment seals bargains metaphysically; collection agent is always a monster | 34 | Key (iron or bone) | Opens any locked door; what waits behind is never what was expected | 35 | Hand tool (hammer, wrench) | Objects struck retain kinetic energy indefinitely; environment becomes hostile | 36 | Lighter or matchbook | Fire summoned is cold and black; burns only the guilty | 41 | Eyeglasses / goggles | Sees through all deception, illusion, and disguise; wearer cannot close eyes | 42 | Gloves (leather or rubber) | Touch transmits the last emotion felt by any object's previous owner | 43 | Briefcase / attaché | Contents preserved in stasis; time inside does not pass | 44 | Telephone handset | Connected to lines that shouldn't exist; callers are always threatening | 45 | Medication / pill bottle | Suppresses supernatural perception entirely — including warning senses | 46 | Painting or portrait | Subject watches through it;

communicates, manipulates, hungers | 51 | Typewriter | Text typed on it becomes true; reality reconfigures to match | 52 | Map (hand-drawn) | Accurate to a location that doesn't exist — yet | 53 | Clock (grandfather or wall) | Slows time in a building-sized area; those outside the zone age normally while those inside experience minutes as hours | 54 | Syringe / vial of fluid | Injection grants a specific ability; dependency forms within 24 hours | 55 | Musical instrument | Performance compels specific emotional response; player loses control | 56 | Weapon (pistol, knife) | Kills what cannot be killed; user marked for retaliation by its kind | 61 | Wristwatch | Vibrates when the wearer is about to make a fatal mistake | 62 | Handcuffs or restraints | Anyone bound cannot lie; binding marks disappear but effects persist | 63 | Tape recorder | Previous owner's last words loop at danger peaks; cannot be erased | 64 | Newspaper (dated ahead) | Next day's events described accurately; handling causes +1 Corruption per reading | 65 | Wallet or purse | Holds exactly what is needed in any situation; contents are never explained | 66 | Mundane item (DA choice) | Appears entirely ordinary; effect is not discovered until a Fracture

=== d6 Inciting Incident

How does the cell first become aware of the case?

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| d6 | Inciting Incident

| 1 | Missing Person Report — A Covenant contact is digging into a disappearance that connects to a known occult signature. They need field backup before the trail goes cold. | 2 | Anonymous Tip — An unsigned letter arrives at a cell dead drop, containing specific details only an insider could know. Who sent it — and why now? | 3 | Police Report (Redacted) — A Keep archivist intercepts a law-enforcement file referencing phenomena that match an active artifact. The police don't understand what they have. The cell does. | 4 | Field Acquisition Gone Wrong — A previous Recovery team retrieved an artifact but never checked in. Their last known position is on the map. Their radio is silent. | 5 | Covenant Intelligence Briefing — Wayfinder Division has been tracking an occult energy spike for weeks. The spike has stabilized. Something has been activated and is being used. | 6 | Civilian Exposure — A non-Covenant civilian witnessed something they cannot explain. The Covenant's disinformation infrastructure is moving to contain the story — but the artifact is still out there.

=== d6 Location

Where does the case take place?

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| d6 | Location

| 1 | Urban Apartment / Residential Block — Dense housing, suspicious neighbors, minimal cover. The artifact has been in someone's home for years. They think they know what it is. They are wrong. | 2 | Research Laboratory — University or corporate facility. Security protocols, locked sample rooms, and at least one obstructive bureaucrat. Someone on staff is already compromised. | 3 | Rural Property — Isolated farmhouse, hunting cabin, or failed commune. No witnesses. No backup. Distance means a 45-minute response time if things go wrong. | 4 | Government Facility — Federal archive vault, military depot, or municipal records building. Covenant cannot officially exist here. Federal jurisdiction complicates everything. | 5 | Industrial Site — Active factory, rail yard, or chemical plant. Environmental hazards. Shift workers everywhere. The artifact is somewhere in the noise. | 6 | Transient Space — Bus station, motel strip, or truck stop. People flow through constantly. The artifact is being moved, and the window to intercept it is closing.

=== d6 Complication

What makes this case harder than it should be?

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| d6 | Complication

| 1 | Rival Faction Interest — Another organization (intelligence agency, criminal syndicate, or rogue occultist network) has tracked the same artifact. They are already on-site or arriving within the hour. | 2 | Civilian Entanglement — Someone innocent — a family member, a local witness, a bystander — has handled the artifact and is already exhibiting corruption symptoms. Their deterioration is already underway. | 3 | Media Attention — A local journalist is following the same trail for completely mundane reasons. Their story goes to press in 48 hours whether the cell intervenes or not. | 4 | Internal Complication — One of the cell's Covenant contacts has gone quiet. A Wayfinder briefing contains an inconsistency. Something in the chain of command is compromised. | 5 | Containment Failure — A previous version of this artifact was thought neutralized. It wasn't. Two instances of the same occult signature are active simultaneously. | 6 | Escalating Entity — The artifact has attracted or generated a supernatural entity that has been active in the area for days before the cell arrived. It is not the primary target — but it will interfere.

=== d6 Named Threat (Optional)

If the campaign calls for a recurring antagonist, determine their involvement:

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| d6 | Named Threat Angle

| 1 | The Named Threat is three steps ahead — the artifact was already moved before the cell arrived. | 2 | An operative working for the Named Threat is on-site, posing as a civilian, law enforcement, or utility worker. | 3 | The Named Threat wants the artifact contained just as badly as the Covenant does — for entirely different reasons. | 4 | The Named Threat has already activated the artifact once. The Fracture condition has triggered. The threat is managing fallout. | 5 | The Named Threat is watching the cell specifically. They have a file on at least one agent. | 6 | The Named Threat is not involved — but they will learn about this case. Increase the Threat Meter by 1 after resolution.

=== Quick Case Build (15-Minute Prep Guide)

Use this procedure to go from nothing to a playable case in one sitting. The output is a minimal but functional case file package: an Operations Board, a handful of Locations, NPC Cards, Information Cards, and a Relic Sheet sketch.

- . Roll d66 on the Artifact Type table. Name the artifact, give it a mundane appearance, and decide what kind of Containment Truths it will require.
- . Roll d6 on Inciting Incident. This determines how the case reaches the team. Brief the players in two sentences. Do not explain the artifact's full logic yet.
- . Roll d6 on Location. This sets the primary theater of operations. Sketch three to five Locations on separate forms — not a linear route, but a web of places the agents might visit in any order.
- . Roll d6 on Complication. Turn it into an organization row on the Operations Board or a modifier on an existing organization.
- . Write two or three NPC Cards. At least one NPC who gives access and one hostile presence that closes time, routes, witnesses, or secrecy.
- . Set up the Operations Board. Fill in the shift row and add organization rows with per-milestone consequences. Note what relic milestones trigger if the agents lose time or mishandle the artifact.
- . Write three Containment Truths as Information Cards. These should cover trigger, appetite, and quiescence. Mark each as Type: Containment Truth. Make sure each has at least two field sources plus an HQ fallback.
- . Open the case with one accessible Location and one visible sign. Everything else can unlock through play.

==== Worked Example: "The Holbrook Frequency"

> Rolled: d66 = 23 (Radio receiver — parallel timeline transmissions). > Incident: 5 (Covenant Intelligence Briefing — occult energy spike, stabilized). > Location: 2 (Research laboratory — university). > Complication: 3 (Media attention — journalist, 48-hour deadline). > > Case Setup: The physics department at Holbrook University in Aberdeen, Scotland > has been receiving anomalous radio transmissions for three weeks. A Covenant analyst > matched the frequency signature to a Tier 2 artifact: a surplus military radio receiver > modified with components sourced from a 1943 German ESP research program. A local > science reporter is writing a "mystery signal" human-interest piece for the Aberdeen > Herald — deadline Friday. > > Operations Board — Relic Milestones: The transmissions become clearer every night shift and begin > imprinting alternate-life memories on listeners. Relic milestones on the Operations Board track this escalation. If the receiver is activated in the > lab on Friday morning, half the department hears the same impossible broadcast. > > Organization Row: The journalist's article runs Friday morning. If the artifact is not secured > by then, the story triggers federal interest and the Covenant loses access to the university. > > NPC Card: Dr. Frances Okafor, 44, physics faculty. She knows the signal is anomalous. > She wants grant funding, not interference. She will cooperate — for a price.

| Distance | Typical Cost

| Local reposition | Part of an existing shift unless the route is under pressure, watched, or time-locked. | Cross-city movement | 1 shift. | Regional drive | 1-2 shifts depending on weather, roads, and surveillance pressure. | Overnight road movement | 2-3 shifts, usually including fatigue or exposure risk. | Cross-country or international transit | Multiple shifts plus route, customs, paperwork, and contact dependencies.

== Travel Procedure

When a travel shift matters, resolve it in four steps:

. Choose the route. Direct, covert, public, scenic, back road, truck route, air, maritime, or rail. . Identify the pressure. Which organization row or relic milestone on the Operations Board might advance while the team is moving? . Roll only if the route is contested. Unknown roads, weather, active pursuit, border crossings, and covert movement justify rolls. . Resolve arrival as fiction, not as a blank cut. The destination should already feel altered by time, risk, or being followed.

=== Travel Windows

Travel becomes interesting when routes are not interchangeable.

Use route choices to create tradeoffs:

* Fast route — cheaper in shifts, worse for secrecy * Quiet route — slower, but better against surveillance or checkpoints * Institutional route — requires paperwork, tickets, or a Contact, but carries a cover story * Illegal route — fast under the right conditions, catastrophic if exposed

== Stakeouts, Transit, and Long-Haul Movement

Stakeouts usually consume a full shift unless the target is already under observation.

Transit tails and route watches are surveillance shifts that may turn into travel shifts if the team follows someone.

Long-haul movement should usually produce at least one of the following:

* route intelligence * fatigue or wear * a tail problem * missed opportunity elsewhere * a visible sign that an organization advanced on the Operations Board while the team was gone

== Vehicle Types and Travel Speeds

[%header,cols="2,1,2,3"]

| Vehicle | Speed | Capacity (Enc.) | Noise | Notes

| On Foot | Slow | Personal carry only | Silent | Low profile; hard to track in crowds. Extended travel over multiple shifts risks exhaustion — the DA may require an Endure (AGI) roll (Difficulty 2) to avoid arriving Broken. | Bicycle | Slow-Medium | +4 Enc. (rack) | Silent | Urban movement; can cut through alleys, parks, and stairways that vehicles cannot follow. Outrunning a car on open road is impossible, but terrain advantage in dense urban areas is significant. | Compact Car (e.g., Honda Civic) | Medium | 20 Enc. | Low | Inconspicuous. +1 die on Sneak rolls to avoid surveillance. | Full-Size Sedan (e.g., Crown Vic) | Medium | 25 Enc. | Low | The standard Covenant field vehicle. Reliable. Boring. Perfect. | Panel Van | Medium | 50 Enc. | Medium | Can transport personnel and equipment. -1 die on Sneak rolls; noticed in residential areas. | Pickup Truck | Medium | 40 Enc. | Medium | Useful in rural terrain. Bed cargo is visible unless covered (bed cap or tarp). Common enough to blend in. | Motorcycle | Fast | 10 Enc. | Medium | Best for tailing, losing a tail, and city navigation. Terrible in bad weather (-2 dice in rain/snow). | Helicopter (chartered) | Very Fast | 30 Enc. | High | Expensive; requires a Contact. Arrival is conspicuous — rotor noise announces you from a distance. Never use near civilian populations if covert. | Boat (motorized) | Slow-Medium | 60 Enc. | Medium | Coastal and river access. Cannot be followed by road. Not available in every scenario.

Vehicle Damage: Vehicles have a simplified Reliability track. Each time a vehicle roll is pushed, or the vehicle is involved in a collision, it takes 1 Wear. At 3 Wear, the vehicle has a problem (engine issue, flat tire, blown fuse). At 5 Wear, it stops.

A Tech (WIT) roll (Difficulty 2) can clear 1 Wear per scene of work with proper tools. Full repair requires a mechanic, a day, and the right parts. For full vehicle Reliability values and Armor Ratings, see [Equipment](#).

== Resolving a Travel Shift

Only roll when the route is actually contested.

* Car or motorcycle: Investigate (WIT) to read the route, Difficulty 1 in clear conditions, 2 at night or in weather, 3 under pursuit or in unfamiliar territory. * Foot or urban transit: Sneak (AGI) to move without drawing attention, Difficulty 1 normally, 2 in hostile areas. * Charter flight or helicopter: Tech (WIT) to coordinate with the pilot or operate comms, Difficulty 2.

On success: The shift resolves cleanly, or the team gains one useful fact about the destination or route.

On failure: Roll on the Road Event table or apply a prepared travel complication.

On push: +1 Corruption as normal. Travel under occult pressure or fatigue is still pressure.

== Road Event Table

Roll dl2 when a travel shift becomes complicated.

[%header,cols="^1,4"]

| Roll | Event

| 1 | Weather Turn. A fast-developing storm (rain, fog, snowdrift). All vehicle rolls at -1 die until the team stops and waits it out (minimum 30 minutes in-game) or pushes through. If they push, weather worsens. | 2 | Breakdown. Vehicle takes 1 Wear immediately. Tech roll (Difficulty 2) to address roadside or continue at -1 die on all vehicle rolls. | 3 | Police Checkpoint. Roadblock ahead — routine or targeted. The team must choose: reroute (+1 leg to the journey), talk their way through (Manipulate (EMP) Difficulty 2; failure = detained briefly), or bluff past (Sneak (AGI) Difficulty 3). | 4 | Road Accident. A civilian incident is visible ahead — a crash, a stalled car, a figure in the road. Stopping may be medically necessary but adds time and a potential witness. | 5 | Tail Detected. A vehicle has been maintaining pace behind the team for the last leg (see Rules for Being Followed below). | 6 | Corruption Event. The drive passes through a zone of residual occult activity. Every character gains +1 Corruption. No check required — the exposure just happens. The area smells like copper coins and burnt static. | 7 | CB Radio Intercept. The team picks up a fragment of conversation relevant to the Case File — a

police dispatch, a rival faction contact check, a panicked civilian. Roll Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 2 to extract actionable intelligence. | 8 | Trucker's Information. A rest stop encounter with a long-haul trucker who has been on the road through the destination area. Neutral contact. Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 1 reveals one useful local detail (road closures, unusual activity, a landmark). Buy them coffee. | 9 | Wrong Turn. Navigation error. Add +1 leg to the journey. The new route passes through an area with different terrain (DA chooses: industrial, residential, rural, waterfront — add flavor). | 10 | Mechanical Oddity. Something in the vehicle is behaving strangely — electronics flickering, compass spinning, tape player recording on its own. Artifact proximity or corruption leak suspected. Lore (WIT) Difficulty 2 to assess. No immediate danger — but it should be noted. | 11 | Fuel Stop. The team must stop for gas (or food, or rest). A short public window of vulnerability opens. Sneak (AGI) Difficulty 1 to transit without being noted by anyone watching. | 12 | Clean Run. No event this shift. The team arrives ahead of schedule. They may ask the DA one question about the destination that they would have known if they'd had more time to prepare.

== Rules for Being Followed

=== Noticing a Tail

A tail can appear at any point during a travel shift — or it may have started before departure (the team's HQ may already be watched). The DA may introduce a tail narratively or trigger it via Roll #5 on the Road Event table.

To notice a tail: * Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 2 — passive awareness during normal travel. * Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 1 — if the team is specifically looking for surveillance. * The tail makes no roll — the DA decides if they are being careful. A professional tail (MJ-12, experienced Vantablack Compact operative) imposes 1 Difficulty to the detection roll.

=== Losing a Tail

Once a tail is confirmed, the driver can attempt to lose it. This is a *Chase sequence* (abbreviated):

Three options, each requiring one skill roll:

. *Outrun:* Tech (WIT) (vehicle) or Endure (AGI) (on foot). Difficulty 2. Success = tail loses visual. Failure = they stay on you, and the leg's Road Event is escalated by one (worsening conditions, additional exposure). . *Blend In:* Sneak (AGI) or Investigate (WIT) (to find a crowd or crowd-accessible route). Difficulty 2. Success = tail loses the vehicle or person in ambient traffic. Requires stopping or drastically altering route. . *Double Back / Trap:* Investigate (WIT). Difficulty 3. Success = not only is the tail lost, but the team may identify *who* is following them (a glimpse, a plate, a voice on a radio). This is valuable intelligence.

> *Abbreviated vs. full chase:* The three options above are a streamlined resolution for travel-context tails. They resolve a tail as a single meaningful decision without interrupting the case engine flow. For a tactical vehicle chase during a Case File scene, use the full Vehicle Chase Rules in [xref:chapters/10-equipment.adoc#chapter-equipment\[Ch 10 — Equipment\]](#). The primary skill for vehicle chases is always *Tech (WIT)*.

On failure: The tail remains. The team may try again next shift if the route continues. If the tail stays through arrival, the followers learn where the team is going.

=== The Tail Arrives

If the team reaches the destination with a tail still on them:

* The DA places an additional hostile element in the arrival scene or a later crisis location. * The team does not know exactly what they brought with them until it surfaces. * One relevant rival organization advances immediately on the Operations Board.

== Being Followed — Named Threat Complication

If the tail is a Named Threat or a designated faction operative (introduced in the Case File), losing

| Question | What to Decide

| What do they want right now? | Recovery, activation, proof, export, destruction, or denial. | How do they apply pressure before violence? | Bribes, surveillance, hospital influence, forged paperwork, clergy pressure, police contact, buyers, cover stories, or disappearing people. | What signs do the agents notice first? | Wrong numbers, sealed records, tailed vehicles, vanished witnesses, competing inquiries, or sudden access problems. | What does crisis look like? | Seizure attempt, forced transfer, public activation, raid, extraction, or massacre.

If the first thing a faction does is shoot, you skipped the interesting part.

=== Pre-Made Faction Dossiers

Each faction section below serves as a reusable Organization Reference template. When building a case, the DA does not need to reinvent a faction's background — instead, copy the relevant dossier and customize it with case-specific milestones, NPC names, and local operational details.

For the full Organization Reference format and how it fits into the case file package, see [Ch 15 — The Case File Package](#).

=== Mapping a Faction Dossier to an Organization Row

The Ch 15 Operations Board uses Organization Rows with 14 countdown squares and labeled milestone squares. When you bring a faction into a case, translate their dossier into an Organization Row entry like this:

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[%header,cols="1,3"]
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| Organization Row Field | From This Dossier

| Name | Faction name (e.g., "The Vantablack Compact")

| Starting Value | How active they are at case start. Dormant (unchecked) = they don't know about the case yet. Starting value 8 = they've been tracking this artifact for weeks.

| Milestone 1 (early) | First visible sign from the Early signs row.

| Milestone 2 (middle) | An escalated move from the Pressure pattern row.

| Milestone 3 (crisis) | The Crisis move from the dossier.

| Cross-links | What advances other rows when this milestone fires. A Compact snatch attempt might advance the Police row; an Accord public rite advances MJ-12.

For each faction section below, a blank milestone template is included. Fill in the specific consequences, NPC names, and locations for each case.

== The Vantablack Compact

A discreet transnational conspiracy of fixers, collectors, intelligence cutouts, and black-market brokers who treat artifacts as leverage. The Compact prefers acquisition, quiet coercion, and deniable theft over open war.

Their campaign role is covert competition.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| Compact Organization Behavior | Notes

| Early signs | Money appears before personnel. Witnesses change stories, shell companies surface, safehouses are cleaned out, and cutouts stop answering phones. | Pressure pattern | Bribe, buy, divert, and isolate. The Compact wants access routes and proof of custody before it wants a firefight. | Escalation | Disposable intermediaries are replaced by disciplined field professionals. Abductions, route closures, and quiet snatch attempts begin. | Crisis move | Final snatch, export handoff, or disappearance of the carrier and all supporting evidence.

Use the Compact when you want professionals who can mirror Covenant tradecraft without matching Covenant ethics.

.Compact Milestone Template [%header,cols="1,3,3"]

| Milestone | Label | Consequence (Fill In) | O_M1 | Compact Active | First Compact operative arrives. Add a tail on one agent or seal one Location's access. | O_M2 | Compact Pressure | A witness disappears or changes their story. One Information Card moves to "unavailable" unless the agents act this shift. | O_M3 | Compact Crisis | [Fill in: snatch attempt / export handoff / evidence erasure]. Cross-links: _

.Typical Compact Operative [%header,cols="1,1,1,1,1"]

| STR | AGL | WIT | EMP | Skills | 3 | 4 | 4 | 2 | Sneak 3, Shoot 2, Manipulate 2, Investigate 2

Compact operatives have 1 point of Armor (concealed vest) and carry a suppressed pistol (Ammo Die d6). They do not fight unless trapped.

== The Ember Accord

A true-believer occult movement built around revelation, purification, and sacrificial faith. The Accord believes artifacts disclose sacred truths that must be activated, witnessed, and survived.

Their campaign role is fanatical escalation.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| Accord Organization Behavior | Notes

| Early signs | Repeated language, devotional flyers, symbols appearing in mundane spaces, worried families, and witnesses speaking of ordeal as revelation. | Pressure pattern | Gather believers, create witnesses, provoke activation, reinterpret suffering as proof. | Escalation | Cells stop hiding and start arranging audiences, vigils, or rites that make secrecy impossible. | Crisis move | Public activation event or sacrificial rite designed to spread the artifact's logic.

Use the Ember Accord when the problem is not only possession of the artifact but an ideology that demands activation regardless of cost.

.Accord Milestone Template [%header,cols="1,3,3"]

| Milestone | Label | Consequence (Fill In) | O_M1 | Accord Gathering | A devotional cell is forming around the artifact. Witnesses are becoming believers instead of sources. | O_M2 | Accord Rite | The Accord attempts a group activation rite. Relic milestone on the shift row may trigger early if the rite succeeds. | O_M3 | Accord Crisis | [Fill in: public activation event / sacrificial rite]. Cross-links: _

.Typical Accord Zealot [%header,cols="1,1,1,1,1"]

| STR | AGL | WIT | EMP | Skills | 3 | 2 | 2 | 4 | Manipulate 3, Lore 2, Fight 2

Accord zealots have no armor and rarely carry firearms. They fight desperately when cornered and are immune to Intimidate. A devoted leader (the Herald) has EMP 5, Lore 3, and causes a Corruption Burst (Rating 2) on a first encounter.

== Majestic-12 (MJ-12)

A heavily militarized branch of the American Department of Defense responsible for handling anomalous threats. MJ-12 seeks to reverse-engineer artifacts into Cold War weaponry and treats human cost as a logistics problem.

Their campaign role is state power and containment-through-force.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| MJ-12 Organization Behavior | Notes

| Early signs | Federal credentials where they should not be, restricted files pulled overnight, surveillance vans, sealed streets, and officials suddenly unavailable. | Pressure pattern | Observe, classify, isolate, and then remove. MJ-12 turns open civic space into controlled terrain. | Escalation | Black-bag detention, evidence seizure, roadblocks, and classified transport. | Crisis move | Overwhelming tactical response or forced site lockdown with the artifact still active inside.

Use MJ-12 when the threat is surveillance, black-bag extraction, official deniability, and overwhelming tactical response.

.MJ-12 Milestone Template [%header,cols="1,3,3"]

| Milestone | Label | Consequence (Fill In) | O_M1 | MJ-12 Surveillance | Agents are under surveillance. One Location becomes "monitored" — any scene there risks being observed and reported. | O_M2 | MJ-12 Lockdown | MJ-12 moves to isolate the artifact site. Access to one Location is suspended until agents can bypass official control. | O_M3 | MJ-12 Extraction | [Fill in: tactical seizure / transport lockdown / detention]. Cross-links: _

.Typical MJ-12 Field Agent [%header,cols="1,1,1,1,1"]

| STR | AGL | WIT | EMP | Skills | 4 | 3 | 3 | 2 | Shoot 3, Fight 2, Investigate 2, Tech 1

MJ-12 field agents wear concealed ballistic vests (Armor 2) and operate in pairs. They have authority to detain, restrict access, and commandeer resources. They are not equipped for supernatural phenomena and gain Corruption normally from artifact exposure.

* *How much does the government actually know?

The US government's awareness of occult artifacts is fragmented and deliberately compartmentalized. MJ-12 is not a unified policy — it is a black-budget program buried inside the Department of Defense, known to fewer than two dozen officials. Most of the federal government has no idea artifacts exist.

MJ-12 knows artifacts are real and dangerous. They do not understand why artifacts exist, what the entities are, or what containment actually requires. Their approach is military: secure the site, extract the object, study it in a controlled facility, and weaponize anything useful. This approach has produced catastrophic failures — classified incidents at research sites that MJ-12 attributes to operator error rather than acknowledging the artifacts' inherent nature.

The Covenant remains independent for three reasons: (1) it predates MJ-12 by centuries and has institutional knowledge that no government program can replicate; (2) the Covenant operates globally across jurisdictions that no single nation controls; and (3) every time a government has attempted to monopolize artifact containment, the results have been worse — the Covenant's archives contain multiple case studies of state-run containment programs that collapsed, leaked, or were corrupted by the artifacts themselves.

MJ-12 and the Covenant are aware of each other. The relationship is hostile but restrained — MJ-12 considers the Covenant an unauthorized non-state actor operating on US soil, and the Covenant considers MJ-12 dangerously incompetent. Neither can afford open conflict. The Cold War provides cover for both: MJ-12 hides its operations behind national security classification, and the Covenant hides behind the assumption that secret societies are conspiracy theories. *

== The Hellfire Consortium

An elite, global network of corporate executives, politicians, and billionaires who utilize blood magic and ancient rituals for financial gain and political manipulation. They treat the occult as a tool for extreme capitalism.

Their campaign role is *elite corruption and patronage.

[%header,cols="1,4"]

| Consortium Organization Behavior | Notes

| Early signs | Lawyers, private security, shell purchases, hospitality staff under orders, luxury transport, and polite denials backed by money. | Pressure pattern | Buy the venue, buy the witness, buy the clinic, buy the route, buy the cleanup. | Escalation | Private estates become operational sites, staff become accomplices, and ritual specialists arrive under business cover. | Crisis move | Controlled activation for profit, leverage, or bargaining power in a sealed private environment.

Use the Consortium when the artifact is moving through luxury channels, shell companies, private estates, or buyers who think occult catastrophe is an acceptable line item.

.Consortium Milestone Template [%header,cols="1,3,3"]

| Milestone | Label | Consequence (Fill In) | O_M1 | Consortium Interest | Legal and financial obstruction begins. One NPC becomes uncooperative; one Location requires a new access route. | O_M2 | Consortium Acquisition | The artifact is moved to a private, controlled environment. Field access requires a new Contact or a Covenant packet. | O_M3 | Consortium Crisis | [Fill in: controlled activation / private rite / export under diplomatic cover]. Cross-links: _

.Typical Consortium Operative (Private Security) [%header,cols="1,1,1,1,1"]

| STR | AGL | WIT | EMP | Skills | 4 | 3 | 2 | 2 | Shoot 3, Fight 3, Manipulate 1

Consortium security wear visible body armor (Armor 3) and operate in teams of four. They enforce exclusion zones without engaging in conversation. Consortium principals (the wealthy clients) are rarely present at operational sites but can accelerate any Organization Row milestone by two squares with a phone call.

== Player-Facing Signs of Rival Pressure

Before a faction organization worsens, show at least one sign:

* a witness suddenly has counsel * a hospital says the file is gone * the wrong priest arrives first * a dockmaster becomes unhelpful for no obvious reason * a car appears twice in one day * the team's cover story stops being enough

The faction organization should feel like a tightening web, not a surprise teleport.

:leveloffset: 1

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[#chapter-notable-members] = Notable Historical Covenant Members

The Covenant's archives contain centuries of operational records, personnel files, and after-action reports. These records are not public — they are locked in the Keep's Restricted Stack and accessed only by agents with appropriate standing or on specific Wayfinder authorization.

What follows is a curated excerpt from those archives: notable members from across the Covenant's history, organized by era. These are not myths. Each entry represents a documented agent who operated under the same mandate agents hold today — discover, recover, and contain. The artifacts they handled were real. So were the costs.

Historical records as gameplay: The DA may surface these entries during play when agents visit the Keep's archive, consult a Wayfinder analyst, or request historical precedent on a specific artifact type. Each entry can serve as a seed for a mission briefing, a clue about a current artifact's lineage, or an NPC hook (a descendant, a rival organization's historical target, a still-active custodian network).

On terminology: The Covenant's internal documentation predates current field terminology. Entries may reference "cascades" (now called Corruption), "ethereal mapping" (Lore-based investigations), "warding compositions" (early Containment Rituals), and "resonance fields" (artifact emission signatures). These terms are historical artifacts of the archive's era, not current mechanical terms. See [Ch 8 — Corruption](#) and [Ch 11 — Artifacts](#) for current terminology.

== The Medieval & Renaissance Eras

[%header,cols="3,1,1,5"]

| Member | Dates | Division | Legacy

| Godfrey of Bouillon | c. 1060–1100 | Recovery | Used the chaos of the First Crusade to seize and sequester dangerous Levantine relics. | Hildegard of Bingen | 1098–1179 | Keep | A visionary nun who created early containment wards disguised as complex musical compositions. | Albertus Magnus | c. 1200–1280 | Wayfinder | Dominican friar who mapped the alchemical resonance of European artifacts. | Roger Bacon | c. 1219–1292 | Keep | Designed the first lead-lined alchemical containment chambers, hidden within academic manuscripts. | Marco Polo | 1254–1324 | Recovery | Used his famous travels as a smokescreen to extract dangerous Silk Road artifacts. | Nicolas Flamel | 1330–1418 | Keep | Guarded a highly unstable, reality-warping artifact masked as the "philosopher's stone." | Marsilio Ficino | 1433–1499 | Wayfinder | Translated the Corpus Hermeticum to decipher ancient artifact triggers for field agents. | Julie d'Aubigny | 1673–1707 | Recovery | 17th-century swordfighter, opera singer, and adventurer whose public duels and theatrical career provided cover for artifact retrievals across France and the Low Countries. Her combat skill and talent for disguise made her one of the earliest Recovery agents to operate openly in hostile territory. | Heinrich Cornelius Agrippa | 1486–1535 | Keep | Authored the Three Books of Occult Philosophy as a coded manual for Covenant catalogers. | Paracelsus | 1493–1541 | Wayfinder | Pioneered treatments for the physical symptoms of early-stage Corruption — the toll that direct artifact handling exacts on unshielded agents. | John Dee | 1527–1608 | Wayfinder | Used Enochian magic and Elizabeth I's court to intercept Spanish occult weaponry.

== The Enlightenment & Victorian Eras

[%header,cols="3,1,1,5"]

| Member | Dates | Division | Legacy

| Athanasius Kircher | 1602–1680 | Keep | Categorized cursed Egyptian artifacts and built the first deep-subterranean vaults beneath Rome. | Emanuel Swedenborg | 1688–1772 | Wayfinder | Mapped patterns of artifact-induced altered perception, developing techniques to navigate occult sensory disruption. | William Blake | 1757–1827 | Wayfinder | Poet, painter, and visionary mystic whose claimed visions of angels and demons were documented encounters with bound entities. His illuminated manuscripts encoded artifact locations and entity behavioral patterns in allegorical imagery that Wayfinder analysts still reference. | Count of St. Germain | 1712–1784 | Recovery | Used his alleged "immortality" as cover for a generational lineage of Recovery agents. | Giovanni Battista Belzoni | 1778–1823 | Recovery | Posed as an archaeologist to extract cursed Egyptian antiquities from collapsing tombs. | Sir Richard Francis Burton | 1821–1890 | Recovery | Master of disguise and linguistics who infiltrated forbidden cities to retrieve stolen relics. | Heinrich Schliemann | 1822–1890 | Recovery | Used the excavation of Troy as a front to extract weaponized mythological artifacts. | Helena Petrovna Blavatsky | 1831–1891 | Wayfinder | Normalized the esoteric through the Theosophical Society to enable covert investigations. | William Wynn Westcott | 1848–1925 | Keep | Co-founded the Golden Dawn, using lodges as safehouses for psychological ward development. | Arthur Edward Waite | 1857–1942 | Wayfinder | Encoded artifact locations and entity weaknesses into the Rider-Waite Tarot deck. | William Butler Yeats | 1865–1939 | Wayfinder | Used poetic resonance and automatic writing to locate dormant Celtic artifacts.

== The 20th Century (Pre-1980s)

[%header,cols="3,1,1,5"]

| Member | Dates | Division | Legacy

| Howard Carter | 1874-1939 | Recovery | Handled the catastrophic curse outbreak during the Tutankhamun extraction. | Nicholas Roerich | 1874-1947 | Recovery | Ran Himalayan expeditions to secure the Chintamani Stone before Axis occultists. | Evelyn Underhill | 1875-1941 | Keep | Developed contemplative techniques that actively counteract artifact-induced psychic destabilization, still used in Psychoanalyze treatment protocols. | Jack Parsons | 1914-1952 | Wayfinder | Blended Thelema with aerospace technology to attempt the destruction of volatile off-world artifacts. His death remains classified in the Restricted Stack.

| Tier | Label | Description | Typical Strength

| 1 | Grunt | No special abilities; acts in mobs; simplified stat block | 2-3 | 2 | Operative | One special ability; acts individually; mild tactics | 3-5 | 3 | Elite | Two or more special abilities; acts strategically; has a plan | 5-7 | 4 | Named Threat | Full stat block; unique abilities; plot significance | 6-10

> Named Threats are specific individuals (a faction leader, a bound entity with a centuries-long history) and should be developed individually rather than drawn from this reference list. The stat blocks above represent archetypes, not named antagonists. --- === Vantablack Compact Field Professional [Human / The Vantablack Compact / Threat: High] ---- Attributes: STR 3	AGI 5	WIT 4	EMP 3 Armor Rating: 1 (concealed ballistic vest) Burst Rating: 0 Skills: Brawl 2	Endure 2 Sneak 4	Deft Hands 3 Firearms 3 Investigate 3	Tech 2 Manipulate 3 Special Abilities: Counter-Surveillance — The Field Professional immediately detects standard Covenant surveillance setups (stakeouts, tails, static observation posts). If the agents attempt an Investigate roll to surveil a Compact operative, it is opposed by the Professional's Investigate 3 (ties go to the Professional — they've done this longer than most agents have been alive). Sterile Exit — When a Compact professional is Broken or their mission is compromised, they
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| Attribute | Value

| Tier | Named Threat (Zone-Based) | Strength | — (cannot be targeted by physical attacks) | Agility | — (does not move; fills a space) | Wits | 4 | Empathy | 5 (uses Empathy to manipulate; passively broadcasts) | Skills | Psychoanalyze 3 (passive pressure), Manipulate 2 (hallucination-induced) | Armor Rating | Immune to physical damage | Burst Rating | 3 | Corruption Cost | +1 Corruption per minute spent within it (scene = +3 total)

Origin: A Mire forms when intense psychological trauma fuses with corrupting artifact energy over years — a long-term infestation of a place by accumulated suffering. Hospitals, prisons, and sites of mass corruption exposure are most at risk.

Special Abilities: — **Zone Control** — The Mire occupies a defined zone (one to three interconnected rooms). All Wits and Empathy rolls made inside the zone are at -2 dice. Firearms and Force rolls are unaffected; the Mire does not respond to violence.

Memory Bleed — At the start of each scene inside the zone, each character witnesses an involuntary memory of the zone's traumatic origin (DA description). Characters must pass an Endure roll (Difficulty 1) or take 1 Wits damage.

Dissolution Trigger — The Mire cannot be destroyed by conventional means. It can be dispersed by: (1) Removing the corrupting artifact at its core (Investigate Difficulty 3 to locate it inside the zone, Lore Difficulty 2 to identify it as the anchor). (2) A Containment Ritual (see [Containment Rituals](#)) performed by an agent with Lore 3+, taking one full scene. (3) Destroying the artifact at its core (Artifact Fracture; triggers a Corruption spike — everyone in the zone takes +3 Corruption). — **Broken State:** Dispersed. The zone returns to normal. Physical damage from the trauma-origin remains (stains, broken furniture, cold spots). The artifact anchor must be contained; leaving it creates a new Mire within 1d6 days.

Motivation: The Mire has no motivation. It is an environmental hazard with rudimentary self-preservation logic. It does not pursue; it holds.

=== The Hollow

[%header,cols="1,3"]

| Attribute | Value

| Tier | Operative (2) | Strength | 5 | Agility | 2 (sluggish, deliberate) | Wits | 1 (no autonomous thought) | Empathy | 0 | Skills | Force 3, Brawl 2, Endure 3 | Armor Rating | 1 (physical deadness reduces impact) | Burst Rating | 2 | Corruption Cost | +1 Corruption on first sighting; +1 if recognized as someone known

Origin: A Hollow is a human corpse reanimated by a corrupting artifact using residual psychic impressions of the deceased. The body retains muscle memory and some learned behaviors — but there is nothing behind the eyes.

Special Abilities:

---- **Artifact Tether** — A Hollow is bound to a specific artifact that controls it. While within Short range of that artifact, it gains +2 dice on all rolls. If the artifact is moved more than 50 meters away, the Hollow loses all special abilities and functions as a Grunt.

Recognition Response — If a player character knew the deceased in life and makes eye contact with the Hollow, they must pass a Psychoanalyze or Endure roll (Difficulty 2) or take 1 Empathy damage immediately.

Dead to Pain — The Hollow does not bleed (no ongoing Strength loss from wounds), cannot be staggered, and ignores fatigue. It will pursue until Broken or the artifact is removed. ----

Broken State: Collapse. The body goes completely inert. The artifact that controlled it is not damaged by the Hollow's collapse, but its occult signature is now readable (Lore Difficulty 1 to identify its history).

Motivation: The Hollow protects the artifact, returned the artifact to its last owner, or simply pursues the last living person it was "tasked" to reach. The DA determines the simple directive at the moment of the Hollow's creation.

=== The Listening

[%header,cols="1,3"]

| Attribute | Value

| Tier | Elite (3) | Strength | 3 (only manifests briefly) | Agility | 5 (intangible movement) | Wits | 6
| Empathy | 5 | Skills | Investigate 4, Sneak 5, Manipulate 3 | Armor Rating | Immune to physical
damage while intangible | Burst Rating | 2 (initially); 4 (once its nature is understood) |
Corruption Cost | +2 Corruption when it speaks directly to a character

Origin: Formed from decades of surveillance anxiety — in a city wired by cold-war paranoia, government wiretapping, and Covenant counter-intelligence operations bleeding occult energy, The Listening coheres as an entity that only knows how to observe and manipulate. It does not attack physically; it attacks information.

Special Abilities: — **Absolute Silence** — The Listening's presence is announced by the sudden total cessation of ambient noise. Phones stop mid-ring. Tape recorders erase. Radio static vanishes. Characters with Investigate 2+ notice it immediately; others need a Wits roll (Difficulty 1).

They Know — Once per scene, The Listening can whisper a secret about one character to another character within Near range. The secret is true. The character who hears it must pass a Manipulate (resisted by Command or Endure, Difficulty 2) or immediately distrust the revealed character for the scene.

Wire Tap — If a character makes a Tech roll within The Listening's zone, The Listening gains access to all information contained in the device used. It may use this information in the same or future scenes (DA's discretion).

Intangible — The Listening cannot be harmed by physical attacks. It can only be targeted by a Containment Ritual (see [Containment Rituals](#)) or destroyed by removing all corrupted surveillance equipment from its zone of origin and performing a Tech roll (Difficulty 3) to disrupt its signal network. — **Broken State: Static.** A burst of white noise — every electronic device in Near range emits a single piercing tone and loses 1 Gear Bonus permanently. The Listening disperses. It may reconstitute in 1d6 days if its occult origin point is not addressed.

Motivation: To know everything. To use what it knows. It does not kill — but it will unravel a team from inside if left unchecked.

=== Fracture Wraith

[%header,cols="1,3"]

| Attribute | Value

| Tier | Named Threat (4) | Strength | 6 | Agility | 4 | Wits | 3 (fragmented; once higher) | Empathy | 6 (weaponized grief) | Skills | Psychoanalyze 4, Manipulate 4, Brawl 3 (manifested physical form) | Armor Rating | 3 (partially intangible) | Burst Rating | 4 (maximum if the Wraith wears the face of a dead teammate) | Corruption Cost | +2 Corruption on first contact; +1 each subsequent scene

Origin: When a Covenant agent dies during a corruption spike — the Corruption threshold exceeded at the moment of death by artifact activation or ent	AGI 3	WIT 4	EMP 2 Arm or Rating: 0 Burst Rating: 2 Skills: Manipulate 3	Lore 2	Brawl 2	Endure 3 Movement: 1 zone / Fast Action (standard) Special Abilities: Resonance Broadcast (Passive) — All characters within the same zone as the Vessel gain	AGI — (incorporeal)	WIT 5	EMP 4 Arm or Rating: Immune to physical damage Burst Rating: 3 Skills: None (the Echo does not act with intention) Movement: Zone-locked (occupies	AGI 3	WIT 4	EMP 2 Arm or Rating: 1 (artificially -warded clothing — subtle, not tactical) Burst Rating: 0 (human, but deeply unsettling) — see DA Guidance) Skills: Lore 4	Manipulate 3	Investigate 3	Defeat Hands 3	Sneak 2	Tech 2 Movement: 1 zone / Fast Action (standard) Special Abilities: Artifact Arsenal — The Collector carries 2-3 Tier 1 artifacts and uses the tactic
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| Stage | Corruption | Behavior

| 0 | 0-3 | Normal. No mechanical difference from a baseline NPC. | 1 | 4-7 | Distorted. The NPC is erratic — inconsistent, prone to misreading motives. -1 die on all social skill rolls targeting them. They believe they are functioning normally. | 2 | 8-10 | Compromised. The NPC's primary goal has been replaced by the logic of a corrupting artifact. They act with genuine conviction in service of something the artifact wants. Burst Rating 1 (their behavior is uncanny and wrong). | 3 | 11+ | Broken. The NPC meets the Fracture Wraith threshold or reaches catatonia. If not Catatonic, treat as equivalent to a Hollow (see above) — still moving, but no longer present.

=== Running a Corrupted NPC

Corrupted NPCs are not villains in the traditional sense. They are victims. Consider the following when playing them:

* A Stage 1 NPC may give the players subtly wrong information — not because they are lying, but because they have stopped being able to distinguish memory from artifact-induced suggestion. * A Stage 2 NPC may have physically altered their behavior to serve the artifact (hoarding it, protecting a building it lives in, feeding it corruption by exposing others to it). * A Stage 2 NPC who is confronted about their behavior becomes aggressively defensive — they are convinced they are fine. A Psychoanalyze roll (Difficulty 3) reveals the fracture. * A Stage 2 NPC who is successfully separated from the artifact for 48 hours begins to recover. A Psychoanalyze roll (Difficulty 2) can accelerate recovery. Recovery is not complete — they retain the trauma and may have acted against people they care about.

=== Identifying Corruption

Detecting a Corrupted NPC in play:

* Investigate (WIT) Difficulty 2: Notice that the NPC's behavior is inconsistent with their established pattern. * Lore (WIT) Difficulty 3: Identify the specific artifact exerting influence based on the NPC's behavioral distortions. * Psychoanalyze (EMP) Difficulty 2: Confirm the NPC is compromised; learn how long it has been going on.

> Design note: Corrupted NPCs are the game's most human horror. The artifacts don't just corrupt agents — they reach out through anyone who gets close to them. The party's best informant may already be Stage 1. The Covenant archivist they trusted for six Case Files may have been Stage 2 for months.

== DA Monster Creation Guidelines

Use these guidelines when building new entities for a scenario.

=== Step 1 — Establish Tier

Choose the entity's Tier from the NPC Tier Reference table. Named Threats require a narrative hook (a history, a motivation, a way they can be permanently stopped) and should appear no more than once or twice per campaign.

=== Step 2 — Assign Attributes

Use the following baselines as starting points:

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Tier	STR	AGI	WIT	EMP
Grunt	2-3	2-3	1-2	1-2
Operative	3-5	3-4	2-3	2-3
Elite	5-7	3-5	3-4	3-5
Named Threat	6-10	4-6	4-6	4-7

Supernatural entities may exceed these ranges in one or two Attributes to reflect their inhuman nature — but balance this against their vulnerabilities.

=== Step 3 — Choose a Primary Skill (and Two Secondary Skills)

The primary skill is what the entity does in combat or interaction. The secondary skills represent what it falls back on. Named Threats get three secondary skills.

=== Step 4 — Define Special Abilities

Limit special abilities by tier:

* Grunt: 0-1 special abilities * Operative: 1 special ability * Elite: 2-3 special abilities * Named Threat: 3-5 special abilities

Good special ability design rules:

. Each ability should create a distinct tactical decision for the players. . At least one ability should have a meaningful counter that can be discovered with a successful Lore or Investigate roll. . Avoid purely defensive abilities — entities that can only be hurt in specific ways are frustrating if players can't find the method.

=== Step 5 — Set Burst Rating

[%header,cols="^1,3"]

| Rating | When to Use

| 1 | Unsettling — wrong but not immediately dangerous (a Hollow in daylight) | 2 | Disturbing — genuinely threatening, supernatural in an obvious way | 3 | Horrifying — the sight alone causes psychological harm | 4 | Shattering — maximum; reserved for entities of existential scale

=== Step 6 — Write the Broken State

Every entity needs an end condition. Answer: What does it look like when this thing stops? What does it leave behind? Is it permanent?

=== Step 7 — Write the Motivation

Even mindless entities have a directive. Define it in one sentence. If you can't, the entity isn't ready yet.

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[#chapter-sample-case-file] = Sample Case File: The Spear That Went Dark

This chapter presents a complete, ready-to-run Neon Relic case file. *The Spear That Went Dark* is the introductory sample that ships with the game. It demonstrates every system working together: the Operations Board, the eight-document case package, Containment Truths, Organizations, NPC Cards, Location Pages, and Information Cards. Run it as written for your first session, or read through it to understand how the pieces fit before building your own.

The full document package — all filled-in forms — lives in the starter kit under `sample-case-file/`. This chapter provides the narrative architecture the DA needs to run the case, plus the handout images and NPC portraits for use at the table.

[#sample-case-situation] == The Situation

The *Spear of Destiny* — or a relic credibly identified as that spearhead and its restored shaft assembly — was held in a private vault beneath the Ferreyra estate under a postwar custody arrangement with the Catholic Church. The vault was not merely a safe. It was a ritual containment site, maintained through a *liturgical suppression sequence* (a Containment Ritual specific to Church-lineage artifacts: a series of consecrated prayers, physical gestures, and material applications performed on a fixed schedule by authorized custodians; the Quiescence Condition for the Spear depends on continuous maintenance of this sequence) that had to be performed on a precise schedule. Three nights ago, a professional theft crew breached the vault, broke the containment lineage, and failed to complete the buyer handoff that was supposed to follow.

Since then, the Spear has gone still somewhere in the city. The heist crew has fractured — one member is suffering from *wound bloom* (a Tier 2 relic symptom: the Spear activates cruciform wound patterns on anyone who handled it under duress, reopening old injuries and opening new ones in dreamlike cycles) at an off-grid clinic, another has vanished, and the surviving leader is trying to fence the object through a currency exchange with connections to foreign buyers. The Vantablack Compact, which funded the theft through cutouts, has deployed a regional fixer named Iván Luján to recover the asset. Luján is becoming the strongest bearer candidate (the Spear's selection mechanism: it reads authority patterns in nearby humans and begins imprinting sovereignty logic on whoever most resembles a commander — this is not possession — the host retains free will and personality, but the Spear rewrites their self-image until they genuinely believe they were born to command). The Spear does not make soldiers; it makes prophets who believe their own myth. Meanwhile, the Buenos Aires police are building a robbery

| Document | File

| Case Brief — DA | [case-brief-da.html](#) | Case Brief — Player (Agent Briefing) | [case-brief-player.html](#) | Relic Sheet | [relic-sheet.html](#) | Operations Board | [operations-board.html](#) | Organization Reference | [organization-reference.html](#) | Location Pages (L1-L7) | [locations.html](#) | NPC Cards (8 NPCs) | [npc-cards.html](#) | Information Cards (I1-I22) | [information-cards.html](#)

The **handouts/** subdirectory contains all the visual assets — clue handout images, NPC portraits, location images, and the relic illustration.

[#sample-case-summary] == DA Quick Summary

What happened? The Compact funded the theft. The crew breached the estate. The Spear destabilized the transfer. The handoff failed. The relic is now hidden, active, and pulling multiple factions toward one contaminated custody crisis.

What do the agents need? Where the crew broke apart, who now has proximity control, what the old containment procedure was, and how to move the relic without completing its escalation.

The object is simultaneously sacred relic, imperial mandate, and weaponizable asset. Each faction understands only one slice of that truth, and the agents must assemble all three before the city becomes the ritual site (a sovereignty event — the Spear's catastrophe milestone: if the bearer reaches full imprinting and the Spear is activated in public, it produces a compulsion field compelling mass obedience to the bearer's spoken commands for several hours, with Corruption exposure for everyone in range).

== Handout Images

Each of the following pages contains a full-page handout image. Print or display these during play as physical clue documents for the players.

<<<

image::png/spear-handout-1-covenant-archive-summary.png[Handout 1 — Covenant Archive Summary,align=center,pdfwidth=90%]

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image::png/spear-handout-2-church-custody-memo.png[Handout 2 — Church Custody Memorandum,align=center,pdfwidth=90%,pdfheight=80%]

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image::png/spear-handout-3-academic-museum-abstract.png[Handout 3 — Academic / Museum Abstract,align=center,pdfwidth=90%,pdfheight=80%]

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image::png/spear-handout-4-black-market-intelligence-brief.png[Handout 4 — Black-Market Intelligence Brief,align=center,pdfwidth=90%,pdfheight=80%]

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| Age Group | Character creation choice determining starting Attribute and Skill point pools. Three tiers: Young (14 attribute / 10 skill), Experienced (13 / 12), Senior (12 / 14). See [Character Creation](#). | Anchor | A physical object linked to a humanizing memory. Once per session, a character may interact with their Anchor to heal 1d4 Corruption. See [Anchors](#). | Armor Rating | The number of Gear dice rolled to absorb incoming damage. Each 6 rolled cancels one point of damage. See [Health, Damage & Armor](#). | Attribute Dice | White dice in the pool, equal to the relevant Attribute score (Strength, Agility, Wits, or Empathy). See [Core Resolution](#).

== B

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Background | Recovery Division's equivalent of Departments. Defines the agent's pre-Covenant expertise and grants narrative hooks. See [Divisions](#). | Broken | State when any Attribute reaches 0. The character is incapacitated and rolls on the appropriate Critical Injury table (Physical or Mental). See [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

== C

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Case File | A structured operation tracked on an Operations Board with a shift row (time tracker + relic milestones) and organization countdown rows. Case Files are built from Locations, NPC Cards, Information Cards, organizations, Containment Truths, and Covenant Request Packets. Playable in flexible order rather than through a linear script. See [Case Files](#). | Clearance Level (CL) | Seniority and authorization rank within the Covenant. Equals Division base CL plus Age Group modifier (Young -1, Experienced +0, Senior +1), minimum 1. Determines gear access and organizational authority. See [Character Creation](#). | Contact | See NPC Card. In the entity model, contacts are NPC Cards with access-granting roles, organization affiliations, and knowledge. They are not a separate case-board element. See [Case Files](#). | Containment Truth | Information necessary for safe resolution of a case, such as a relic's trigger, appetite, tether, shielding method, quiescence condition, or transfer sequence. See [Case Files](#). | Corruption | Cumulative psychological and occult damage track. Gained from pushing rolls, Division Talent activation, Fear, artifact use, and supernatural exposure. Maximum Corruption Threshold = 10 + Empathy score; exceeding it causes permanent catatonia and character retirement. See [Corruption, Fear & Healing](#). | Covenant Request Packet | A field request sent to the Covenant for delayed support such as archive pulls, identity checks, freight screening, or comparative case data. Only one packet may be sent per shift, and responses take at least 2 shifts. See [Case Files](#). | Critical Injury | A specific wound or trauma rolled on a D66 table when a character becomes Broken. Physical criticals use the Physical table (STR/AGI = 0); mental criticals use the Mental & Emotional table (WIT/EMP = 0). Some entries are marked † (Death Check). See [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

== D

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| D66 | A roll of two six-sided dice read as a two-digit number (first die = tens, second = units). Used for Critical Injury tables. Range: 11-66. | Damage Type | One of three categories: Physical (targets STR or AGI), Mental (targets WIT or EMP), or Corruption (added directly to the Corruption track). See [Health, Damage & Armor](#). | Dark Secret | A specific hidden fact from the character's past — an event, decision, or relationship someone wants buried. Serves as a roleplay device and XP hook ("Did your Dark Secret complicate the mission?" = +1 XP). See [Advancement](#). | Death Check | A single d6 roll required when a Critical Injury is marked †. On 1-2: the character dies (or is permanently retired for mental death). On 3-6: survival, but the Critical Injury still applies. See [Health, Damage & Armor](#). | Department | Specialization within a Division. Wayfinder agents choose Wings, Keep agents choose Departments, and Recovery agents choose Operational Paradigms instead. Stack is a Keep department, not a separate Division. See [Divisions](#). | Difficulty | The number of successes (6s) required to pass a standard skill roll. Default Difficulty is 1 if a rule does not state otherwise. Opposed rolls compare totals instead of using a fixed Difficulty, and a few special rolls such as Fear checks use their own binary rules. See [Core Resolution](#). | Director of Agents (DA) | The table's facilitator role. The DA presents scenes, adjudicates uncertainty, tracks the Operations Board (organization rows and shift row), and portrays the world and opposition. See [Director of Agents Guidance](#). | Disposition | An NPC's current openness to engagement in Social Conflict, tracked from 1 (Closed) to 5 (Open). At Disposition 3 or higher, direct low-risk questions are answered without a roll; social rolls are reserved for sensitive disclosures or requests against self-interest. See [Social Conflict](#). | Division | Character class within the Verdant Covenant. The three playable Divisions are Wayfinder (research/intelligence), Recovery (field retrieval), and The Keep (vault security, custody, and logistics). See [Divisions](#). | Division Item | A signature supernatural object issued to every member of a Division. Wayfinder: Verdant Codex. Recovery: Verdant Satchel. Keep: Warden's Bracer. See [Divisions](#). | Division Talent | A class-specific ability unique to one Division. Costs +1 Corruption to activate (most talents). See [Divisions](#). | Dying | State when a Broken character has an active Death Check Critical Injury (result marked †) that has not yet been resolved. An untreated Dying character will die. See [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

== E

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Experience Points (XP) | The game's only advancement currency. XP are awarded at the end of each Case File through debrief questions and spent to raise skills, buy new talents, or increase Clearance Level. See [Advancement, Talents, and Dark Secrets](#).

== F

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Fast Action | One of three action types in combat. Represents a quick or secondary effort: moving one zone, drawing a weapon, taking cover, or using a small item. See [Combat](#). | Fear Check | A special binary Wits roll triggered by supernatural horror. One or more 6s = success. Any 1s = +1 Corruption. No 6s = failure (+1 Corruption + Panic Table roll). See [Corruption, Fear & Healing](#). | Fear Rating | Narrative classification (0–5) of how terrifying a creature or event is. Used by the DA to determine when to call for a Fear check. 0 = no check triggered. See [Corruption, Fear & Healing](#). | Free Action | An action in combat that requires negligible effort: speaking a short sentence, dropping an item, or glancing at surroundings. Unlimited per turn. See [Combat](#). | Operations Board | The single tracking surface for a Case File. Contains a shift row (time tracker + relic milestones) and organization countdown rows. 14 columns count down from 14 1 (days until catastrophe). See [Case Files](#). | Organization | External reactive pressure during a Case File, tracked as a countdown row on the Operations Board. Uses O#M# shorthand for milestones. Examples: rival factions, law enforcement, local press, religious institutions, smuggling networks. An organization is not the artifact itself. See [Case Files](#).

== G

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Gear Dice | Black dice in the pool contributed by equipment. Each 1 rolled on a Gear die causes the item to degrade one step. See [Core Resolution](#). | General Talent | A talent available to any character regardless of Division, providing a mechanical exception or situational bonus. General Talents are chosen at character creation in place of a Division Talent or purchased later for 6 XP. The canonical list lives in [Advancement, Talents, and Dark Secrets](#).

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| Development Points (DP) | The shared resource the cell earns during Aftermath and spends on Headquarters facilities, personnel, and infrastructure upgrades. See [Headquarters](#). | Headquarters (HQ) | The Covenant facility serving as the team's base of operations between Case Files. Provides medical care, equipment requisition, research facilities, and downtime activities. See [Headquarters](#).

== I

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| Information Card | A playing-card-sized reference for a discoverable fact in a Case File, identified by an I# code (I1, I2, etc.). Lists where the information can be found (Locations), who knows it (NPCs), and when HQ can provide it as a fallback. Type is either Containment Truth or supporting intel. See [Case Files](#). | Insight | A permanent mechanical bonus gained from certain Critical Injuries, marked (Insight) in the injury name or effect. Represents a silver lining from trauma — heightened perception, empathy, or expertise. Cannot be removed. See [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

== L

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Location | A place the agents can go during a Case File. Each Location is the DA's primary reference during play — a form listing description, availability, NPCs present, information available, organizations present, positive/negative results, and milestone changes. See [Case Files](#).

== M

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Maximum Corruption Threshold | The point at which a character's mind permanently fractures: 10 + Empathy score. Exceeding this value retires the character. See [Corruption, Fear & Healing](#).

== N

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Named Threat | A significant antagonist in a Case File — a faction operative, corrupted NPC, or supernatural entity important enough to have a name, motivations, and stat block. See [Case Files](#). | NPC Card | A playing-card-sized reference for a significant person in a Case File. Carries organization affiliation (O#), secret, goal, artifact connection, starting knowledge (I# refs), gained knowledge (milestone-driven), locations, and positive/negative results. Contacts are NPC Cards, not standalone elements. See [Case Files](#).

== P

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Panic Table | A d6 table rolled on Fear check failure. Determines the character's involuntary response: Fight (1), Flight (2), Freeze (3), Denial (4), Compulsion (5), or Fugue (6). See [Corruption, Fear & Healing](#). | Shift Row | The top row of the Operations Board. Each day-column is quartered into Morning / Day / Evening / Night. Tracks time spent and relic escalation — relic milestones trigger when the DA fills a shift quadrant that crosses a milestone day. See [Case Files](#). | Push | Re-roll all non-6 dice after a roll fails to meet its Difficulty, or after a success when you want more successes. Costs +1 Corruption. Each roll may only be pushed once. Gear dice that show 1 on the push cause degradation. See [Core Resolution](#). | Psychoanalyze | A skill used to read psychological states, detect deception, stabilize distressed people during social scenes, and treat mental and emotional Critical Injuries. See [Social Conflict](#) and [Health, Damage & Armor](#).

== R

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Relic Milestones | Day-keyed events on the Operations Board's shift row that define what the anomaly does if it remains active, mishandled, or unresolved. When the DA fills a shift quadrant that crosses a relic milestone, the artifact event triggers. Distinct from organizations, which represent external reactive pressure. See [Case Files](#).

== S

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| Scene | An emergent intersection of Location, NPC, and Information entities during a Case File. A scene occurs when agents go to a location and the DA assembles the relevant NPC Cards and Information Cards. Scenes are not pre-authored event nodes. See [Case Files](#). | Shift | The core unit of operational time in a Case File. Each day contains 4 shifts of 6 hours each: Morning, Day, Evening, and Night. See [Case Files](#). | Skill Dice | Green dice in the pool, equal to the relevant Skill rating (0-5). See [Core Resolution](#). | Slow Action | One of three action types in combat. Represents a committed effort: attacking, using a skill, administering first aid, or reloading a weapon. See [Combat](#). | Stunt Points | Extra successes (6s) beyond the required Difficulty on a roll that allows stunt spending. In combat, they can be spent on special effects such as increased damage, disarming, or knockback. See [Combat](#).

== T

[cols="1,3", frame=none, grid=rows, stripes=none]

| The Verdant Covenant | The ancient secret society the player characters serve. Discovers, recovers, and contains supernatural artifacts to protect humanity. Organized into three operational Divisions (Wayfinder, Recovery, The Keep). Stack (Logistics) is a department within The Keep. See [The Verdant Covenant](#).

== V

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| Verdant Codex | Wayfinder Division Item. An enchanted field journal that secures memory, assists with language and symbol work, highlights likely historical correlations, and preserves documents. See [Divisions](#). | Verdant Satchel | Recovery Division Item. A specially enchanted field bag that masks minor artifact signatures, stabilizes transport, warns of instability, and keeps basic field tools ready. See [Divisions](#).


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| Warden's Bracer | Keep Division Item. Dampens nearby emissions during handling, warns of containment failure, enables safer handling of cursed objects, absorbs 1 Corruption per session, and grants +1 Armor Rating. See [Divisions](#).

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| Zone | An abstract area of space used for combat positioning — a room, corridor, alley, or rooftop section. Moving one zone costs a Fast Action; moving two zones (running) costs both the Fast and Slow Action for the round. See [Combat](#).

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[#appendix-combat] = Appendix: Advanced Combat Rules
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This appendix collects situational combat rules that most sessions will not use. The core combat loop — zones, actions, initiative, conditions, and Broken — is in [Ch 5 — Combat](#). The rules here cover ammunition tracking, full automatic fire, chases, vehicle combat, and large-group (mob) combat.

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== Ammunition Tracking
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Ammunition is tracked using a Resource Die. When you acquire a weapon or reload, set its ammo die based on the weapon type and current magazine state:

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| Ammo State | Die | Notes

| Pistol — full magazine | d10 | 9mm, .38, .45; standard load | Shotgun — full load | d8 | Pump or semi-auto shotgun | Rifle — full magazine | d8 | Assault rifle, battle rifle, .308 | Half loaded (any) | d6 | Partially used magazine | Low / scrounged (any) | d4 | Found ammo, emergency reload | Drum / extended mag | d12 | Special acquisition (CL 4)

> **Two-track ammo system:** This table governs in-combat per-shot tracking — roll when you push a Firearms roll, fire full auto, or the DA calls for it. Between scenes, use the Supply-level Resource Dice in [Equipment](#) to track how much ammo the team has on hand. When you reload in the field, roll the supply die; then reset the weapon's combat ammo die to its 'full' value from this table.

When do you roll the ammo die?

* After every turn in which you fire (standard fire — the die represents the resource pressure of sustained combat). * After pushing a Firearms roll — roll an additional time (you burned through extra rounds). * After a full auto burst — roll twice (see Full Auto below). * At the DA's discretion when dramatically appropriate (ambush, very long firefight).

Rolling the ammo die:

* Roll the current die. On a 1 or 2, step the die down one size (d8 d6 d4 empty). * On empty (die was d4 and rolled 1-2): weapon is dry. Reload costs a Slow Action.

=== Full Auto

Weapons capable of fully automatic fire (noted in the Equipment tables) may fire a full auto burst on a Slow Action instead of a standard shot.

* **Effect:** Make two separate attack rolls against the same target (or split between two targets in the same zone). Resolve each roll independently — each can hit, miss, or generate stunt points. * **Ammo:** Roll the ammo die twice after a full auto burst (once per attack). * **Penalty:** After firing full auto, the firing character suffers -1 die on all Firearms rolls until the start of their next turn (recoil and muzzle rise). * **When in doubt:** If the Equipment tables do not specify a weapon as full auto, it fires semi-auto only.

== Chase and Pursuit

When one side is fleeing and the other is pursuing, use the following chase rules.

=== Chase Structure

A chase is divided into chase rounds. Each round, both the fleeing and pursuing party roll their relevant attribute + skill:

* **On foot:** Agility + Sneak (for stealth flight) or Agility + Endure (for pure sprint) * **By vehicle:** Wits + Tech (see [\[vehicle-chase-rules\]](#) for full vehicle chase procedure, speed modifiers, and maneuvers)

> **DA discretion on skill choice:** These are default options. The DA may call for other skills when the context demands it — a chase through a crowded market could use Manipulate (EMP) to slip through a crowd; a chase through a building's maintenance passages could use Investigate (WIT). The DA should always tell the players which skill they're calling before the roll.

=== Chase Outcome Per Round

* Compare successes. The side with more successes gains distance (fleeing) or closes distance (pursuing).

| Position | State

| 1 | Rammed / Contact — vehicles are adjacent; ramming and boarding are possible. | 2 | Following — pursuing vehicle is directly behind; gunfire from rear positions is possible. | 3 | Closing — pursuit is active; the gap is narrowing or holding. | 4 | Widening — the pursued vehicle has gained distance; gunfire at Long range only. | 5 | Escaped — the pursuer has lost visual contact. Chase ends.

The pursued vehicle wins by moving to position 5. The pursuing vehicle wins by moving to or holding position 1-2.

=== Chase Roll

Each round of a chase, both drivers make a roll:

* Tech (WIT): The primary chase skill. Represents reading traffic, anticipating routes, and making calculated maneuvers with vehicles under pressure. Use this for all standard chase rolls. * Tech (AGI): Used when attempting sudden unpredictable movement — cutting through a building site, reversing against traffic, going off-road. Higher risk, higher reward. The DA may call for AGI + Tech instead of WIT + Tech when a maneuver is more reflexive than tactical.

Both sides roll simultaneously. The side with more successes moves the Contact Track one position in their favor. Ties: no position change.

Speed modifiers:

* Each speed tier above the opponent's: +1 die on the chase roll. * Each speed tier below the opponent's: -1 die on the chase roll. * Handling bonus/penalty applies directly to the roll.

Pushing a chase roll: +1 Corruption as normal. The vehicle also takes 1 Wear immediately (the driver is wringing everything out of it).

=== Vehicle Maneuvers

Declare before rolling. No cost unless noted.

[%header,cols="1,2,3"]

| Maneuver | Skill | Effect

| Ram | Force (STR) | Only available at Contact. Roll Force (STR) opposed by opponent's Tech (WIT). On success: both vehicles take 1-3 damage (equal to Force successes); Contact Track does not change; occupants of both vehicles take 1 Agility damage (thrown around). Cannot ram a vehicle more than two speed tiers faster. | PIT Maneuver | Tech (WIT) Difficulty 3 | Available at Contact only. On success: target vehicle spins — they lose their next action and the pursuer moves to Contact. On failure: the maneuvering driver's vehicle takes 1 Wear. | Gunfire from Vehicle | Firearms (standard roll) | Available at Following or closer. -1 die on all shooting rolls from a moving vehicle unless the shooter has the Stable Platform talent. A passenger shooting from a moving car is at -1 die; a driver shooting is at -2 dice. | Off-Road Break | Tech (AGI) Difficulty 2

| Drive off the paved route. On success: move one position on the Contact Track toward Escaped. On failure: vehicle takes 1 Wear and no position change. If in a vehicle with off-road penalty (Motorcycle in rain, Van, Helicopter equivalent): add +1 Difficulty. | Blending In | Sneak (WIT) Difficulty 2 | Abandon the direct chase and disappear into traffic or terrain. On success: move directly to Escaped (skip the track). On failure: no change and opponent moves one step toward Contact.

== Vehicle Damage

When a vehicle takes damage (from ramming, gunfire, or environmental hazard):

. Roll damage as normal. Subtract the vehicle's AR. . Remaining damage is applied as Wear (not as Strength damage to occupants, unless the damage is extraordinary). . At 5 Wear: vehicle stops. Characters inside may take 1 Agility damage from the sudden stop (Endure Difficulty 1 to avoid). . Structural damage: At DA discretion, a catastrophic hit (4+ damage after AR) may cause a specific system failure: blown tire (-2 die Handling), cracked windscreen (blindness penalties for driver), fuel leak (vehicle stops at end of scene unless repaired).

Repairing Wear:

* Tech roll (Difficulty 2) + 30 minutes + access to tools: clear 1 Wear. * Full garage repairs (overnight, proper tools): restore to starting Reliability. * Field repairs without tools: Tech Difficulty 4, clears 1 Wear, cannot reduce below 3.

=== Vehicle Breakdown

When Reliability reaches 5 Wear, the vehicle stops. Roll d6:

[%header,cols="^1,4"]

| Roll | Breakdown Type

| 1-2 | Total Failure. Engine seized. Not repairable in the field. Needs a tow and a full day of garage work (restore to 2 Wear, 4 hours minimum). | 3-4 | Serious Fault. Driveable at Slow speed only. Tech (Difficulty 3) to clear in field; otherwise full garage repair. | 5-6 | Inconvenient Failure. Battery, tire, or small component. Tech (Difficulty 1) to address in 15 minutes. 1 Wear remains after fix.

A breakdown during an active chase is resolved immediately: the broken-down vehicle is treated as Contact on the next round (the pursuer closes automatically).

== Group Combat (Multiple NPCs)

When 3 or more combatants on the NPC side share a common purpose and act together, they may be treated as a mob.

=== Mob Rules

* A mob draws one Initiative card and acts as a single entity on that card. * A mob has a shared Strength pool equal to 3 per member (e.g., a 4-person mob has Strength 12). Maximum mob Strength is 15 regardless of size. * A mob attacks as one unit: roll dice pool equal to the best individual's dice pool plus bonus dice equal to the number of additional members (beyond the first), maximum +3 bonus dice total. * Damage to a mob: Any attack that deals Strength damage reduces the mob's shared pool. When the mob Strength pool reaches 0, the mob is broken — all members are Broken or fleeing. The DA may narrate intermediate casualties at thresholds (e.g., one member falls at Strength 6, another at Strength 3). * Splitting a mob: Area effects (full auto burst, explosive, fire) or AoE-capable stunts can split a mob into two smaller groups. The DA distributes remaining Strength between them.

> Mobs represent low-tier hostiles (cultist grunts, security guards, Compact foot soldiers). Named or significant NPCs always act individually with their own initiative and stat blocks.

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[appendix] == Year Zero Engine Free Tabletop License

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Year Zero Engine Free Tabletop License (version 1.0)

Fria Ligan AB ("Free League") has created the attached Year Zero Engine System Reference Document ("YZE SRD").

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